Successful Harvard Essays

Harvard College · Harvard Business School · Harvard Law School

60 essays with professional reviews, 2018–2025

Collected from The Harvard Crimson
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Successful Harvard College Essays (2025)

10 essays

Claire's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/10-successful-harvard-essays-2025
Essay #: 1

Essay

In my vision I focus on a lone front tooth backdropped by a black abyss; thin lips dance around it in motions forming words, yet I can't seem to hear them.

In the kitchen behind my grandfather sits his definition of luxury — a now stale and cold Filet-o-Fish from the Beijing McDonald's. American basketball plays on the television across from where we're sitting on the sofa; players' shoes squeak and balls bounce louder in my ears than those words. In this moment, his Mandarin goes in one ear and out the other. I don't listen the way I do when he's screaming at my mother, a bitter, blind rage fueled by undercurrents of fear and "I miss you."

My focus blurs, and the tooth disappears. Basketball fades to silence, and I'm on the airplane home to America. We're separated once more by an ocean and three thousand unspoken miles. It's a whirlwind; five years pass, and my few apathetic summers in China are over before I can blink twice.

The last clear memory I have is waking up on my thirteenth birthday to my dad handing me the landline kept for international phone calls: "Waigong has something he wants to read to you."

It is a poem that he had written about me. Through the phone, I could do nothing but hear his voice, static worsening the Mandarin already slurred by missing teeth. The poem says everything he loved about his granddaughter, everything he saw in her, despite barely knowing her. It is a reflection of last dreams, visions, and hopes of his own.

He was gone not long after that, once more turned to forever.

It wasn't until I found myself chancely entrenched in poetry because of a mandatory school competition that I began to think deeply about this disconnected relationship. Poetry Out Loud's anthology introduced me to hundreds and hundreds of poems, and I felt like a hungry child at a buffet. When I discovered "Old Men Playing Basketball" by B.H. Fairchild, I saw tired arms and shaky hands as a pure geometry of curves, hobbling slippers as the adamant remains of that old soft shoe of desire. In words, I was safe to miss my grandfather for all the things that made him human. For the first time in my life,

I began to realize that I might have a love for beautiful words that ran deep in my blood, a love that couldn't be lost in translation.

On that makeshift podium in the school cafeteria my sophomore year, "Old Men Playing Basketball" becomes "Waigong Playing Basketball." I'm taken back to that sofa in Beijing one more time, where he takes my small hand into his tremoring one covered by gray-brown patches of melasma, where he tells me, "You are a gift, a wonder. You are a hu die." Butterfly: my Chinese name. Born to one day fly.

But it is no longer his voice I hear. It is my own— crisp and clear, raw and strong. The poem becomes the glass wand of autumn light breaking over the backboard, where boys rise up in old men. I see the whole scene this time, not just tooth and abyss. I hear every word.

Perhaps I will never be able to know my grandfather beyond his love of basketball and poetry, or hear his voice read me another poem. But when I am stirred by beautiful lines or liberated by my pen on paper, I know I am one of two same hearts, forever bound together by the permanence and power of language.

I am a vessel in flight, listening, writing, speaking to remember histories, to feel emotion, to carry forth dreams and visions and hopes of my own. My grandfather becomes an elegant mirage of a basketball player, carried by a quiet grace along my trail of spoken words floating upwards toward heaven.

Professional Review by The Ivy Institute

Some essays tell you who someone is. Clara's shows you how she became that person.

What makes Fish Out of Water stand out isn't just the fish-to-freshman metaphor or her stories that connect immigration and biology — two themes admissions officers encounter often — but how she makes those familiar ideas feel personal. It's how at ease she is in describing discomfort and how she captures the awkwardness and isolation of language barriers with honesty. A less thoughtful writer might have simply said, "It was hard learning English." Clara, however, shows us how, using creative humor to poke fun at herself while revealing her unique skills, flaws, and strengths through SpongeBob reruns, word-play, and a fascination with labeled diagrams. This is exactly what admissions officers want to see: the maturity to reflect in a way that brings the story vividly to life beyond the screen.

She doesn't just talk about resilience — she shows us where it came from, and how art and science became a way to make sense of things. Her writing is vivid without being

overdone, and metaphors like “language feels slippery like fish on my tongue” feel true because they come from lived experience. By the end, when she writes “You’ll find your water,” it lands. It’s not just a neat ending — it’s a reminder, quiet and generous, that growth doesn’t have to be loud to be real.

Alexander's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/10-successful-harvard-essays-2025
Essay #: 2

Essay

The mouthwatering scent of beef broth brought back a flood of childhood memories as it wafted around me. After a 12-hour drive from Florida to Texas, the familiar smell meant I was in ""bep cua bà"", or ""grandma's kitchen"" in Vietnamese. Every summer when my family visited my grandparents' house, my grandma always had a steaming pot of pho ready for us when we arrived, and this time was no exception. For my family, pho was more than a Vietnamese delicacy: it symbolized bringing us together over a warm, hearty meal. This specific visit, however, came with a change of perspective; as a young adult who was now conscious of his cultural roots, I wanted to learn more about my heritage by learning how to cook pho from my grandma.

As she boiled the water, my grandma stressed to me, ""Every bowl of pho needs a strong foundation: the broth."" Without a good broth, she explained, none of the other ingredients mattered. As I stood over the boiling pot, I thought about my own foundation: my family. My parents immigrated to America after the Vietnam War with nothing and had to work tirelessly to accomplish the celebrated ""American Dream"". From taking me to a 7 am student government fundraiser or a 10 pm baseball game in a city five hours away, I would not have been able to participate in these activities, which I consider an integral part of my identity, without their support. Being fortunate enough to have a strong foundation in my life has allowed me to be a strong foundation for others. For example, as an upperclassman on my varsity baseball team, I strive to be available for my teammates. Last season, when a younger teammate was struggling in a few games, I stayed back after practice to work with him on his fielding before driving him home, even though he lived almost an hour away. This small gesture was a reflection of my attempt to build a strong foundation for others.

As I watched the broth simmer in a giant pot that my grandma had continuously stirred for two days, she imparted another bit of wisdom onto me: making a great bowl of pho was also all about balance. Simply taking a great broth and indiscriminately adding to it would not suffice; each of the ingredients had to be in perfect balance with each other. Balance was never really something I considered until recently, when I experienced the

struggle that can come from its absence. When I suffered a stress fracture in my lower back a few years ago that left me unable to play baseball for the foreseeable future, I felt as if suddenly a major part of my identity had been stripped away. I struggled with this new reality for a while until I realized I could fill this temporary void by acting as a mentor for my younger teammates. Additionally, with my newfound spare time, I was able to further develop my interest in Mu Alpha Theta, which gave me a new, enriching opportunity to compete in mathematics competitions. By the time I was finally cleared to play, I had developed a fresh appreciation for the importance of maintaining a balance among all the activities I did, as I had experienced firsthand the empty feeling of having this balance stripped away.

While putting the finishing scallions in the bowl, I reflected on the delectable meal I helped create and realized that what had started out as me simply wanting to learn more about my heritage became something more poignant: an introspection. Although there may not be a single perfect recipe for pho, by applying my grandma's cooking principles in my everyday life, whether it be in baseball, my volunteer lab experience, or my service trip to Guatemala, I hope to be able to make a ""bowl of pho"" that is perfect for me.

Professional Review by HS2 Academy

Alexander’s essay is a thoughtful and emotionally resonant reflection on identity, family, and personal growth. By using the preparation of pho as a central metaphor, he artfully connects his Vietnamese heritage with broader themes of foundation, balance, and resilience. The imagery of bếp của bà (grandma’s kitchen) adds warmth and specificity, grounding the narrative in meaningful cultural context.What stands out most is Alexander’s ability to translate personal experiences into universal insight. His response to adversity—mentoring a teammate and rediscovering his passion for mathematics after a sports injury—demonstrates quiet leadership and adaptability. These moments are authentic and show his values in action.The structure, moving from broth to balance to introspection, is coherent and thematically rich. However, some transitions could be smoother, and a few phrases are slightly repetitive or abstract. The conclusion, while heartfelt, might leave a stronger impression if it ended with a more concrete personal image rather than a metaphor about the “perfect bowl.”Overall, this is a sincere and engaging personal statement that reflects depth and character. With minor revision for clarity and rhythm, Alexander’s essay is well-positioned to make a strong impact on admissions readers.

Barry's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/10-successful-harvard-essays-2025
Essay #: 3

Essay

I woke up one morning to the usual noise in the kitchen. “That plate of porridge is mine,” my brother yelled outrageously at my sister, “leave it or else I will beat you up.” Food scrambles and fights were order of the day in the family I was raised. The size of one’s meal would be determined by one’s age. You had to fight for food at times, or else hunger would eat you alive. Living with ten siblings in a polygamous family is not the definition of tranquility. However, I have learned more from this revolving door than I could have been taught in solitary silence. Beyond chaos, there is a whisper that teaches the benefits of unselfish concern.

My mother was a teacher, but her salary could not sustain the big family. Almost every day, she would wake up early in the morning before work and go to the fields. My parents were shadowy figures whose voices I heard vaguely in the morning when sleep was shallow, and whom I glimpsed with irresistibly heavy eye-lids as they trudged wearily into the house at night. We sat together as a whole family on special occasions. After a bumper harvest, my parents would sell their crops in the neighborhood. I vividly remember my mother counting proceeds from the crop sale, her dark face grim, and I think now, beautiful. Not with the hollow beauty of well-simulated features, but with a strong radiance of one who has suffered and never yielded. “This is for your school fees arrears,” she would murmur making a little pile. “This is for the groceries that we borrowed from Mr Kibe’s store,” and so on. The list was endless. We would survive at least for the present.

My father instilled in me the importance of education. I would see the value of education every time I shook hands with him; the scratches and calluses from the field in his hands were enough motivation. After every award I received, he would firmly shake my hands as a sign of profound pride. My tacit prayer was to ease his pain one day. Unfortunately this was never to come true, he died on 5 February 2016 in a car accident, only a week before I received my IGCSE O LEVEL results and I had attained 14 straight A grades, standing out to be one of the top performers in the country. After my father’s death, his brothers took everything that he had acquired.

Inevitably, circumstances forced me to take a break from school in January 2017 and bear my share of the eternal burden at home. I had to take care of my mother whose health was deteriorating. I would spend the day doing household chores, and the nights were times of intensive study. It was on my mother's deathbed when I was fully convinced that she was a seasoned fighter. "Barry," she called me, "I am not going to die till you finish school." In order not to disillusion that extraordinary faith in her voice, I assured her that she was going to live. Unfortunately, she succumbed to death on the 15th of March 2017. I "died" with her. My belief in the God she had ardently prayed to till the time of her demise was shaken.

Already laid waste by poverty and pain, I went back to school through the generosity of strangers. School became a battleground for victory. I came back to life determined than ever before. I out-performed the country boys who mocked my struggle. I went on to win accolades in the National and Regional Mathematics Olympiads and was awarded the Higher Life Foundation Scholarship that was going to pay my fees throughout high school.

Today, I am an epitome of a black, double-orphaned, African boy who lost everything he ever valued, but refused to give up on his dream.

Professional Review by HelloCollege

A casual reader of Barry's essay about growing up in a chaotic dozen-or-so-person African household might mistakenly think it is poorly written. It does, after all, bear several hallmarks of an undercooked draft: non-idiomatic constructions like "my brother yelled outrageously," rather than "yelled in outrage;" or the seemingly un-overlookable blue squiggle that Google Docs inserts beneath "I came back to life determined than ever before," prodding its author to insert an elided more.

But such accusations fail to note the piece's tremendous strengths: its eagle-eyed specificity, its emotional nuance, its poet's facility with a resonant turn of phrase. Most writers would conclude their opening paragraph a sentence earlier than Barry does, content to have neatly stated that "I have learned more from this [busy household] than I could have been taught in solitary silence" — a tidy summation of the essay's topic — but Barry knows that the best persuasive writing employs this sort of clarity as a foundation on which to erect constructions that affect the reader in ways simple statements of fact cannot. Reading the grace note sentence with which Barry follows the thesis above ("Beyond chaos, there is a whisper that teaches the benefits of unselfish concern."), I was

immediately sold. The wise whisper that emerges from the scrum of Barry's domestic life may well be, we're left suspecting, Barry's own.

Happily, the rest of Barry's essay is at least as effective as its opening. Whether he's delivering the news of his father's passing with a measured understatement that communicates sadness more loudly than the most piercing funeral wail or pausing in an aside to note the beauty of his mother's face as she mundanely tallies household expenses, we inhabit Barry's mind as we read, feeling his presence throughout — his intellectual fingerprints unmistakeable, even on the digital page.

Claire's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/10-successful-harvard-essays-2025
Essay #: 4

Essay

Of the memorable moments in my life when I have discovered one of my passions, almost all of them involve my bright yellow Crocs. Buying rubber shoes in such a conspicuous color was not a spontaneous decision; it took me two months to choose. I had been stalking crocs.com, clicking between the color options, and asking for the unsatisfying opinions of friends before what felt like my rom-com “meet cute” moment: a girl wearing a black tracksuit walked past me in Crocs the brightest shade of yellow I had ever seen. That very week, I opened my laptop and decisively purchased a size 8 pair of “Lemon” Crocs. Ten business days (and two months to build up the courage to wear my eye-catching kicks out in public) later, my self-discovery began.

I was wearing my Crocs when I recognized the importance of activism in young communities. This revelation came on a Saturday in March 2018. I took a 25-minute train ride down to Washington D.C. to participate in the March for Our Lives rally—my first protest. For all 25 anxiety-inducing minutes, my heart raced and my muscles tightened as I tried to ignore the probing stares from strangers wondering why I decided to pair yellow shoes with a green coat.

But my fears (both Croc and non-Croc related) quickly dissolved as I stood alongside activists that were my age; in front of a stage dominated by leaders that were my age; making me realize that the only thing stopping me from being a student activist, at my age, was effort. The young voices calling for change inspired me to step into my responsibility to use my voice to help those whose voices are being suppressed. I stood there for one hour, but what I saw was enough to encourage me to actualize my vision for a world where students are driven to engender social change through service. So, five months later, I co-founded The Virago Project (TVP), a student-led organization focused on building a community of activists like the ones I stood alongside in March. A “virago” is a woman displaying exemplary qualities, but the term has been twisted to demean assertive women. From its name to its activities, TVP is about redefining leadership.

After my day in D.C., I wore my Crocs to every student meeting TVP held. I wore them as we sold 150 handmade bracelets to raise funds for a local children’s home and again when

we posted colorful cards with encouraging messages all over my high school. Walking into rooms full of ambitious student leaders using TVP as a jumping-off point for their own service projects, I beamed as their gaze met my sunny shoes and then shot up to my equally cheery smile.

“Dunni, why do you wear such noticeable shoes when you lead these meetings?” asked one of our activists.

Pleasantly dumbfounded, I could only respond with a curious smile—it’s not often that frivolous items lead to unintentionally philosophical inquiries. So, I held my tongue until the answer struck on a late-night in November 2019.

I wear such noticeable shoes when I stand in front of other student leaders because I want to model the kind of leadership that is as smile-inducing, deliberate, and visible as my Crocs. TVP has trained me to be, above all, altruistic, and I love that I get to learn and model this with a generation of world changers. It took me two months to decide I wanted a pair of sun-colored shoes but only two seconds and a model to realize that I desired the option I’d once overlooked. Now, I realize that, to curious strangers, I am the girl walking past in Crocs the brightest shade of yellow they have ever seen. And I am delighted with the thought that I could be the one to break someone’s cycle of indecision and social apathy.

Professional Review by Momentum College Consulting

This essay is a masterclass in narrative authenticity and intentional storytelling—two traits that are hallmarks of the most compelling college applications. With a confident yet conversational tone, the writer uses a symbol as unexpected as bright yellow Crocs to introduce deeper themes of identity, leadership, and social impact. What begins as a seemingly light anecdote becomes a powerful meditation on visibility, voice, and purpose.

What distinguishes this piece is its ability to connect the personal to the political without sounding forced or formulaic. The author doesn't just recount her activism—she illustrates how that moment catalyzed a philosophy of leadership that is joyful, inclusive, and self-aware. The Virago Project isn’t presented as a resume entry; it’s the natural outgrowth of her lived experience, brought to life through vibrant imagery and self-reflection.

It’s important to remember that admissions officers may have read 50 essays before yours on any given day. They are reading for something that feels fresh, specific, and emotionally alive. This essay succeeds because it hooks the reader early, sustains interest

through engaging pacing and humor, and subtly weaves in elite attributes: initiative, social awareness, and emotional intelligence.

At Momentum College Counseling, we emphasize that students don't need grand, world-changing moments to write memorable essays—they need clarity, introspection, and a compelling lens. This essay delivers on all three. It's vulnerable without being sentimental, ambitious without being performative. Most importantly, it captures a student with the courage to be visible, in yellow Crocs or otherwise—and that kind of confident originality is exactly what resonates in admissions rooms at schools like Harvard.

Isabelle's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/10-successful-harvard-essays-2025
Essay #: 5

Essay

Breakfast after church is a Sunday staple in my family. We're not allowed to eat beforehand, so right after Mass ends, my sister and I race to the bagel shop only to inevitably wait in a long line. Often when we reached the cashier, we'd find they were out of plain bagels. It was a perennially difficult decision: pick from an assortment of non-plain bagels, or wait another 20 minutes for new plain bagels.

People's bagel choices tell you everything about them, and I was a plain bagel girl through and through. Even when faced with 20 extra minutes of hunger, I decided to leave the sweet bagels for the adventurous, the savory for the straightforward, and the "everything" for the indecisive. I came for plain bagels, and I would get them, no matter the wait.

After a long wait, the warmth of the freshly-baked plain bagels radiating through the paper bag assured me my patience was worth it. Being a plain bagel girl means knowing exactly what you want—no more, no less. It means that I'm in control of my decision-making and always end up satisfied.

In senior year, my teacher graciously brought bagels to our class. Upon approaching the bag, however, I found there were no plain bagels left. Instinctively, I retreated. But my teacher stopped me and advised that I break from my comfort zone. Reluctantly, I chose an egg bagel, preferring its odd yellow shade to the surrounding sweeter variety (who wants a french toast bagel anyway?). My first bite introduced me to a new world: this sweet and savory egg bagel flawlessly balanced the worlds of the adventurous and the straightforward.

My willingness to try an egg bagel didn't lead to a phase of food experimentation, but it did make me see that I could be more spontaneous than my plain bagel self might allow.

Before high school, you could never spot me on a dance floor; I much preferred to watch from the audience. But in my freshman year, I joined the dance department of my school's annual production of S!NG on a whim.

As soon as I tried the first move, I knew the decision was worth it. I enjoyed diligently practicing routines and adding my own flair, satisfying my tendency to prepare

thoroughly while also fulfilling my desire to explore the realm of dance. Eventually, I excelled so much that the directors chose me as their successor—a position that has strengthened me as a dancer, leader, and person. Though I relished my newfound sense of spontaneity, my plain bagel girl roots helped me to effectively manage others' dancing. I tirelessly choreographed and re-choreographed each step and count of a routine, no matter how long the detailed revisions took. During practices, I analyzed the dancers' movements and refined them to what could only be described as plain bagel perfection.

Sometimes the moments when I thought I needed to be in control to be successful were when I needed to be more spontaneous. In my first year being director, I was unfamiliar with managing a multitude of variously skilled dancers. Shedding my fear of being an inexperienced leader was difficult, but I soon learned to open myself to others' advice about describing moves and maintaining the beat. Together, through sometimes spontaneous practice sessions and spurts of inspiration, we worked to adapt the choreography to accomodate all dancers.

I revel in the contradiction that is my simultaneous meticulousness and spontaneity: my egg bagel epiphany. I can count on myself to prepare thoroughly to optimize my potential, no matter how long it takes. But I can also trust myself to make the most of the unknown and stay true to myself while doing so. It's what makes me multidimensional; it makes me a young woman no longer defined by her bagel choices but rather by her versatility and what she can do with it.

Professional Review by Dan Lichterman

As an admission essay counselor, I regularly advise candidates that the best personal statements combine unexpected creative choices with an uncommon self-awareness. Isabelle's essay perfectly encapsulates this approach in a single line: "People's bagel choices tell you everything about them, and I was a plain bagel girl through and through."

The playfulness of distilling character into bagel preference invites readers to better understand Isabelle's attraction to consistency and control. Only when a flawless egg bagel challenges her "plain bagel" nature does Isabelle re-evaluate the costs of eschewing spontaneity. Joining her school's dance production on a whim, she uncovers invigorating new ways to work with, and against, routine. When she is eventually named program director, she draws upon her plain bagel epiphany to balance perfectionist tendencies with the adaptability true leadership demands.

Isabelle's story demonstrates an evolving self-knowledge that will serve her ambitions well. She writes with verve, unearthing hidden meaning within the mundane. "I decided to leave the sweet bagels for the adventurous, the savory for the straightforward, and the "everything" for the indecisive." How she unpacks this meaning feels truly personal, bringing a multidimensionality to her candidacy that could never be captured by grades, test scores, and extracurriculars alone.

Olivia's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/10-successful-harvard-essays-2025
Essay #: 6

Essay

When I was little my grandfather taught me the German word Waldeinsamkeit, the feeling of being truly alone in a deep forest. “Forests are special in Germany,” he explained. “In Florida…it’s swamps,” pointing to the brackish pond behind his house.

Back then, I knew only that he was a scientist, and that my mom’s forehead furrowed when he was mentioned. It was years before I saw him again, and many more years before I learned that, despite the silence of forests and families, no one is truly alone.

I always felt that science was in my blood. In 8th grade, I attended the Summer Science and Engineering Program at Smith College. I left hoping to study Chemistry--that was what my grandfather had taught.

So in high school, I emailed dozens of labs…and received one positive response, from a plant lab. Plants? They didn’t move or talk; they’re boring, I thought. And I had accidentally killed every plant I’d touched--including a fake one I’d dropped. But Dr. Yanofsky encouraged me. He also taught me that most of what I’d assumed about plants was wrong.

New research suggests injured Douglas firs send distress signals to nearby pines through a series of mycorrhizae, a fungi which acts like a plant internet. In other words, trees “talk” to each other and are “friends” during hard times--they help injured trees by sharing resources. If we listen at the right frequency, we can literally hear forests communicating.

In Dr. Yanofsky’s labs, I began using CRISPR-Cas9 to explore two genes in Arabidopsis thaliana. It took years, but my engineered plants produced nearly three times the fruit of the wildtype average, with clear applications toward world hunger. I entered my project in the Greater San Diego Science and Engineering Fair (GSDSEF), where I won First Place and Sweepstakes, sending me to the International Science and Engineering Fair (ISEF), where I became a Finalist.

The next year, I took these principles to the Garcia Scholars program at Stony Brook University to study nanotoxicity. I’ve learned that people across the globe speak a

universal language of science, including bad puns. I've also learned that everyone had a mentor.

That's why I helped launch the Student Leadership Board of GSDSEF. Traveling to dozens of schools, leading monthly Saturday workshops, I saw classrooms without science equipment. I met kids whose parents couldn't afford even modest science fair entry fees.

So I created Science Fair Buddies, a mentoring program at a middle school where most students receive free lunch. I persuaded a local company to provide financial support, and recruited science fair alumni as mentors. We hold workshops when late buses are available. I've learned to look and listen in ways I hadn't before. "Will there be snacks?" often means "I haven't had a meal today." Kids make formal presentations in t-shirts because that's their only shirt. Seats for parents at award ceremonies are often empty. Taylor, a 5th grader with orange hair, comes with her grandfather; he's her primary caretaker. Many kids seem to be their own caretakers.

In the last year, in an awkward conversation, I learned my own mother was one of these kids. I learned my grandfather was an alcoholic. That she spent afternoons stranded at bus stops. That he once ran over her dog. That he broke down a neighbor's door to drag her back home. That the swampy pond behind her house was her designated meeting spot for friends to comfort her.

Last year, we traveled across the country to bring him home to live with us. He was alone, and suffering from progressive dementia. Some days he speaks nonsense, asking for "blue noses" for lunch. But yesterday he said his hobby was "finding truth where it may not always be obvious."

Forests may be peaceful, but they're not lonely, or even silent. Trees—and people—are always sharing resources in ways that remind us we're never truly alone.

Professional Review by Hamilton Education

Over the years we've had hundreds of acceptances to Harvard, Stanford, MIT, etc. In our experience, all successful Ivy-level essays demonstrate at least two of three vital things– Impact, Insight, and Identity. Olivia's essay powerfully explores the first two: Impact and Insight.

After athletic recruits and donors, identity-driven elements play a key role in Ivy-level admissions. If your identity is likely to contribute to the diversity of an Ivy-level campus, embrace and explore it. But what if–at least in the eyes of admissions readers–your identity isn't helpful? What if you are a "basic white girl?"

That's how Olivia described herself when I first met her as an 8th-grader, back when teenagers aspired to be "extra" rather than "basic." Her brother had found a pathway to MIT and Princeton through math competitions. But Olivia wasn't a MOSP-level contender, so she would need to find another way to show Impact.

Too young to work in animal labs, in the 9th grade she wrangled her way into a plant lab. Her work there led to meaningful discoveries–and eventually to the International Science and Engineering Fair (ISEF). She also created significant outreach programs to share her love of science. That's Impact.

But without Insight–an ef ort to explain the larger social and personal significance–a student's Impact is merely a resume. As an editor, my job–and that of the many talented Editing Partners at Hamilton Education–is to help students find that Insight. In Olivia's case, I sent her a book called The Hidden Life of Trees, and had Olivia free-write extensively about her life and family. But it was actually her mother who contributed the final piece–a hidden aspect of her family that endowed the technical things Olivia had done with greater meaning and purpose.

Years ago I taught Literature and Narrative Theory at UCLA, and after that I served as Editorial Director of a food-and-wine magazine. As a professional editor, my job wasn't to give writers bigger or better words, but rather to help sell the story. At Hamilton Education, we like to start early–as early as 8th grade–so that we can help students build the right kind of resume. But we are not merely advisors–we are professional editors: we help students identify what their real story is, and how they can best tell it–so that universities like Harvard simply must say "Yes."

By the time Olivia graduated high school, I was hearing the word"basic" less frequently. But since Olivia gained admission to Harvard, Princeton, Stanford and other top universities, she apparently showed Ivy-level schools something "extra" about her.

Jinna's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/10-successful-harvard-essays-2025
Essay #: 7

Essay

It’s terrifying how much we can get from Amazon nowadays: groceries, clothes, books, and crises of faith are all just a click away.

After Audible thanked me for listening to The Most Dangerous Branch: Inside the Supreme Court's Assault on the Constitution by David Kaplan and The Brethren by Bob Woodward and Scott Armstrong, I wanted to cry, scream, and march to Washington to shake answers from Chief Justice John Roberts.

My emotional whirlwind burst from the dichotomy between reality and my expectation of it. Growing up, I knew the judicial branch as the apolitical arbiter of constitutional law and the bias-blind defender of civil rights. With fear across the nation rising as fast as the global temperature, I was sure the best way to change the failing status quo was through the courts. I dreamed of becoming a lawyer to advocate for justice and to help my country prosper. My ambitions sprouted from the ideals of public service ingrained into me at school and at home, and my goal hinged only upon the judiciary’s mandate to protect our freedoms. My dream was purposeful and straightforward.

But 37 hours of audiobook rewrote all my beliefs in the judicial branch.

The Supreme Court: apolitical arbiter and bias-blind defender? No. Rather: potentially politicized, petty, proud, and irrational. Partisan politics dance about the Justices’ Conferences. The Constitution and personal biases govern rulings. Most rights supposedly afforded by the Constitution are interpretations, not explicit clauses, of it. For example, Chief Justice Warren Burger manipulated case assignments, so Justice Potter Stewart tattled on him to Woodward and Armstrong in retaliation. The right of the judiciary to strike down laws deemed unconstitutional is derived more from Marbury v. Madison than from Article Three. Justice Harry Blackmun based his majority opinion in Roe v. Wade on the rights of the doctor to practice. Stare decisis is optional, as is judicial restraint.

I felt sick. I had worshipped the courts as the perfect forum for change, always upholding truth, equality, and scholarship; I saw them as the eventual birthplace of solutions to gun

regulation, climate crises, gerrymandering, immigration, and social inequality. I did not want to acknowledge courts could be anything but perfect.

Desperation drove me to keep listening, but with every new case I covered, the clearer it became that I had worshipped an impossibility. After finishing Jeffrey Toobin's The Nine, I finally admitted that, prior to these books, I had known nothing. Perhaps that epiphany should have terrified me, but it did quite the opposite.

It was liberating.

Socrates once wrote that true knowledge was in knowing that you know nothing. I couldn't agree more: once you know you've hit wisdom rock bottom, you can be reckless with your curiosity because you only have everything to gain.

Since that epiphany, I have been gleefully chasing infinity. Even if my capacity to learn is finite, my curiosity is not. The history of the courts, the ethics of judicial restraint, the politics of judging, the rhetoric of opinions, the intersectionality of all of the above and more… there is so much to explore.

For the record: I purchased those audiobooks on a whim. I was not looking for anything more than a fascinating nonfiction read. But they have plunged me into an exhilarating, all-consuming, fully unpredictable adventure, one that stretches back to our nation's founding and far into our future. While these books initially upset me by revealing the imperfections of the judicial branch, they showed me a whole undiscovered history and future at my fingertips. Rather than smothering my dreams of public service, they fanned the flames; now, my dream of public service is fueled by my passion to serve and to learn.

And I'm ready to chase it.

Professional Review by InAmerica

Jinna's essay is a standout example of intellectual curiosity, personal reflection, and authentic voice. From the clever and engaging opening line to the thoughtful conclusion, Jinna skillfully takes the reader on a journey of discovery, disillusionment, and renewed purpose. The narrative is driven by a deep dive into the workings of the U.S. Supreme Court, showcasing not only their passion for justice but also their willingness to question long-held beliefs and grow from that discomfort.

What makes Jinna's piece particularly compelling is their ability to balance sophisticated ideas with accessible, heartfelt storytelling. The references to books like The Most Dangerous Branch and The Nine are used not to impress, but to demonstrate sincere

engagement with complex issues. Their voice is confident, occasionally humorous, and consistently reflective.

Jinna's essay also captures a meaningful transformation. Rather than clinging to idealism, they embrace complexity, demonstrating resilience, adaptability, and a hunger for learning—qualities that admissions committees value deeply. The final message, that disillusionment gave way to a deeper and more grounded passion for public service, is powerful and uplifting.

Altogether, this essay is a memorable, intellectually rich, and emotionally resonant piece that clearly reflects the maturity and promise of the writer.

Carrie's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/10-successful-harvard-essays-2025
Essay #: 8

Essay

I am a builder. No. I am a seasoned architect. My tools are foreign to the realities of others but mundane by my standards. I don't compose the perplexing and unique structures that most think of when the word architect is mentioned. Matter of fact, I don't make structures at all; my mastery is in the assembly of walls. Mental ones, to be exact. I am a skillful artist of intricately woven walls to create a complex maze for the others that try to get to know me; they are left confused, with no choice but to surrender their arbitrary efforts to "save" me.

I was unmatched in my array of skills. That was until I met Mark. Mark was a worker from my first mental hospital visits who had attached himself to my conscience before I could push him away as I had done with so many others. With an equally impressive skill set, he was able to navigate his way through my long-standing labyrinth to its center. That's where he found me. Still crouched next to my fledgling wall, dirt on my knees with dust on my face, I had finally been figured out for the first time in years. How did he get here? When did I let my guard down? The answers to these questions sat obnoxiously in front of me. The game that we always played. Horse. Such a benign game, that the thought of it having any significant part in my life is utterly incomprehensible. But it did, nonetheless.

Little did I know that Mark was studying to become a therapist in his studies of psychology, and I, his first patient. This is not a story of teenage love and life-changing heartbreak, but of one where an abandoned kid whose father raped her and whose mother gave up custody to have the father's perverted approval, finally gets the parental figure that she was never offered before. I was an emotional wreck at this time, not wanting to live, much less fight a court battle to get the "justice" everyone so badly wanted for me. So Mark, the father I never got to have, taught me how to swim in the never-ending circumstances I was drowning in. With every swish of the net of our game, a new way he would teach my fumbling feet to move in the water. And with every finished game, he was one wall closer to the reality behind my facade. He taught me that being angry at my circumstances would not fix them or get me any closer to overcoming them.

Nothing is going to change my mom's decision. Nothing is going to turn back time and change what my dad did. I can be the ruler of the lonely maze I created, or I can be surrounded by people who love and care for me. It wasn't easy destroying all the walls I had taken years to build and perfect, but it wasn't impossible either. This isn't a fairytale where Mark waved a magic wand and all was better and my walls disappeared from my mind. This is reality, and it took time, patience, and effort to unassemble my walls. Brick by painstaking brick. But in the actual world, people don't get happily ever after. Some of my walls are still there. And that's okay. I have learned to recognize my progress instead of singling out my flaws.

I am finally okay with not being perfect. My walls have chips and cracks, but I am content with their creation and their destruction. The destruction of familiarity is a beautiful thing. And so I climb out of the water, let the flowers bloom in the cracks of my walls, and walk off the court arm in arm with someone who sees me for who I am, not whom I pretend to be.

Professional Review by IvyWise

This essay demonstrates both narrative skill and emotional insight. The extended metaphor of building mental walls and creating a maze is skillfully woven into the essay and creates a complex yet accessible symbolism that captures the student's emotional struggles and her healing process. In choosing to write about this deeply traumatic experience, the student reveals courage, vulnerability, and resilience and gives the reader a glimpse into how it has impacted her life. At the same time, the student makes it clear that this experience doesn't define who she is. Remarkable honesty and maturity emerge through the student's reflection of how she has actively worked to confront this trauma and move beyond it; the student doesn't present herself as a victim in spite of the fact that she was. There is a sense of humility and strength that emerges at the end of the essay when the student recognizes that perfection isn't the goal, but that growth is. As a reader, you can't help but be drawn into the essay from the get-go; this compelling and nuanced writing speaks to the student's high level of self-awareness.

Janna's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/10-successful-harvard-essays-2025
Essay #: 9

Essay

I wake up in monochrome. Just past the tips of my toes, the Flatiron Building rises above the bustling black and white streets of New York. Cars hurtle by in blurred gray tones. I am a hawk or helicopter or hot air balloon, and I have somehow worked myself into the sky of an Old Hollywood movie. Of course, this only lasts as long as I keep my eyes locked on the IKEA photograph I hung up across from my bed a few years back.

Just before I turned fourteen, I burst out of IKEA—my all-time favorite store—dead set on crafting on a "new and improved" Helen. I rushed home, stripped my room, and launched my transformation. Out with the beaded golden comforter! Out with the floral rug! Out with the pastel prints of savanna animals!

Well, perhaps this is too dramatic. Items are rarely thrown out in the Krieger household, just put to another use. Gazelles and cheetahs now peer down at me from the hallway wall, and the floral carpet rests beneath the brass coffee table in the living room. As for the comforter, I still use the exact same one, just concealed by a stark white cover. Still, the meaning holds: I was ready to refocus. Life seemed to be accelerating and I was not going to sit by the roadside, watching the wheels kick up dust.

Back then, I did not know what I wanted to be, and I still do not know now. However, never has there been any doubt in my mind about what I want to be doing. I want to whiz from idea to idea, question to question, and all the while, learn as much as possible. In all its action of rushing cars, the IKEA photograph epitomizes this ambition. No billion-dollar skyscraper or jewelry store in New York could ever win me over. I am not after Gatsby's gilded highlife, but New York's dynamic—the city's perpetual drive.

When I open my eyes, however, I am just as likely to wake up in a vibrant forest of green as I am to rise in the midst of charcoal city streets. Plants flourish on either side of my headboard. Vines of English ivy cascade down my bookcase, and a sentry palm fans out in front of my closet doors. New York reigns over one wall, but the other three are governed by nature.

This contrast did not always exist. Apart from the occasional bouquet, the Krieger household was void of vegetation until my sophomore year. One Saturday, my copper phytoremediation experiment made the breakfast table home to four groups of greenery. Over the next few months, I watched parts of my garden flourish, and then wilt, and then (remarkably) recover. Although all my plants were eventually reduced to a green juice of sorts for absorbance testing, they had started a revolution.

Soon after my experiment ended, I realized I missed my garden, and the plant invasion began. Today, my room harbors seventeen species, meshed into a diverse jungle. A few have even spilled out, taking up residence in the living room and kitchen. Just as I am captivated by the movement of the city, I admire the delicate hardiness of plants. Left untouched by humans, forests would cover most of the United States, and even in the midst of man-made destruction, many species still find a way to break through the cement.

In my room, plants and city streets share the stage. They do not battle, but exist in equilibrium, the gray with the green, urban acceleration in balance with the stability of nature. These worlds are not opposites. For all their differences, they share the energy of growth as well as the promise of regeneration and renewal. To thrive, I need not tear myself between manmade landscape and the natural environment; I need not pick between rapid action and natural growth.

I choose both.

Professional Review by UWorld

This essay immediately captivates with its vibrant, self-aware personal voice. The opening anecdote about "crafting a new and improved Helen" from IKEA purchases is unique and humorous, effectively drawing the reader in. The essay's structure is strong, building from a whimsical personal transformation to a deeper exploration of ambition and balance. The emotional impact comes from the clear passion for both urban dynamism and natural tranquility. The author's journey from shedding old decor to embracing a room divided by cityscapes and plants is a clever and tangible representation of internal growth.

To enhance this already compelling piece, Janna might consider refining the opening to maintain that strong narrative momentum. While the self-correction "Well, perhaps this is too dramatic" adds charm, it slightly deflates the initial burst of energy. She could integrate this self-awareness more seamlessly. For instance, she might say, "My teenage self, dead set on crafting a 'new and improved' Helen, burst out of IKEA, ready to strip my

room of its outdated self. The golden comforter? Gone. The floral rug? History. Or so I thought. In the Krieger household, items are rarely thrown out, just repurposed." This maintains the dramatic flair while immediately introducing the idea of repurposing, which beautifully mirrors Janna’s later theme of synthesis rather than opposition. The essay's strength lies in its exploration of equilibrium; it could perhaps lean even more into how this balance between city and nature informs her specific academic or personal aspirations.

Emma's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/10-successful-harvard-essays-2025
Essay #: 10

Essay

The first bridge I ever built was made of paper and glue.

My 8th grade physics teacher tasked my class with building a bridge out of two pieces of paper. Instead of focusing on the paper, I applied layers and layers of glue, strengthening the paper each time. The following week, the bridge successfully held 22 pounds, setting the highest school record in 12 years.

Two years later, I began building bridges of a different kind.

The car that brought me from the airport drove away, and I stepped through the doorway into the tiny apartment in the small city of Troyan, Bulgaria. The walls were covered with my stick- figure paintings and childhood pictures.

I laid my eyes on the wise woman in front of me and leaned down to pull her into a hug – not so tightly that it would break her, but enough to show my love. Raising her wrinkly hands to wipe my tears of joy away, my grandmother mumbled a row of Bulgarian words of affection and smiled. I didn't understand, but I smiled back.

Since she lives 1247.092 miles away from me, my grandmother is not always there to give me a hug when I need it most. Nevertheless, her heart of gold transcends physical distance and has taught me more than anyone about kindness, empathy, and compassion for others. Although she can't walk me through the intricacies of Bayesian statistics or neuroscience for my upcoming test, she tries her best to understand my ambitions and goals, and contributes in other ways – whenever I have an important test coming up, she prays, lights up candles, and keeps them lit until I'm done.

I could purchase plane tickets to trek the distance that separated our homes, but two other gaps were harder to traverse: my aging grandmother's health was deteriorating and I didn't speak Bulgarian.

I sought to create bridges to close these gaps.

My grandmother suffers from rheumatoid arthritis, a disease that presses her body from every side, deforming her joints, and arching her back. She is the smallest person I know,

but yet for me, the greatest.

I wished that I could show her the world and take all her pain away, but the only thing that I could do for her was building a bridge that would connect her to the knowledge she wouldn't be able to access otherwise. I spent countless hours researching healthy meals to create a detoxifying and anti-inflammatory nutrition plan for her that would be easy to cook. The research paid off – the pain in her joints subsided.

When my grandmother and I "talked," emotions flowed between our souls like stars fly through space. Words would only describe what we feel – but not show. It was like listening to a song, but not paying attention to the lyrics, only to the pain and passion in the singer's voice and the flow of the melody.

In 2017, I decided that I finally wanted to learn Bulgarian. With a flashlight under my blanket, I started learning the Cyrillic alphabet and Audio CD's with Bulgarian day-to-day conversations talked me to sleep. I surprised my grandmother by writing her a letter – written without Google Translate for the first time. Phone calls became much more frequent, and we grew closer together, but I wanted to go one step further. I moved to Bulgaria for a semester the year after in order to see her happy face when we could finally sing the song of our conversations – with the lyrics.

Seeing the influence my bridges had on my grandmother inspired me to build more. After I came back to Germany, I learned that bridges could be built between anyone.

In March 2020, my best friend's mother confided in me that she was overwhelmed with the task of coordinating her children's schoolwork at home during quarantine. It occurred to me that a platform for building bridges from younger students to older ones could take the load off of parents during this time. I quickly found that bridging these two groups of students leads to a higher learning efficiency since younger students often feel more comfortable studying with students that they can identify with. Soon, my startup was connecting a high-quality and often entirely subsidized learning resource to a socioeconomically diverse population of students from all over Germany.

I hope that by building bridges, we learn to better appreciate each other's differences in order to create a more empathetic and connected world – together.

My bridge made of paper and glue eventually collapsed after holding 22 pounds. But my next bridge is always stronger than the one before. Above all, I will continue connecting others, and I am excited to see what bridge I will build next.

Professional Review by VAL MISRA, MR. MBA®

What did the essay do well? This powerful essay's anecdotes and personal narrative writing, linear structure, and shining themes of 'turning adversity into opportunity' and 'identity and self-reflection' are all winning attributes. Emma begins with a nice hook by clearly articulating the main essay topic —building bridges — and her first success and ingenuity at it. She is motivated to continue building bridges. Emma then moves into a deeply personal anecdote on the story anchor, her grandmother, who suffers from a painful disease, lives afar, and speaks a different dialect. Through her vivid imagery and detailed, creative prose, Emma draws the reader closer to her grandmother by evoking genuine emotions in us. I feel both sympathy and empathy for her grandmother's struggles and genuine happiness when I learn of Emma's second successful bridge connecting them closer. Emma's personal brand is superbly revealed— compassion, kindness, knowledge-seeking, problem-seeking, and connecting— all traits highly valued on college campuses. Emma shows the positive reinforcements and emotions of her grandmother serve as her 'epiphany' and catalyst for building more bridges- her startup. Finally, Emma's introspection and personal growth illuminate. She realizes the power of connecting people and knowledge together to build a better, more empathetic world- bridge building is part of her identity.

What could be improved about the essay? Emma's beautiful storytelling voice and imagery used in her grandmother's anecdote could have been used elsewhere in the essay (best friend's mother) to emphasize the overall symmetry of her creative writing abilities. Emma could have provided examples of future bridges she might build (at college, career, other) instead of leaving it open-ended.

What makes this essay memorable? This essay is memorable for two reasons. First, Emma's anecdote on the story anchor, her grandmother, is unique and profoundly touches us. Emma shares her authentic voice and vivid details that showcase their deep bond and love for each other; I love grandmother's lighting of candles and praying during Emma's test-taking. That Emma's character is revealed to us in its entirety through 'helping' grandmother is delightful- "show don't tell". Second, Emma captures her growth journey and self-reflection from overcoming adversity to impacting the world, both of which are inspirational and virtuous leaving us hopeful. I know this is not the final bridge Emma and other like-minded students will build.

"It's not an 'S'. On my world it means 'hope'!" – Kal El, Man of Steel, a Zach Snyder film.

Successful Harvard Business School Essays (2025)

7 essays

Grace's Essay

Successful Harvard Business School Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/successful-harvard-business-school-application-essays-2025
Essay #: 1

Prompt

Prompt: "As we review your application, what more would you like us to know as we consider your candidacy for the Harvard Business School MBA program?"

Essay

Since I was six, my family has volunteered to help the desperately poor and medically underserved in the remote village Boucan Carre, Haiti. Until my sisters and I were old enough to volunteer in Haiti ourselves, we would help from home, picking up donations, organizing annual benefits, and leading fundraisers. When I was fourteen, my parents fostered a Haitian boy, who was seeking medical treatment for growth hormone deficiency and malnutrition. Due to his condition, at the age of twelve, [he] stood three feet tall, weighed 45 pounds, and wore a 5T size in clothing. He was sweet and playful, but at times struggled to overcome anger, sorrow, and self-harm, resulting in violent and often public outbursts. We loved [him] despite the challenges, and our family adapted. My parents were, rightly, consumed with [him] and his well-being, so I embraced the role of mediator within our large family. I took on a parent role to my younger sister, who felt neglected, and I supported my parents to ease their burden. Though fostering [him] was difficult, we grew stronger as a family and in our relationships to both Diego and each other. I had expected to take on the role of older sister to Diego, but I never anticipated that my role with my younger sister, or my parents, would change as well. Interpersonal relationships are complex and dynamic, and through the experience, I learned that a significant change to an established system, like my family, can create a ripple effect that can be difficult to predict.

In my professional experience, I have seen how targeted investments can have a similar unforeseen ripple effect on communities, positive or negative. For example, recent infrastructure investments by telecommunications companies have improved access to the internet in Africa, which has earned these companies' higher subscriber growth, their intended outcome. The unintentional, although positive, ripple effect was that it paved the way for growth in digital finance in the region, giving millions of people access to

credit and financial accounts who would not otherwise have them. Similarly, private equity has a place in the global economy as a stimulus for growth, innovation, and productivity, and also as a means to connect excess capital to companies seeking it. In my time at [Private Equity Firm], my team has invested in large companies based in South Korea, Germany, and the Netherlands. The investments have resulted in net job growth and productivity gains in their respective locations. However, the economic value of global investment activity and its ripple effect is not going far enough to affect villages like Boucan Carre or people like Diego. My hope is that with a deeper understanding of local cultural dynamics, international private equity investment can improve its impact and reach.

As a Lebanese-American growing up in a small Tennessee town, I learned to navigate the juxtaposed perspectives of my family in Lebanon and my environment in Knoxville and bridged the gap between the two cultures. Professionally, I have found that connecting across cultural divides is important for effective communication. For example, I work closely with a company based in Seoul, and through interacting with colleagues there, I observed that professional culture in Korea is far more formal than in America. Drawing on my experience connecting my Lebanese and southern cultures, I trained my own mannerisms to improve our communication, even in minor ways such as referring to familiar colleagues as “Mr.” or Ms.” By improving my awareness of cultural nuances and adapting my communication habits, our interactions became more effective and, eventually, more frequent, which helped information flow across the two groups.

I want to invest in international markets, where I can apply my skills in finance and my perspectives on relationships and working across cultures to make an impact on the poorest communities. Upon graduation, I want to join an operations-focused private equity firm with international reach, because investing in developing markets will be at a smaller scale than my work thus far at [Private Equity Firm] and will require more operations improvements to create value for individual communities.

To be successful in my goal, I need a broader business base. My education and career have been narrowly focused in finance and at arms’ length. At my firm, we talk about the complexities of integrating acquisitions, but I have never integrated disparate IT systems myself or seen the work that goes into it. We tell our investors about operational improvements we can make, but I have never run manufacturing equipment or improved output. The next step to fill these gaps is to gain greater understanding in new areas of business. Based on my discussions with current students (e.g., [HBS Alumni ’19) and alumni (e.g., [HBS Alumni] ’16) who are colleagues, I know that HBS is the best program

to attain this broader business base and to engage myself in a campus community. I will take advantage of courses such as Managing International Trade and Investment to understand the landscape of foreign investment, and TOM to deepen my understanding of operations, an area in which I am weak today. I will learn from section mates from diverse backgrounds who view problems and approach solutions differently. I can apply my experiences to real life scenarios in cases and group assignments. I hope to pursue a FIELD immersion program where, for example, my group could implement a new product in a developing community, execute a marketing strategy at a small scale in a foreign country, and confront real, localized problems in the process. I plan to join the Investing Club to learn from peers from other asset class backgrounds, like start-ups or international growth equity. There, I can leverage my experience leading Notre Dame's Wall Street Club by organizing speaker series around broader investment strategies, including social impact and emerging markets, which will develop my understanding of localized investing in international markets.

Private equity investment has the potential to positively impact communities like [my brother's]. By transcending cultural divides, investments can create opportunities that are mutually beneficial to local populations and businesses, creating jobs and new industries that improve quality of life for low-income communities, while being economically attractive for companies. I know HBS can deliver an MBA experience that provides me with the broad business foundation I need to be effective in targeted investing in developing markets.

Professional Review by Austin GMAT Review

In the 2025-26 HBS application, three short essays ask about your business mindset, growth, and leadership. Coming from a previous application cycle, Grace's essay is much longer than yours will be but still provides us with insight into what HBS values.

HBS wants to learn not only about your business experience but also your motivations and thinking. Grace describes how the arrival of her foster brother, a displaced Haitian boy, unexpectedly changed the family dynamics, which she interestingly compares to the unintended "ripple effect" of global investment dropped into developing markets. She also draws a connection between her upbringing as a Lebanese-American in the South and her adaptive abilities as an American in Korea. Grace both highlights her international experiences and demonstrates how they shape a unique business viewpoint that allows her to perceive obscure patterns, connections, and realities.

HBS expects you to acknowledge what you have to learn. Grace describes past growth – becoming a parent figure to her younger sister – and her desire for growth at HBS. By humbly admitting her operational knowledge gaps, Grace reveals a growth mindset.

Finally, HBS looks for leadership traits that will enable you to guide and motivate others. Grace demonstrates big picture thinking in her goals for international investment, particularly in her desire to invest locally and positively impact communities. She displays empathy towards others, and she describes not only what she will gain from HBS but also how she plans to give back to the HBS community, an important aspect of leadership.

J's Essay

Successful Harvard Business School Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/successful-harvard-business-school-application-essays-2025
Essay #: 2

Prompt

Business-Minded Essay Prompt: "Please reflect on how your experiences have influenced your career choices and aspirations and the impact you strive to make on the businesses, organizations, and communities you plan to serve."

Essay

When I was 15, my best friend moved to China, and two years later, my family and I visited. We spent days exploring temples and markets, but I'll never forget seeing a vendor selling bottled clean air. Were people really buying air? How bad was the pollution that something like bottled air could be sold?

My father worked in the O&G sector and we often discussed its impact on the environment. During my engineering studies, I delved deeper into climate change, energy transition, and the economic potential of sustainable practices. Post-graduation, I joined EnergyCo, an energy transition company in Mexico. At first, I didn't know much about electricity markets, but I understood that decarbonizing electricity generation could have a huge impact on reducing pollution.

When EnergyCo asked me to lead its expansion into Texas, I was excited yet intimidated. In Mexico, I had become an expert in our young energy market, but Texas was a mature market, and my team included professionals with decades of experience. I often felt like an imposter, humbled by the knowledge around me, but I soaked up every learning opportunity. Doing so, I learned that while providing clean energy is essential it is only a small part of the problem. The grid itself, outdated and overburdened across the world, is a fundamental part of the equation.

Modernizing power grids to accommodate renewable energy and make them more reliable, resilient, and able to distribute energy efficiently is essential if we want to achieve our energy transition goals.

I aspire to tackle this challenge, particularly in Latin America, where reliable energy access could drive significant progress. By strengthening these systems, I hope to

empower communities and businesses alike, giving them the clean energy they need to thrive and eliminating any market for bottled clean air.

Professional Review by Cosmic College Consulting

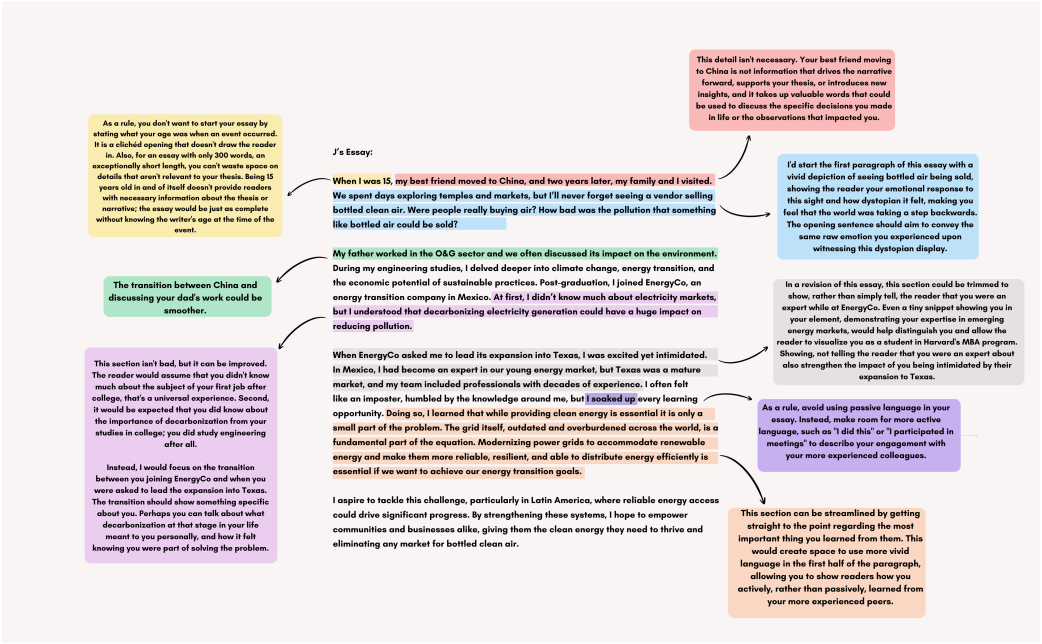
This essay succeeds because it establishes a clear, personal motivation for J's interest in clean energy, demonstrates the depth of that motivation through vivid storytelling and real-world experience, and shows how J will be an excellent MBA student. J's memory of seeing bottled "clean" air sold in China is a striking, visceral, dystopian image that hooks the reader instantly. The connection to childhood conversations about the environmental effects of their father's oil and gas career deepens this motivation by introducing nuance into their origin story.

Equally compelling is how J connects their academic and professional experience to their motivation. Their work expanding an energy transition company into Texas shows initiative, humility, and growth, traits every MBA program wants from their students. By sharing how they learned from industry veterans and discovered the crucial role of power grids, J demonstrates their intellectual readiness to benefit from Harvard's community of experts and peers. Most importantly, the essay closes with a tangible, inspiring goal, abolishing the need for bottled clean air, and explains a step J will take in accomplishing that by modernizing grids and expanding access to sustainable energy in Latin America. This vision makes it easy for admissions officers to root for J's success and see the broader impact of investing in their education.

Prospective MBA applicants should study how this essay weaves story, credibility, learning, and ambition into a single, compelling narrative. Scroll below to see a critical review of J's essay by a Cosmic College Consulting MBA admissions expert:

Critical Review

Annotated feedback from Cosmic College Consulting:


This detail isn't necessary. Your best friend moving to China is not information that drives the narrative forward, supports your thesis, or introduces new insights, and it takes up valuable words that could be used to discuss the specific decisions you made in life or the observations that impacted you.
As a rule, you don't want to start your essay by stating what your age was when an event occurred. It is a clichéd opening that doesn't draw the reader in. Also, for an essay with only 300 words, an exceptionally short length, you can't waste space on details that aren't relevant to your thesis. Being 15 years old in and of itself doesn't provide readers with necessary information about the thesis or narrative; the essay would be just as complete without knowing the writer's age at the time of the event.
J's Essay:
When I was 15, my best friend moved to China, and two years later, my family and I visited. We spent days exploring temples and markets, but I'll never forget seeing a vendor selling bottled clean air. Were people really buying air? How bad was the pollution that something like bottled air could be sold?
I'd start the first paragraph of this essay with a vivid depiction of seeing bottled air being sold, showing the reader your emotional response to this sight and how dystopian it felt, making you feel that the world was taking a step backwards. The opening sentence should aim to convey the same raw emotion you experienced upon witnessing this dystopian display.
My father worked in the O&G sector and we often discussed its impact on the environment. During my engineering studies, I delved deeper into climate change, energy transition, and the economic potential of sustainable practices. Post-graduation, I joined EnergyCo, an energy transition company in Mexico. At first, I didn't know much about electricity markets, but I understood that decarbonizing electricity generation could have a huge impact on reducing pollution.
The transition between China and discussing your dad's work could be smoother.
This section isn't bad, but it can be improved. The reader would assume that you didn't know much about the subject of your first job after college, that's a universal experience. Second, it would be expected that you did know about the importance of decarbonization from your studies in college; you did study engineering after all.
Instead, I would focus on the transition between you joining EnergyCo and when you were asked to lead the expansion into Texas. The transition should show something specific about you. Perhaps you can talk about what decarbonization at that stage in your life meant to you personally, and how it felt knowing you were part of solving the problem.
When EnergyCo asked me to lead its expansion into Texas, I was excited yet intimidated. In Mexico, I had become an expert in our young energy market, but Texas was a mature market, and my team included professionals with decades of experience. I often felt like an imposter, humbled by the knowledge around me, but I soaked up every learning opportunity. Doing so, I learned that while providing clean energy is essential it is only a small part of the problem. The grid itself, outdated and overburdened across the world, is a fundamental part of the equation. Modernizing power grids to accommodate renewable energy and make them more reliable, resilient, and able to distribute energy efficiently is essential if we want to achieve our energy transition goals.
In a revision of this essay, this section could be trimmed to show, rather than simply tell, the reader that you were an expert while at EnergyCo. Even a tiny snippet showing you in your element, demonstrating your expertise in emerging energy markets, would help distinguish you and allow the reader to visualize you as a student in Harvard's MBA program. Showing, not telling the reader that you were an expert about also strengthen the impact of you being intimidated by their expansion to Texas.
As a rule, avoid using passive language in your essay. Instead, make room for more active language, such as "I did this" or "I participated in meetings" to describe your engagement with your more experienced colleagues.
I aspire to tackle this challenge, particularly in Latin America, where reliable energy access could drive significant progress. By strengthening these systems, I hope to empower communities and businesses alike, giving them the clean energy they need to thrive and eliminating any market for bottled clean air.
This section can be streamlined by getting straight to the point regarding the most important thing you learned from them. This would create space to use more vivid language in the first half of the paragraph, allowing you to show readers how you actively, rather than passively, learned from your more experienced peers.

Rhonda's Essay

Successful Harvard Business School Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/successful-harvard-business-school-application-essays-2025
Essay #: 3

Prompt

Leadership-Focused Essay Prompt: "What experiences have shaped who you are, how you invest in others, and what kind of leader you want to become?"

Essay

“Counsel with your feet, not your voice.” This phrase, ingrained in me during my summers as a YMCA camp counselor, has profoundly influenced my leadership vision over the past decade. Though supervising five-year-olds differs vastly from leading pharmaceutical manufacturing campaigns, the principle of leading by example remains central to my approach.

Truly inspirational leadership combines empathy, approachability, and proactivity. To better understand and support patients with uncured medical conditions, I actively engage with service organizations such as Kesem, Misericordia, and Camp One Step. These experiences have deepened my empathy and reinforced my commitment to impactful leadership in healthcare.

Starting my career at a company with over 80,000 employees, I discovered the importance of leading through action rather than rhetoric. To ensure the effectiveness and safety of every product, impactful leaders must be both contributors and project managers. As a manufacturing program manager, I embraced this philosophy by conducting on-site visits with vendors and shadowing technicians. Through this hands-on approach, I effectively guided my team through risk management and process improvements.

While leading pilot-scale engineering batches from conception to analysis, careful planning is crucial, but day-to-day unexpected challenges are unavoidable. By implementing trending and tracking technologies, I monitored for unexplained excursions well before issues became mission-critical, allowing for swift interventions and minimizing product loss or reactor downtime through proactive leadership.

By pursuing an MBA at Harvard, I aim to enhance my leadership capabilities further, continuing to “counsel with my feet” and inspire others through direct, impactful action.

Professional Review by Applicant Lab

This applicant has clearly had an impactful career so far; one that’s allowed them to cultivate and demonstrate promising leadership potential! The essay starts strong: the enduring YMCA camp counselor lesson paints a vivid picture, while still respecting HBS’s desire for brevity. The essay is also strong in highlighting the breadth of the applicant’s experience: the reference to working with vendors and technicians emphasizes interpersonal skills across multi-faceted teams, and introducing new tracking technologies demonstrates initiative.

The essay could have been optimized even further by trimming away superfluous information. Broad-sweeping pronouncements about which traits “truly inspirational”, “impactful leaders” have were a wasted opportunity: that word-count would have been better allocated to describing very specific details around the candidate’s specific actions taken during specific anecdotes. Another place to optimize could have been to remove information I’d already know from elsewhere in the application form/ resume (e.g. volunteer activities; company’s number of employees), as well as the unnecessary closing line about the desire to go to HBS (which is already assumed!).

In ApplicantLab, my HBS module is one of several that provides multiple step-by-step lessons to teach you how to optimize your essay; this one was strong, but could have been even stronger by trimming some vaguer parts and replacing them with vivid, memorable details unique to the candidate.

Miguel's Essay

Successful Harvard Business School Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/successful-harvard-business-school-application-essays-2025
Essay #: 4

Prompt

Growth-Oriented Essay Prompt: "Curiosity can be seen in many ways. Please share an example of how you have demonstrated curiosity and how that has influenced your growth

Essay

My favorite place in the world is Lopresti Park, a soccer field in East Boston. Here, you might see an Algerian dancing to Brazilian funk music or a Nigerian sharing Colombian food with an Albanian. Despite our differences in language, culture, and religion, we're united by the same passion: soccer. Growing up here taught me that soccer is a universal language that transcends barriers and allows communities to form across lines that often divide. I knew that the sport could be used on a greater scale.

So, I decided to conduct research in Colombia on soccer's role in social transformation in marginalized communities. After seeing the sport used as a tool for reconciliation in Medellín and Bogotá, I applied what I learned by organizing tournaments that brought together over 40 people. During one match, two players got into a scuffle, and I had to step in. I paused the game, mirrored their words, validated their frustrations, and reframed the issue to help them reconcile. Weeks later, I witnessed one of those players—known for being hot-headed—step in to de-escalate a similar dispute. I felt I had made a difference in my neighborhood.

My curiosity, which stemmed from seeing my community being formed across barriers, led me to understand the importance of building understanding between those from different backgrounds. As someone whose life has oscillated between disparate cultural and socioeconomic worlds, I've often served as a bridge between people from different backgrounds. At HBS, I'll bring this same spirit. I'll contribute to the Private Equity Club, Impact Investing Club, and Consulting for Impact with my global perspective and experience from Fulcrum. I'll join clubs like Soccer, First Generation, and the LASO. But above all, I'll strive to build bridges and facilitate a compassionate community.

Professional Review by Personal MBA Coach

Miguel's approach to HBS's final essay, which remains the only unchanged prompt for the 2025 to 2026 MBA application cycle, is both smart and strategic. Many applicants have expressed concerns to Personal MBA Coach that the new HBS essays offer limited space to share their personal stories and tell HBS what truly sets them apart. Through this curiosity prompt, however, Miguel effectively conveys multiple distinct messages to the admissions committee, each thoughtfully woven into his narrative.

First and foremost, by sharing how he researched soccer's broader impact on marginalized communities and then used this research to benefit his own community, Miguel conveys his passion for soccer along with his intellectual curiosity, deep appreciation for diverse cultures and backgrounds, and a proclivity for action. These values all resonate strongly with HBS.

Second, Miguel presents himself as a leader in an authentic and understated way. Rather than focusing on his own accolades, he tells a story about how another player benefited from the skills Miguel taught him. This approach allows readers to see Miguel as a leader others naturally want to follow.

Finally, Miguel shares his distinctive cultural and socioeconomic background, positioning himself as a bridge between different communities. This insight helps the admissions team envision the inclusive and thoughtful leader he will be on campus. Despite this essay's many strengths, it could be improved by removing the closing section on HBS. Personal MBA Coach does not advise including long lists of contributions, as these often come across as disingenuous and not well developed. Further, this type of content is not necessary to address the prompt.

Sam's Essay

Successful Harvard Business School Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/successful-harvard-business-school-application-essays-2025
Essay #: 5

Prompt

Prompt: "As we review your application, what more would you like us to know as we consider your candidacy for the Harvard Business School MBA program?"

Essay

The conspicuously large red glasses that have adorned my face for the past decade are integral to who I am. These 2”x2” square-faced rims have proven to be an instant conversation starter and a means by which I am often remembered. They are even featured on a crowd-sourced page on WikiCU – Columbia’s version of Wikipedia – meant to chronicle my work as Student Body President. In fact, my glasses have their own page too. All this attention, now endearing, to a pair of glasses was certainly never my intention. The red glasses resemble merely a fashionable accessory to most, but have a far deeper significance to me: they embody a past insecurity that I have now overcome.

Growing up in the desert city of Dubai, I have ironically always been attracted to water activities, and was a competitive swimmer during middle school. I loved the sport and used it as a channel to navigate what was a tough period of social identity. While I made many new friends at swim meets, I also truly valued the reflective time I had to myself in the pool. However, my vision started to deteriorate at the age of thirteen, and my parents introduced me to my first pair of remarkably average spectacles. Over the following eighteen months, my vision became blurrier and I would get throbbing headaches if I did not wear my glasses. Although significant astigmatism is not an uncommon condition, it was a weakness that constantly stared me in the face and seriously impacted my daily life. I questioned what I had done wrong and how I could counter what I viewed as a handicap – should I watch less TV? Should I change my vegetarian diet? Should I pray more frequently at the temple?

My vision disadvantaged me in the pool, and I slowly lost interest in swimming. It was agonizing to find myself distant from such an important part of my childhood. I acknowledged that the plastic frame with thick lenses was here to stay. To a younger

version of myself, it seemed like I was destined to parade my weakness perched on my nose with no place to hide.

After a year of resentment, I was poised to shake things up. I was determined to tackle this demon and reimagine the implications. On a summer trip to Mumbai, I purchased my first pair of jumbo unbranded red glasses. The large size and loud color waswere a deliberate choice. This was my internal battle cry as I was tired of hiding – no more drab glasses; no more shunning my handicap.

The principal back at my conservative high school disliked the bright red color that starkly contrasted the somber school uniform, and was vocal about his distaste for the glasses. He attempted to bully me into not wearing them, but I was not willing to turn back now. My creative compromise was to resort to dual identities; I brought two pairs of glasses to school daily – the lively red pair for the classroom and a rimless sober pair for the common areas that the principal roamed.

Fortunately, college was more welcoming; “are they real?” was the third most frequent question during orientation after “how do you speak such fluent English?” and “did you ride camels back home?” My red glasses were an easy icebreaker and the unconventional fashion appeal helped debunk stereotypes of an engineer’s appearance. The warm response towards my red glasses gave me newfound confidence in my new home many seas away from family. This self-belief helped me successfully run for freshman Class Representative, which subsequently led to three reelections in different capacities on student council. My team and our agenda evolved each year but the constant red glasses portrayed a sense of familiarity and trustworthiness. The red glasses accompanied my team on our posters around campus, on our social media outreach, and as we went door to door speaking with the constituents we strived to serve. Even those that were unaware of the student council’s initiatives knew they could always reach out to “the guy with red glasses.” Inadvertently, the red glasses had become my personal brand.

As I embarked into the business world, I gave considerable thought to how I would present myself. Post college, pressed suits and ties replaced t-shirts and sweatpants, and I questioned if I was supposed to retire the red glasses for a more professional alternative. Recalling my high school experience, I settled on a dual appearance, wearing different sets of glasses depending on my target audience and desired message. While this helped me control my persona, the glasses were still more of a trusted friend than simply a showpiece; they continued to give me courage and reminded me not to back down in challenging times. In my first year at [the Investment Firm], I spent a couple months at my portfolio company and the experience was initially as uncomfortable as it was

exciting. I had to often provide guidance to senior executives who were far more tenured than I was, and I questioned how I, three years into my career, was to convince industry experts of my views. Through my internal conflict, the red glasses I wore served as a constant reminder that I could push through my reservations, and I did.

My red glasses have become endearing to friends and family because they are truly an extension of myself. Friendly, colorful, and bold, they encapsulate my personality well. Friends (and occasionally strangers) often grabbed my glasses to take a photograph wearing them, leading to a photography blog through senior year of college titled "Sidd B. Imposters" that captured over a hundred such moments. After years of practice, I even have a jovial response to compliments now: "Thanks – they're the only reason I have friends!"

As an investment professional today, I look back and realize that the red glasses have yielded an unexpectedly high return on investment; they seem to have an intangible draw that enhances what I bring to the table. Accompanying me on my journey thus far, the red glasses are essential to my individuality. They have become what my family and friends expect to be greeted with, give me a mode to connect with strangers, and reinforce the boldness I feel we should all have towards our work and dreams. Although I aspire to wear crimson red proudly, I have no intention of leaving behind my candy apple red glasses. I am confident that they will help me embrace the dreaded cold call and will partake in the many adventures I hope to have with my section mates.

Professional Review by VAL MISRA, MR. MBA®

What did the essay do well?

This delightful, unique essay captures the reader through its winning themes of 'identity and self-reflection' and 'turning adversity into opportunity' intertwined wonderfully with Sam's vivid imagery of a special character– his red glasses (Red), his strong narrative writing, personal and professional anecdotes, and deeply human elements.

Sam's opening hook is excellent- the introduction of Red, which becomes a part of his identity early in his life and he showcases this, doesn't tell, brilliantly. Highlighting his ocular condition as a weakness and the unfortunate impacts it had on his early life is sad, yet we are uplifted through his self-reflection and determination to overcome.

Through his authentic voice, we then embark on a journey of personal growth, exploring Dubai, Mumbai, Columbia University, and his investment firm, while gaining insight into his inner voice, the obstacles he faces, and his ability to prevail over them with the help of

his trusty companion, Red. Thus, Sam is able to communicate not just his accomplishments but also who he is as a person and leader in a novel way.

What could be improved about the essay?

Although the essay is powerful, it could have been improved by providing further contextual details in the anecdotes regarding the situations at hand. For example, at Sam's investment firm, he could have provided a concrete example with details on the specific investment, walking the reader through the situation, stating his actions/dialogue to convince his supervisors to adopt his financial views, and what the professional impact was.

What makes this essay memorable?

This essay is memorable for two reasons.

First, the use of Red as an individual character that gives strength to Sam throughout his life is deeply heartfelt and authentic. Red is (almost) a superhero for Sam. His descriptive storytelling abilities with Red are superb and leave the reader smiling.

Second, Sam's depth of introspection and self-development throughout the essay shines brightly. He has constantly looked deep within himself, grappled with his demons, and come out ever stronger, showcasing his emotional maturity. A great lesson for the reader.

Nisha's Essay

Successful Harvard Business School Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/successful-harvard-business-school-application-essays-2025
Essay #: 6

Prompt

Prompt: "As we review your application, what more would you like us to know as we consider your candidacy for the Harvard Business School MBA program?"

Essay

I was 4 years old when I stepped foot in my first Bharatnatyam dance class. Everything was foreign to me – I had just learned how to walk a couple years back, and now this? But, the moment the girls' feet struck the floor, I was mesmerized by the way their movement captured a steady rhythm. I galloped over to the others in excitement and gave it a try. Right. Left. Jump. Right. In that simple moment, I was hooked. Bharatnatyam, though best known for its powerful footwork and elegant storytelling, is also described as a brutal test of stamina, commitment, and grit, not typically suited for someone who hasn't even hit puberty. My parents assumed I would eventually get fed up and quit like most others who caved under the pressure. However, the rush I felt as a toddler kept me hyper-motivated for the next 7 years as I trained for my Arangetram, the coveted two-hour solo graduation performance.

The path to the finish line was not an easy one. I struggled in areas that required maturity, such as extension, emotion, and stage presence, and I often felt inadequate versus my older peers. I practiced twice as hard for months, going so far as to tell myself stories with just my eyes while brushing my teeth to improve my expressions. At age 11, I beat the odds and became the youngest dancer in Central Florida to receive her diploma. As I took my final bow that evening, I realized my first experience as a dancer not only tested my character – it defined it. The ruthless discipline I developed at an early age from dance naturally bled over into all areas of my life, which pushed me to achieve a unique well-roundedness. An example of a day in my high school shoes looked like this: 5am wake-up, debate team captains meeting during lunch, Latin ballroom competition run-through after school, pit stop at Taco Bell with friends, Spanish homework, evening tennis practice, Indian soap operas with grandma, sleep. My friends questioned whether I really did that last step, but my trick never involved skipping my beauty sleep. My secret

sauce was the way I was hardwired as a dancer; I was laser focused on putting more than I thought I had into every new venture to leave a lasting impact rather than simply "learning the moves."

Over the years, I gained fluency in balancing several moving pieces at once and was thrilled to receive the "Best Dancer" senior superlative, to be appointed captain of my varsity tennis team, and even to strut down the football field as "Homecoming Princess." As I stood at the podium to give my graduation speech as valedictorian, I was proud, but I was even prouder to have become someone the athletes, student government leaders, artists, and other multifaceted students sitting across from me could relate to and respect. I entered Penn feeling like a rock star, but I was quickly humbled when I noticed my individual efforts, no matter how disciplined, weren't getting me very far. I struggled in my first Economics class. I got rejected from several on-campus organizations I applied to. And when I finally landed my first leadership position with the South Asia Society (SAS), the group was dysfunctional and uninvolved.

As I examined what I could possibly do to turn SAS around, dance once again proved to be my failsafe. My college dance team, Penn Masti, taught me the importance of collaboration and camaraderie for a group's success– after all, if one member was unprepared or disinterested, our practices lost productivity and our performances unraveled. Ergo, for the next three years on SAS Board, I poured my energy into building an analogously positive culture and sense of community. I launched several team-building initiatives, including an annual retreat, one-on-one coffee chats, monthly Board bonding events, and "Highs and Lows" exercises, and gradually the culture improved. For the first time ever, I saw bonds and passion form that sparked new ideas for programming and growth. Over time, we attracted a tight-knit network of 300+ students that became one of the most active and influential communities on campus.

Though this was my first real experience as a member of a high-functioning team, it transformed my toolkit for an approach to my career in finance. A few months into my job in healthcare investment banking, the most senior banker in our office quit, along with 5 others. The group left behind was severely under-resourced and overwhelmed. Right on cue, at the worst possible time, I got an offer to start early at my current job. The idea of leaving my group hanging during a time of extremely low team morale kept me up every night. If I left, I could burn bridges with the same people who developed me. But if I stayed, I could stall my career. I ultimately chose to stay with my team. My decision forced me to step up to positions above my level given our limited human capital. I put in several 4am nights digesting research on cell therapy, building meticulous market

models, and practicing presentations to executives to close one of the most transformative biotech deals of 2017. My dance discipline kept me going despite the 100-hour work weeks. It also drove me to simultaneously help reinvigorate my team. I offered a listening ear to disgruntled analysts who wanted to see change. I organized weekly team lunches and a transparent staffing sheet to streamline workflow communication. I even recruited talented new analysts to solidify the sustainability of the group. Very slowly, but surely, the group emerged from the slump as a cohesive unit, and I moved on having gained valuable deal experience and knowing they were well-equipped to handle future obstacles together.

I, much to my chagrin, admit that since graduating I've been consumed on multiple occasions with the rigorous single focus of work. I find myself battling with time while trying to balance my professional ambitions in healthcare private equity with my personal goals – sometimes it feels as though there aren't enough hours in a day. Dance has thankfully been my avenue to escape and connect with my community. Upon moving to New York, I was eager to blend my passion for dance with my desire to build meaningful relationships outside of work. I began volunteering for Dance for PD, a non-profit offering specialized dance classes for patients with Parkinson's Disease to enhance cognition, motor skills, and social interaction. Swing dancing with 65-year-olds may not be the ideal Saturday morning for all, but I feel a fulfilling connection with my partner each time a hand stops trembling, or a smile emerges when he or she finds the beat. For everything dance has given me, it's been a privilege to help improve the well-being of others through dance. Even still, I've gained so much from this experience, perhaps most importantly learning resilience from my new companions who show up to every class with tales of last week's adventures in hand, as if no neurological condition stands between them and a normal lifestyle.

My first foray into dance was the beginning of the rest of my life as I know it. Dance empowered me to have no resistance whatsoever to hard work and taught me countless lessons that have made me the woman I am today. Today, I am more balanced, open-minded, and patient. Today, I believe that collaboration, or lack thereof, can catalyze leaders to either change the world or take a backseat. Looking forward, I am hopeful to make an impact at HBS and at a high-growth healthcare startup with the same creative mindset and commitment to action. And though I can't be completely sure of what the future holds, I know I will always have a part of that little girl of 4 years within me — my love for dancing and everything it inspires me to do.

Professional Review by Ivy League Stories

The absolute greatest essays are really just stories, and Nisha completely understands this. After all, these essays are titled “Statement of Purpose.” What better way can you convey your purpose than telling a story about your life? The most important things that make this essay exceptional are the vivid narrative arc and self reflection that exists from beginning to end. Nisha invites readers on a journey that gracefully transitions from childhood discipline to professional discovery, all while never losing sight of her values and passion.

Accomplishments are not just listed. Nisha allows space for her experiences to be nuanced. She speaks of the discipline it took and the pressure she faced to receive her Bharatnatyam diploma at 11, and she makes it a beautiful motif. Nisha tells us stories about balancing high school, transforming SAS into an active organization, and selflessly managing a depleted investment banking team.

Although seemingly separate parts of her life, she connects them all through her motif: “dance once again proved to be my failsafe”, “My dance discipline kept me going despite the 100-hour work weeks.” Nisha highlights the symbiosis that exists between personal identity and successes.

This essay also does a beautiful job of humanizing Nisha, specifically when she describes volunteering with Dance for PD: “I feel a fulfilling connection with my partner each time a hand stops trembling.” This experience expresses how dance has not only served to increase discipline, but also humanity, which adds nuance. Nisha’s purpose is clear, her leadership is admirable, and her resilience in the face of adversity is undeniable. She lives through the impact that she speaks of and does so in such a compelling way, making her a stellar applicant.

Tim's Essay

Successful Harvard Business School Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/successful-harvard-business-school-application-essays-2025
Essay #: 7

Prompt

Leadership-Focused Essay Prompt: "What experiences have shaped who you are, how you invest in others, and what kind of leader you want to become?"

Essay

It was in the last week of my externship at Pathao when over 300 employees (two-thirds of the company) were laid off, including nearly everyone I'd worked with for six months. I was shocked by the sudden turn of events. Pathao was the leading transportation startup in Bangladesh but had just failed to secure a Series B investment. Frustratingly, the downsizing had little to do with how well Pathao performed and more to do with the disappointing IPOs of two tech giants across the world – Uber and Lyft. Here I saw the very real limitations of capital not flowing into companies and countries where I felt needed it most – where it could have the largest societal impact per dollar invested. I want to lead the charge to get more capital into the geographies, industries, and companies, where the potential of impact on underserved people is optimized.

I attribute my global empathy and fascination with the world to growing up with a giant world map on our living room wall pinned with photos of family friends living all over the world. As Christian missionaries, my parents visited and befriended people of all nationalities and brought home stories of people they had served. They modeled for me the profound impact one could have on another's life, from providing a struggling mother with food to feed her family to giving love and hope to an orphan child. Expecting to follow in my parents' footsteps and become a missionary, I went on numerous service trips to developing countries like Paraguay and the Philippines where I taught English and helped build schools. I gained perspective and connection to people in environments different from my own but realized that the inequality was far greater than I could effectively reduce through a direct one-on-one model.

While in college, I saw my two older brothers thriving in the world of finance, which introduced me to another model for societal impact: be successful and use your financial resources for good. To learn more, I did summer internships at a tech startup and,

enjoying the experience, joined a for-profit consulting firm after college. At L.E.K. I first understood how capital had both the scale and the influence to drive impact. Based on our analyses, our private equity clients would shift hundreds of millions of dollars in and out of markets, which would have meaningful effects on the business' surrounding communities. But often the work didn't align with my core values of serving the underserved. As I contemplated next steps, I kept returning to a question my brothers had asked me – "what would you regret not doing when you look back at your life in fifty years?"

That question led me to join Bridgespan where I could continue to sharpen my business skills while working on creating change at scale on social issues. My first project was advising the $2 billion TPG Rise Fund on making impact minded investments. Though they clearly had financial know-how, TPG needed guidance in measuring impact using data-driven methods and incorporating it into their investment framework. My role was, as TPG described it, to be an "impact bodyguard". For example, when I worked on their $150 million investment into CFPA Microfinance, we directed them to include impact covenants to ensure that a portion of their loans would go to low-income, rural farmers that didn't have prior access to financing. I realized that there was a giant gap of expertise and knowledge in being a true "impact" investor, not just an investor that happens to have social impact.

Though I conceptually understood the social impact of my work, wanting to see the impact actualized on the ground, I searched for high-growth, impact-focused companies, which is how I ended up at Pathao. There, I saw the positive impact on the more than 50,000 drivers who now made living wages, and on the 3,000,000 riders whose commutes were cut in half. Moreover, the positive effect of impact investing capital in Pathao was validated when I represented Pathao at the National Economic Mobility Roundtable hosted by a leading NGO, BRAC. High ranking government officials and national non-profit leaders looked to me to describe the social and economic impact Pathao and other private sector companies have had on low-income individuals through creating quality jobs at scale. My experience at Pathao has confirmed my belief in the role that impact investing could have on individuals, communities, and even entire countries. However, it was also at Pathao where I saw the profit-driven constraints of the investors as demonstrated by the financially-motivated downsizing I experienced.

During and after HBS, I will push the impact investing industry to become more impact-first and globally-focused. While working at leading impact funds like Echoing Green and Acumen, I will construct creative solutions like impact bonds and global fund

management structures to further advance their thinking and actions. I envision promoting additional accountability around manager compensation, incorporating predictive impact modeling, and utilizing global sourcing as commonplace practices in these funds. I will bring a bipartisan perspective from both the for profit and non-profit world, international experience, and knowledge from within ventures and with investors to lead and innovate impact investing. In my living room one day, I envision an even bigger world map, now even more crowded with faces of people I helped. I hope to help make the world a more equitable place by moving capital, at scale, to those who need it most in the world.

Professional Review by GoElite

The essay skillfully merges personal narrative with industry insight. The opening scene, a sudden mass layoff at Pathao that removed two thirds of the staff, instantly anchors the reader in the harsh realities of capital scarcity in emerging markets. Each career step that follows, from service trips to finance, consulting, and finally impact investing, builds a coherent story line that highlights a rising commitment to underserved communities. Specific figures such as fifty thousand drivers, three million riders, and a one hundred fifty-million dollar microfinance deal add credibility and show operational fluency. The term “impact bodyguard” supplies a memorable detail that proves the writer grasps how covenants convert good intentions into measurable outcomes. The concluding section sets out concrete post-HBS targets, including impact bonds, pay tied to verified outcomes, and globally sourced deal flow, demonstrating both strategic vision and technical depth.

To elevate the piece further, linger a bit longer on the Pathao layoff. A brief, sensory description of the office in that moment would heighten emotional stakes and clarify why the event was pivotal. Strengthen a few links in the narrative chain by showing how L.E.K. projects clashed with personal values and how CFPA covenants changed borrower lives. Finally, tighten future goals with decisive verbs such as “will link” or “will model” to project confidence.

Successful Harvard Law School Essays (2025)

4 essays

Aaron's Essay

Successful Harvard Law School Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/successful-harvard-law-school-essays-2025
Essay #: 1

Prompt

This essay responds to the following prompt: The Admissions Committee makes every effort to understand who you are as an individual and potential Harvard Law School student and graduate. Please share how your experiences, background, and/or interests have shaped you and will shape your engagement in the HLS community and the legal profession.

Essay

It has, tragically, become cliché to comment on our country's political divisions. However, one recent development is particularly concerning to me: the politicization of the judicial system. Whether merited or not, lawyers are today often regarded as political operatives, and judicial rulings seen as commitments to a political party, rather than to the Constitution. Given rising polarization and cynicism, it is imperative that law students pledge themselves to the founding values of our country, over which neither party has a monopoly. As a result of living in environments that span the political spectrum and teaching philosophy for two years, I have gained a respect for the American values at the heart of our legal system, and I believe my perspective will enhance classroom dialogue, community service and my career.

As a Midwesterner who has spent significant time on both coasts, I understand how our founding values can bridge partisan divides. I saw this firsthand at protests against the Keystone XL pipeline led by Bold Nebraska. The lineup at these protests included not only speakers from the expected environmental groups, but also traditionally conservative ranchers and farmers. They joined the coalition after losing their land to eminent domain on behalf of Keystone XL, and the coalition campaigned against eminent domain on the premise that the pipeline was not in "the public good," despite projected jobs and tax revenue. When civic goals conflict, such as promoting economic prosperity, defending property rights and protecting the environment, lawyers must look beyond partisan biases. They must ask relevant questions, such as whether "the public good" includes future generations' interests, and rely on the Constitution and legal precedent for

answers. Only by using clear-headed reasoning, and rejecting stubborn political tribalism, can these kinds of diverse alliances arise to fight for justice.

Honest commitment to the rule of law not only unites otherwise diverse groups, but it can also foster understanding for opposing viewpoints. Through my professional experience in education, I have learned the importance of grounding politically fraught discussions in empathy. Two years ago, when I was asked to teach a unit on the history and ethics of abortion, I was understandably nervous. Leading high school girls in a discussion on abortion was sure to be fraught, particularly in a Catholic school with a mostly progressive student body. So, I opened the unit by exploring why this issue is uniquely divisive in politics. The right to bodily autonomy and the right to life are two of the most important, intimate human rights. However, those same rights seem diametrically opposed to one another when a person faces the choice of abortion. Therefore, abortion is one of the most dramatic moral dilemmas a person can face and a voter can weigh. My goal for the unit was for my students to better understand why someone might hold a view opposed to their own, even if they did not change their own opinion on the topic; through class discussion, my own understanding of the issue deepened.

All lawyers must learn to understand opposing viewpoints, if only for the sake of crafting better legal arguments. For public interest lawyers, this becomes especially crucial, because well-intentioned legal professionals can put their personal moral beliefs ahead of the rule of law and jeopardize their legal integrity.

Lawyers and judges must understand and respect different viewpoints in our pluralistic, hyperpartisan world. At a time when many would rather argue with strawmen, ignore real complexity and isolate themselves against the political Other, students of the law must resolve to hold a higher, more complex loyalty to the founding ideals of our nation, tolerate dissenting opinions that share that loyalty, and fight the rising forces that undermine those ideals. My experiences have prepared me to share this perspective throughout my legal career.

Professional Review by Ivy League Stories

Aaron’s essay is relevant and timely. He discusses a huge issue in law today and makes very clear how highly he holds values and integrity. He then cohesively weaves in his stories and experiences which highlight why he specifically will be an asset in the classroom and beyond.

Many people can name the political division in our country as a problem, but Aaron stands out through his anecdotes. This makes the problem feel much more real. The story about conservative farmers and environmentalists coming together to protest against eminent domain fortifies his argument that when hyperpartisanship is rejected, “diverse alliances arise to [effectively] fight for justice”

Furthermore, Aaron’s story on teaching Catholic school students a unit on abortion provides another personal experience - this time portraying his capacity for empathy, growth, and humility. He navigates an almost impossible situation by leading with empathy, and allowing his students to “better understand why someone might hold a view opposed to their own,” which is the kind of moral patience and open-mindedness that law demands. He is also deeply reflective, showing readers that he was also able to learn from this experience, a great trait for any student.

Aaron directly links his life experiences to law and concludes his essay speaking about the increasing need for nuance, complexity, and empathy in the world. Then he beautifully includes a call to action, emphasizing that it is the responsibility of law students to bring these values forth, and how his experiences have qualified him to do so.

It is critical to note that this essay excels because it does not just argue for Aaron’s admission, but also shares his ideology for what values should inform the law, and how he has personally lived them out.

Daniel's Essay

Successful Harvard Law School Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/successful-harvard-law-school-essays-2025
Essay #: 2

Prompt

This essay responds to the following prompt: The Admissions Committee makes every effort to understand who you are as an individual and potential Harvard Law School student and graduate. Please share how your experiences, background, and/or interests have shaped you and will shape your engagement in the HLS community and the legal profession.

Essay

In the spring of my junior year, the Union-Philanthropic Literary Society (UPLS), a 234-year-old organization at Hampden-Sydney College, elected me its president. The position came with several prescribed roles: preside over weekly debates in a black robe on a nineteenth-century throne, appoint members as officers, and plan the Society's numerous social events. Informally, however, it also required that I ensure that the tone of the Society's proceedings accord with its values of "truth, virtue, and friendship," and it has been this part of the work that has proven the most challenging, rewarding, and instructive for how I will pursue my career in law.

When I joined UPLS, its leaders impressed upon me the importance of these values and exemplified most of them. They modeled friendship by getting to know all the members, and they were always available to work on my speeches for the next debate. The President in particular helped me grow intellectually by subjecting my beliefs to the level of scrutiny that truth ought to withstand. At the same time, however, I saw instances of alcohol-fueled behavior within the Society that resulted in hard words and broken relationships. The Society, like the rest of campus, revolved around binge drinking. Though the leadership had inherited rather than created this culture, and though they made progress in changing it, old organizations turn slowly. When they graduated and I was elected President, I understood that it was now up to me to shape the Society's culture and continue its tradition of academic and personal mentorship.

One way I do so involves our debates. UPLS meets every Sunday to debate a topic (often a hot-button issue), and members are cumulatively responsible for presenting at least six

speeches on it. To prepare members for these speeches, I work with them on ideas, listen to and critique practice speeches, and help them formulate what they think to be true rather than what will win the argument. We go over charitable interpretation, what to do with one's hands while speaking, how to vary tone and pacing to avoid sounding monotonous, and many other forensic techniques. I work to direct the entire enterprise toward the truth, which UPLS has shown me can be approached by presenting the strongest possible argument for a variety of positions in the context of reasoned debate.

I spend more of my time, however, in academic and personal mentorship. I frequently review papers and talk through ideas for assignments with other members, either during my tutoring hours or while shooting pool in the student center. I helped my roommate, a sophomore involved in the Society, overcome his habit of procrastinating by planning out his weeks to get work done earlier with time to review it with others. Under my mentorship, another member who came into the Society with beliefs based on a few disturbing internet subcultures has since begun to read broadly and integrate his beliefs into the broader culture. I have encouraged the other leaders of the Society to make themselves similarly available, and I see the positive influence we have had as friends on the other members.

Finally, I have been working to address the Society's outstanding problems with alcohol. I wanted the Society to look different from the rest of campus, to be an environment where people could be comfortable not drinking at all or drinking in moderation. Since my election, I have organized a variety of non-alcohol-related events ranging from croquet tournaments on the front lawn to late-night poker games. When the Society does serve drinks, I step in when someone begins to binge. The goal is to make the culture one of moderate consumption where abstinence is acceptable and thereby to influence the conduct of the Society's members for the better. In my tenure, I have had considerable success.

As my graduation approaches, I hope to continue my education in a field that revolves around advocacy, honest reformulation, and collaborative exertion—law. Though I do not know in what area of law I want to work, only that I am attracted to litigation, I know that UPLS has shaped my choices of law school and made me value excellence. I intend to be part of HLS's intellectual community that teaches its students to be not just on the winning team but on the right side of issues. I want to join a community like HLS that comes closer to the truth by engaging with different perspectives respectfully, and I intend to be a voice that values other views and encourages similar behavior in others. I also hope to be the person who others can come to for a citation, counterargument, or

cheering up. In short, I want to bring a little bit of UPLS to HLS, where I will continue to pursue truth, virtue, and friendship on my path to a career in law.

Professional Review by Austin LSAT Prep

Daniel has not selected a specific area of law to pursue, and he knows only that he is attracted to litigation. He cannot tell Harvard Law School what he hopes to achieve as a lawyer, so his challenge is to present a persuasive case for why he, Daniel, will be a worthy addition to HLS and the legal profession.

The strategy that Daniel successfully employs for his Personal Statement is to describe a life experience applicable in the field of law as compelling evidence that he will be an excellent lawyer.

Wisely, Daniel does not simply remind HLS that he was elected president of a venerable student organization, impressive as that may be. Instead, he honestly describes a difficult situation that he addressed: society members were engaging in harmful drinking behaviors, which he believes undermines the ideals ("truth, virtue, and friendship") that made the institution special.

Sometimes illegal and/or unethical behaviors or practices permeate an organization so completely that they are accepted as unchangeable. As an officer of the law, a lawyer must be willing to take action and provide ethical guidance. Daniel not only demonstrates personal integrity but also his ability to lead others to uproot the deeply embedded binge drinking culture.

Daniel also describes his experience in debate, a desirable skill for an attorney, and his mentorship. However, his clear-eyed recognition of a situation harmful to his organization and his willingness to take decisive action as a leader is what makes him stand out to HLS.

Grace Elizabeth's Essay

Successful Harvard Law School Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/successful-harvard-law-school-essays-2025
Essay #: 3

Prompt

This essay responds to the following prompt: The Admissions Committee makes every effort to understand who you are as an individual and potential Harvard Law School student and graduate. Please share how your experiences, background, and/or interests have shaped you and will shape your engagement in the HLS community and the legal profession.

Essay

“Welcome! My name is Grace, and I will be taking care of y’all this evening.” The first time I uttered those words, I had no idea the impact they would have on my life. I was 18 when I started working at my hometown’s most famous restaurant. Unbeknownst to me, working as a waitress was about to radically shift my perspective.

I will never forget the first time I walked into the kitchen. My favorite restaurant was no longer a sliver of paradise; it was as if a veil had suddenly been lifted. The thermometer read 118 degrees. Men and women were hollering at each other in a language I did not understand. Some people glared at me, others smiled, and some did not seem to take any notice of my presence at all. I felt like a deer in the headlights. I was no longer the young girl sitting on the patio at table 5. I became just another part of a well-oiled machine. Anyone who has worked in a restaurant can understand how crazy and hectic it can be. Now, imagine that environment in a language you don’t speak. How do you communicate “avocado allergy” to someone who doesn’t speak the same language?

I quickly adapted, picking up some Spanish phrases here and there and eventually making friends with many of the Spanish-speaking people in the kitchen. Waitressing was difficult work, but I soon began to love it. I have worked there seasonally for three years now. I am not the same person today that I was when I started, primarily because of an event that took place my first summer.

The sun was inescapable, the wind was nonexistent, and the humidity was stifling— it was uncharacteristically hot, even for late July in Texas. I was working on the outdoor patio,

and when I wasn't frantically re-filling customers' glasses with water, I was in the bussing station chugging my water bottle and trying to avoid the scorching Texas heat that was draining energy from me minute by minute. I was working alongside a busboy named Carlos, who could not have been more than 16 or 17. He was very thin, jumpy, and

did not speak any English. As I walked into the kitchen to check on the status of my table's fajitas, I heard a huge commotion. Whether it was from heat exhaustion, dehydration, or a combination of the two, Carlos had collapsed. I heard someone yell out, "Call an ambulance!" The managers rushed in to assess the situation and call for help when suddenly, a dishwasher - who I would later recognize as Carlos's uncle - burst into the kitchen. "No!", he exclaimed, "No llames a los paramédicos". The managers tried changing his mind, but the man was unrelenting.

The realization hit me as hard as the Texas sun beat down: Carlos couldn't be helped. He was undocumented, and calling for help could put him at risk of deportation. It was later shared with me that the young boy fled from El Salvador to the United States that very summer, escaping life in gangs. While I was there making some pocket money, young Carlos was there to survive. I realized that there was an entire class of people - undocumented immigrants - living in the shadows of American society, people working to make a better living for themselves, out of necessity and not for pocket change. It was humbling to realize my lack of understanding.

Waitressing has taught me valuable skills: multitasking, effective communication, time management, and customer service, all while honing my ability to remain calm and composed in a fast-paced environment. But when I reflect on my time as a waitress, those skills are not what come to mind. Instead, I think about the people I have worked with. I think about the dishwasher who could not afford to take a few days off work following the death of his sick mother. I think about the bartender who works two shifts a day, seven days a week, 52 weeks a year, in order to send money back to his family in Mexico. I think about the busboy who had to repeat his freshman year of high school because he did not have enough time to complete his homework between shifts. I think about the bar-back who spends every holiday by himself because he has no family in the States. Finally, I think about Carlos.

My relationships with these people have made me aware of the privileges that I took for granted every day, namely, being born on American soil. My experience as a waitress has made me realize that I want to go to law school to learn how I might do whatever possible to help people: whether it be immigrants like Carlos or anyone in need. I believe that the legal profession provides a powerful platform for advocating for justice and equality, and

I am committed to using my education and skills to make a meaningful difference in the lives of those who are often marginalized and underserved. Through law school, I intend to not only gain the knowledge necessary for this endeavor but also to continue building the empathy and understanding that have been fostered by my time as a waitress.

Professional Review by LSATMax

Details, details, details.

If we could sum-up Grace Elizabeth's essay in just three words, that would be it. This story is vivid. The reader can sense the heat of the kitchen, hear the yells of restaurant workers, and feel the sense of urgency among the characters. This is a great example of "show, don't tell" when writing.

But this wasn't just a random hook to catch the readers' attention, either, this story led to real character growth and motivation to become a lawyer. Grace Elizabeth was accepted to Harvard Law because her personal narrative demonstrates a rare combination of emotional intelligence, humility, and moral clarity—qualities essential for the study and practice of law. Rather than relying on flashy achievements or name-dropping credentials, she uses a deeply human story to illustrate her growing awareness of systemic inequality, particularly regarding undocumented immigrants. Her ability to recognize privilege, empathize across language and cultural barriers, and respond with a desire to act, not just reflect, sets her apart.

The icing on the cake is that all of this connects to her interest in the law. This is what makes it a strong law school personal statement—connecting a personal story to the motivation to study law. This "formula" gives the complete picture of you as an applicant.

In the end, this essay succeeds because the author frames her experiences not as obstacles or resume-builders, but as opportunities to learn, to listen, and to grow. Admissions committees look for applicants who not only recognize such moments but also seize them and reflect meaningfully on their significance. The essay captures that perfectly.

Kevin's Essay

Successful Harvard Law School Essays (2025)
Source: https://business.thecrimson.com/successful-harvard-law-school-essays-2025
Essay #: 4

Prompt

This essay responds to the following prompt: What motivates you to pursue law? How does attending law school align with your ambitions, goals, and vision for your future?

Essay

I sit in the center of a pine table, blissfully unaware. Before me is a baseball, a gold coin, a pencil, and a computer mouse. “Choose one,” my dad beckons. Stumbling over the hem of my hanbok, I make my way forward. After a pause, I grab the mouse, and whispers fill the room: “He’ll be just like his dad!”

Every so often, my parents fondly recall my doljabi, a Korean tradition where one-year-old babies choose their “fate” among objects symbolizing different careers on their first birthday (often reflections of their parents’ wishful dreams for them). The computer mouse was my dad’s own touch, a sci-fi-loving tech nerd, whose Lego-building skills and Star Wars fanaticism I adopted even by age four. Following in his footsteps, I entered college undeterred in my goal to be a software engineer just like him.

My first semester brimmed with naive excitement, as I eagerly completed every bonus project in my computer science class and even taught myself advanced programming concepts. However, as the late-night talks with my hallmates about our aspirations faded into a mere memory, I found myself habitually watching the news, searching for hope amid the uncertainty brought by the pandemic. Instead, I saw a country wrought with health inequities, politicized misinformation, and violent acts of discrimination, and an overwhelming urgency to redress them stirred within me. Though I donated to important causes and educated myself, I felt increasingly powerless with each passing day, distant from suffering communities as I was sheltered from their pain by my TV screen.

On March 16, 2021, just a few miles from my campus home, a horrific shooting of Atlanta spas killed eight innocent bystanders, most of whom looked like me. Watching the evening news, I wrestled with a sobering mix of hopelessness and guilt: What could have prevented this? It could have just as easily been me. Upon sharing my reflections, I was

met with my dad's oft-quoted Korean proverb: "Jin Insa Dae Cheonmyeong" or "Fate ultimately decides, but man does what he can." The once encouraging words no longer felt acceptable though; I couldn't bring myself to leave this tragedy up to "fate."

The next day, while learning about sorting algorithms in my computer science class, I began to see a disconnect between my academic spaces and reality, and wondered how my education could help me respond to issues of equity and justice. When the Stop Asian Hate movement gained traction, I received a stern warning from my family to not attend the rallies and avoid causing controversy. Rather than passively enduring injustices, I wanted to redirect the generational Korean perseverance I inherited into proactively addressing them. The following Sunday, my pastor offered thoughts and prayers, but refrained from further action in order to remain "apolitical." Although I felt disheartened by his neutral stance, I was also motivated to find ways to apply the principles of my faith, helping others in practice.

As these environments formed core aspects of my identity, I held doubts about my capacity to create change, unable to shake the sense that the voices around me rang against my own. However, I noticed that whenever hardship arose, lawyers were the first to respond. Curious as to whether I too could have a tangible impact in a legal career, I interned with my local district attorney's office. On my first day, I was assigned to research the militancy of "sovereign citizen" movements. While the task initially seemed trivial, I was later told that my analysis convinced the presiding judge that an armed sovereign citizen group marching across the state was a significant flight risk. Though I played a small role alongside the attorneys to protect our community, my familiar feeling of powerlessness had disappeared.

My search for avenues to channel my intellectual curiosity, cultural values, and faith toward serving others has guided my journey in the law. At the start of my third year, I grafted a new major into my academic focus that finally allowed me to explore fundamental normative questions, deepening my philosophical understanding of the law and its capacity to address our technologically driven future. Interning for a legal nonprofit, I attended criminal court daily and saw firsthand the responsibility of lawyers to zealously advocate for their clients and community, never feigning passive indifference to clear suffering. Now, as a legal assistant for a state court, I serve individuals who turn to the law as their last hope: some barred from employment due to their criminal pasts, others burdened by a lack of financial support for their children. Empathizing with their stories through our conversations, I have realized that the law is also a powerful instrument of the grace integral to my faith, giving a second chance to those who

desperately need it. In these ways, my legal career thus far has enabled me to act beyond the perceived limits of my identity, equipping me to address the suffering I see. However, the most meaningful thing I have gained is hope, a hope grounded in the idea that my choices, rather than my fate, are the driving force in creating a more just world, even if I didn't pick up a gavel on my first birthday.

Professional Review by The Harvard Crimson

Harvard Law School's Statement of Purpose is a two page opportunity to highlight your potential — beyond what test scores and resume lines say. Kevin accomplishes this with exemplary storytelling. Throughout his essay, not only does Kevin depict his character, but he also demonstrates his efficacy.

Kevin's story follows a clear trajectory. After a compelling hook, he smoothly introduces himself, sprinkling important details about his background which add depth to his profile. Then we reach the peak of the story: the internal conflict Kevin experiences caused by the clash of his traditional lifestyle and values with his empathy and responsiveness to the state of the world. After this climax, Kevin brings the story to its conclusion as he resolves the conflict. The key to his emotional resolution? His empowerment and the impact he has through legal work. Kevin neatly completes his story by cleverly connecting his opening hook back to his concluding sentence. The contrast between the beginning sentence and ending conclusion demonstrate his personal growth and reflection.

Honing further into the success of Kevin's essay: how he writes about his internal conflict demonstrates his connection to family, academic prowess, and determined disposition. In the third paragraph we learn how Kevin succeeds in his original intellectual pursuit. We later discover Kevin's nature for empathy as he narrates his internal conflict when viewing the political climate. Instead of acknowledging this and moving on, Kevin changes. He acts to resolve his conflict, which highlights his can-and-will-do attitude. Kevin illustrates specific moments and accomplishments from his experiences exploring the legal field, backing up his passion for law with substantial evidence of excellence.

Overall, Kevin's narrative is so compelling because he describes a reciprocal relationship, where both the legal field and the person positively impact each other. Kevin creates a beautiful and complete narrative in this story. He clearly explains why he is passionate about law while delivering evidence of his actionable character and academic prowess. And he manages to appeal to a widespread struggle we all share while also making it

sound intricately unique: the dilemma between balancing your past with thinking of your future.

Successful Harvard College Essays (2024)

9 essays

Sarika's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2024)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2024/
Essay #: 1

Essay

I, Too, Can Dance

I was in love with the way the dainty pink mouse glided across the stage, her tutu twirling as she pirouetted and her rose-colored bow following the motion of her outstretched arms with every grand jeté.

I had always dreamed I would dance, and Angelina Ballerina made it seem so easy. There was something so freeing about the way she wove her body into the delicate threads of the Sugar Plum Fairy's song each time she performed an arabesque. I longed for my whole being to melt into the magical melodies of music; I longed to enchant the world with my own stories; and I longed for the smile that glimmered on every dancer's face.

At recess, my friends and I would improvise dances. But while they seemed well on their way to achieving ballerina status, my figure eights were more like zeroes and every attempt at spinning around left me feeling dizzy. Sometimes, I even ran over my friends' toes. How could I share my stories with others if I managed to injure them with my wheelchair before the story even began?

I then tried piano, but my fingers stumbled across the keys in an uncoordinated staccato tap dance of sorts. I tried art, but the clumsiness of my brush left the canvas a colorful mess. I tried the recorder, but had Angelina existed in real life, my rendition of "Mary Had a Little Lamb" would have frozen her in midair, with flute-like screeches tumbling through the air before ending in an awkward split and shattering the gossamer world the Sugar Plum Fairy had worked so hard to build.

For as long as I could remember, I'd also been fascinated by words, but I'd never explored writing until one day in fourth grade, the school librarian announced a poetry contest. That night, as I tried to sleep, ideas scampered through my head like Nutcracker mice awakening a sleeping Clara to a mystical new world. By morning, I had choreographed the mice to tell a winning story in verse about all the marvelous outer space factoids I knew.

Now, my pencil pirouettes perfect O's on paper amidst sagas of doting mothers and evanescent lovers. The tip of my pen stipples the lines of my notebook with the tale of a

father's grief, like a ballerina tiptoeing en pointe; as the man finds solace in nature, the ink flows gracefully, and for a moment, it leaps off the page, as if reaching out to the heavens to embrace his daughter's soul. Late at night, my fingers tap dance across the keys of my laptop, tap tap tapping an article about the latest breakthrough in cancer research—maybe LDCT scans or aneuploidy-targeted therapy could have saved the daughter's life; a Spanish poem about the beauty of unspoken moments; and the story of a girl in a wheelchair who learned how to dance.

As the world sleeps, I lose myself in the cathartic cadences of fresh ink, bursting with stories to be told and melting into parched paper. I cobble together phrases until they spring off my tongue, as if the Sugar Plum Fairy herself has transformed the staccato rumblings of my brain into something legato and sweet. I weave my heart, my soul, my very being into my words as I read them out loud, until they become almost like a chant. With every rehearsal, I search for the perfect finale to complete my creation. When I finally find it, eyes dry with midnight-induced euphoria, I remember that night so many years ago when I discovered the magic of writing, and smile.

I may not dance across the stage like Angelina Ballerina, but I can dance across the page.

I, too, can dance.

Professional Review by The Ivy Institute

In this essay "I, Too, Can Dance," Sarika skillfully describes how she went from wanting to dance like the made-up character Angelina Ballerina to discovering deep fulfillment and a way to express herself via writing. The essay opens with a detailed account of Sarika's early fascination in dance, which was sparked by the animated performances she saw on television. However, we learn that her first attempts to mimic these dancing routines are hampered by her physical constraints in a wheelchair, which complicates and frustrates her young goals.

Despite these difficulties, Sarika's story is full of tenacity and originality. Her experiences with other artistic mediums, such as painting and piano, follow a similar pattern of initial enthusiasm followed by an awareness of her physical limitations. However, these endeavors are presented as stepping stones, each one strengthening her drive and guiding her in the direction of a field in which she may genuinely succeed.

When Sarika discovers writing, her story takes a dramatic turn. This realization is not just a solace but also a victorious discovery of her voice. Writing takes on the role of her dance floor, where words enable her to move gracefully, telling tales and articulating concepts

with the same grace and fluidity that performers display on stage. Sarika describes her writing process using dance-related imagery, such as her pencil "pirouettes" and her narratives "leaping off the page," effectively drawing comparisons between dance and writing.

Sarika's profound reflection and her mature realization that artistic expression can take numerous forms are what make her essay so moving. She conveys a strong message about accepting one's abilities and exploring many avenues for artistic expression. By the time the essay comes to an end, Sarika has come to terms with her destiny and even begun to like it. She finds happiness in the rhythmic tapping of her keyboard late into the night, creating stories that have the grace and complexity of a dance that has been expertly choreographed.

Francisco's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2024)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2024/
Essay #: 2

Essay

Three days before I got on a plane to go across the country for six weeks I quit milk cold-turkey. I had gone to the chiropractor to get a general check up. I knew I had scoliosis and other problems; however, I learned that because of my excessive, to say the least, intake of milk my body had developed a hormone imbalance. I decided it would be best for my health to completely stop drinking milk and avoid dairy when possible. Little did I know, this was only the start of a summer of change; three days later I got on a plane to attend the Minority Introduction To Engineering and Science (MITES) program in Massachusetts.

I assumed that most of the people were going to be unhealthily competitive because of my past experiences. I thought I would keep to myself, do my work, and come back no different. Living in a building with 80 people I've never met in a place I've never been while making a significant life style change was not easy. The first few days were not kind: I got mild stomach ulcers, it was awkward, and I felt out of place. That first Thursday night however, all of that started to change. On Thursday evenings we had "Family Meetings" and on this particular Thursday part of our Machine Learning class was working together when the time came to go to the dining hall for whatever this "Family Meeting" was. Honestly we dreaded it at first, "I have work to do" was the most common phrase. We learned that "Family Meeting" was a safe space for us to talk about anything and everything. Today's theme was, "what's something important about your identity that makes you unique?" but the conversation quickly evolved into so much more. People spoke about losing family members, being shunned at home, not feeling comfortable in their own skin, and more. So many people opened up about incredibly personal things, I felt honored to be given that trust. The room was somber and warm with empathy as the meeting concluded. Out of my peripheral vision I saw Izzy, one of my Machine Learning classmates, rushing back to the conference room. I realized something was not right. Instinctively, I followed her back to where we were working. Izzy sat down and immediately broke down, the rest of us filed in as she started to talk about what was wrong. It felt as though an ambulance was sitting on my chest, my breaths were short and stingy. I was afraid; afraid my support wouldn't be good enough, afraid to show that I

cared, afraid they didn’t care for me. In this one moment all my insecurities, some I didn’t even know I had, came to the surface. The heavy silence of hushed sobbing was broken by an outpouring of support and a hug. We all started sharing what we’re going through and even some of our past trauma. Slowly that weight is lifted off my chest. I feel comfortable, I feel wanted, I feel safe.

This is the first time I truly felt confident, empowered, and loved. I am surrounded by people smarter than me and I don’t feel any lesser because of it. I have become the true Francisco, or Cisco as they call me. I now, at all times, am unapologetically myself. The difference is night and day. As the program progressed I only felt more comfortable and safe, enough so to even go up and speak at a family meeting. These people, this family, treated me right. I gained priceless confidence, social skills, self-worth, empathetic ability, and mental fortitude to take with me and grow on for the rest of my life. Through all of this somehow cutting out the biggest part of my diet became the least impactful part of my summer.

Professional Review by The Ivy Institute

Francisco's essay, "Three Days Before I Got on a Plane," describes his involvement in the Minority Introduction to Engineering and Science (MITES) program at M.I.T., which serves as the backdrop for his introspective voyage. The story starts with a seemingly minor decision—giving up milk for health reasons—but it soon turns into a metaphor for the life-changing events that transpire. The essay skillfully makes use of this internal transformation to set up a summer that would fundamentally alter Francisco's perception of himself and his interactions with others. He is first nervous about the MITES program because he anticipates a very competitive setting that would make him feel even more alone. The physical and psychological difficulties he encounters early in the program—such as minor stomach ulcers and a strong sense of alienation—reinforce this worry.

But at the program's weekly "Family Meetings," which are meant to encourage candid conversation and support among members, the story takes a dramatic turn. Here is when Francisco undergoes a significant transformation. One meeting's theme, "what's something important about your identity that makes you unique?" expands into increasingly detailed, intimate revelations, turning the gathering into an environment of empathy and vulnerability. Francisco is extremely touched by the candor with which his peers have shared their personal issues, and this prompts him to reconsider how he approaches the program and his peers in general.

Francisco's essay does a fantastic job of illustrating how community and candid conversation can have a significant impact on personal development. His experience serves as a testament to both the value of safe spaces in learning environments and the transformational potential of empathy. By the time the essay comes to an end, Francisco has grown as a person and acknowledges that he is now "the true Francisco," or "Cisco" as his friends call him. He highlights how this experience has given him the confidence to be authentically himself and has given him priceless social skills, self-worth, and emotional fortitude that he will use throughout his life.

Although Francisco's essay effectively recounts a transformative summer experience, it could be enhanced by the inclusion of additional personal details and background information to provide a more comprehensive understanding of his life and experiences. Valuable context could be provided by including specifications about his initial interest in engineering and science or his prior experiences with competitiveness. Expanding on how the MITES program influenced his long-term goals would further enhance the essay. Additionally, elaborating on his relationships with peers both before and after the program would offer a clearer picture of his social growth. These additional details would create a more complete and compelling narrative—presenting Francisco as a multifaceted individual.

Lauren's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2024)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2024/
Essay #: 3

Essay

Lunch and recess were opportunities to 'play' Stephen Sondheim's Sweeney Todd, so we murdered our friends. We'd bake the dead into meat pies and scream cacophonously, "WE ALL DESERVE TO DIE!" Nine-year-old me even teased my hair, donned my Mrs. Lovett costume for Halloween, and rambled on about Australian penal colonies and how dead fiddle players make for "stringy" meat. You cannot imagine my disappointment when everybody thought I was Frankenstein's Bride.

Like Gypsy Rose Lee, my siblings and I spent our formative years at rehearsals and performances, where I was indoctrinated into the cult that worships Sondheim. In our household, Sondheimian theatre was a religion (I'm not sure how I feel about God, but I do believe in Sondheim.) My brother and I read Sondheim's autobiography, Finishing the Hat, like the bible, reading the book cover to cover and returning to page one the moment we finished. At six, he introduced me to Sondheim's West Side Story, which illustrates the harms of poverty and systematic racism. Initially, I only appreciated Jerome Robbins' choreography (Sorry, Mr. Shakespeare). When I revisited the musical years later, I had a visceral reaction as I witnessed young adults engaging in deadly gang rivalries. Experiencing Tony's gruesome death forced me, a middle-class suburbanite, to feel the devastating effects of inner-city violence, and my belief in the need for early intervention programs to prevent urban gun violence was born.

I began to discover political and historical undertones in all of Sondheim's work. For example, Assassins whirlwinds from the Lincoln era up to Reagan's Presidency. Originally, I simply thought it was hysterical to belt Lynette Fromme's love ballad to Charles Manson. Later, I realized how much history I had unknowingly retained from this musical. The song "November 22, 1963" reflects on America's most notorious assassination attempts, and alludes to each assassin being motivated by a desperate attempt to connect to a specific individual or culture to gain control over their life. Assassins awakened me to the flaws in some of our quintessential American ideals because the song "Everybody's Got the Right" illustrates how the American individualism enshrined in our Constitution can be twisted to support hate, harm, and entitlement. I

internalized Sondheim's political commentary, and I see its relevance in America's most pressing issues. The misconstrued idea of limitless freedom can be detrimental to public health, worsening issues such as the climate crisis, gun violence, and the coronavirus pandemic. These existential threats largely stem from antiquated ideas that the rights of the few outweigh the rights of the majority. Ironically, a musical about individuals who tried to dismantle our American political system sparked my political interests, but this speaks to the power of Sondheim's music and my ability to make connections and draw inspiration from unlikely sources.

Absorbing historical and political commentary set to music allows my statistical and logical brain to better empathize with the characters, giving me a deeper understanding of the conflicts portrayed on stage, almost like reading a diary. Theatremakers are influenced by both history and their life experiences. I internalize their underlying themes and values, and my mindset shifts to reflect the art that I adore. I'm an aspiring political changemaker, and Sondheim's musicals influence my political opinions by enabling me to empathize with communities living drastically different lives from my own.

I sang Sondheim melodies before I could talk. As I grew intellectually and emotionally, Sondheim's musicals began to carry more weight. With each viewing, I retained new historical and political information. This ritual drives me to continue studying Sondheim and enables me to confidently walk my own path because Sondheim's work passively strengthens my ethics as I continue to extrapolate relevant life lessons from his melodies. Sondheim's stories, with their complex, morally ambiguous characters, have solidified my ironclad set of morals which, together with my love of history, have blossomed into a passion for human rights and politics.

Professional Review by Admission Science

Lauren's essay has punch. From the first line, where she's gleefully "murdering" friends in a Sweeney Todd-themed recess game, you're hooked. This isn't your average personal essay; it's a wild ride through a Sondheim-obsessed childhood. One where "theatre was a religion" and Finishing the Hat was the bible.

What makes this essay stand out is Lauren's unabashed passion. She doesn't just like musicals. West Side Story actually gave her visceral reactions that shaped her intellectual growth. Lauren describes how the political context of those musicals ignited her passion for social justice. She also reveals a mind that's both analytical and creative, connecting historical anthems to modern-day issues like gun violence and the pandemic.

This is something we always encourage students to do—let your passion shine. Your college essay is the best place to let your authentic voice through. So be sure to pick a topic you're truly invested in. That passion will be contagious, and it will leave a lasting impression on the reader.

Lauren also did an excellent job of maintaining a relatable and endearing tone ("I'm not sure how I feel about God, but I do believe in Sondheim"). She successfully tied her passion for Sondheim's work to her aspiration to become a political changemaker. This alignment of passion and purpose is compelling and is ultimately what makes her a strong candidate for Harvard.

Daniella's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2024)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2024/
Essay #: 4

Essay

Each time I bake cookies, they come out differently. Butter, sugar, eggs, flour — I measure with precision, stir with vigor, then set the oven to 375°F. The recipe is routine, yet hardly redundant.

After a blizzard left me stranded indoors with nothing but a whisk and a pantry full of the fundamentals, I made my first batch: a tray of piping hot chocolate chunkers whose melt-in-the-mouth morsels comforted my snowed-in soul. Such a flawless description, however, belies my messy process. In reality, my method was haphazard and carefree, the cookies a delicious fortuity that has since been impossible to replicate.

Each subsequent batch I make is a gamble. Will the cookies flatten and come out crispy? Stay bulbous and gooey? Am I a bad baker, or are they inherently capricious? Even with a recipe book full of suggestions, I can never place a finger on my mistake. The cookies are fickle and short-tempered. Baking them is like walking on eggshells — and I have an empty egg carton to prove it. Perhaps beginner's luck had been the secret ingredient all along.

Yet, curiosity keeps me flipping to the same page in my recipe book. I became engrossed in perfecting the cookies not by the mechanical satisfaction of watching ingredients combine into batter, but by the chance to wonder at simplicity. The inconsistency is captivating. It is, after all, a strict recipe, identical ingredients combined in the same permutation. How can such orthodox steps yield such radical, unpredictable results? Even with the most formulaic tasks, I am questioning the universe.

Chemistry explains some of the anomaly. For instance, just a half-pinch extra of baking soda can have astounding ramifications on how the dough bubbles. The kitchen became my laboratory: I diaried each trial like a scientist; I bought a scale for more accurate measurements; I borrowed "On Food and Cooking: the Science and Lore of the Kitchen" from the library. But all to no avail — the variables refused to come together in any sort of equilibrium.

I then approached the problem like a pianist, taking the advice my teacher wrote in the margins of my sheet music and pouring it into the mixing bowl. There are 88 pitches on a keyboard, and there are a dozen ingredients in the recipe. To create a rhapsodic dessert, I needed to understand all of the melodic and harmonic lines and how they complemented one another. I imagined the recipe in Italian script, the chocolate chips as quick staccatos suspended in a thick adagio medium. But my fingers always stumbled at the coda of each performance, the details of the cookies turning to a hodgepodge of sound.

I whisk, I sift, I stir, I pre-heat the oven again, but each batch has its flaws, either too sweet, burnt edges, grainy, or underdone. Though the cookies were born of boredom, their erratic nature continues to fascinate me. Each time my efforts yield an imperfect result, I develop resilience to return the following week with a fresh apron, ready to try again. I am mesmerized by the quirks of each trial. It isn't enough to just mix and eat — I must understand.

My creative outlook has kept the task engaging. Despite the repetition in my process, I find new angles that liven the recipe. In college and beyond, there will be things like baking cookies, endeavors that seem so unvaried they risk spoiling themselves to a housewife's drudgery. But from my time in the kitchen, I have learned how to probe deeper into the mechanics of my tasks, to bring music into monotony, and to turn work into play. However the cookie crumbles in my future, I will approach my work with curiosity, creativity, and earnestness.

Professional Review by EssayEdge

Daniella's essay is lovely, fun and effective. It genuinely and naturally showcases different sides of her, how she approaches problems, what she values. The mundaneness of the topic fits her conclusion and insights beautifully. She employs humor, shows resilience, creativity, intellectual curiosity and an authentic propensity for philosophical thought. Her "voice" is confident, the word choice creative, and the vocabulary in each paragraph poignantly reflects different sides of her (the scientist "diared each trial"; the musician tries to create a "rhapsodic dessert").

The several paragraphs detailing Daniella's cookie making process are also very strong. She lingers with sensual details that resonate (you can smell, taste and feel those chocolate chunkers) rather than overstuffing the essay with mentions of her various credentials or experiences. This structure is bold, and humble. It allows Daniella to show rather than tell the reader how she thinks, how she solves problems, how she perseveres. This is very powerful.

This essay measures 618 words (standard limit is 650). Daniella could have used the additional words to add to paragraph 3: when else did she experienced that similar processes lead to different results – perhaps in music performance? And/or in the next paragraph(s) she might have added a sentence to consider the potential impact of atmospheric conditions on baking, as well as more broadly/metaphorically.

Clara's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2024)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2024/
Essay #: 5

Essay

My nightstand is home to a small menagerie of critters, each glass-eyed specimen lovingly stuffed with cotton. Don't get the wrong idea, now – I'm not a taxidermist or anything. I crochet.

Crochet is a family tradition. My grandmother used to wield her menacing steel hook like a mage's staff and tout it as such: an instrument that bestowed patience, decorum, and poise on its owner. During her youth in Vietnam, she spent her evenings designing patterns for ornate doilies and handkerchiefs. Then the Vietnam War turned our family into refugees. The Viet Cong imprisoned my grandfather, a colonel in the South Vietnam Air Force, in a grueling labor camp for thirteen years. Many wives would have lost hope, but my grandmother was no average woman. A literature professor in a time when women's access to education was limited, she assumed the role of matriarch with wisdom and confidence, providing financial and emotional security. As luxuries like yarn grew scarce, she conjured up all sorts of useful household items – durable pillowcases, blankets, and winter coats – and taught my mother to do the same. Because of these bitter wartime memories, she wanted my handiwork to be of a decidedly less practical bent; among the first objects she taught me to crochet were chrysanthemums and roses. However, making flowers bloom from yarn was no easy task.

Even with its soft plastic grip and friendly rounded edges, my first crochet hook had a mind of its own, like the enchanted broom in "The Sorcerer's Apprentice." It stubbornly disobeyed my orders as I impatiently wrenched it through the yarn. My grandmother's stern appraisal of my efforts often interrupted this perpetual tug-of-war: My stitches were uneven. The edges curled inward. I would unravel my work and start anew.

I convinced myself that cobbling together a lopsided rectangle would be the pinnacle of my crochet prowess but refused to give up. Just as a diligent wizard casts more advanced spells over time, I learned to channel the magic of the crochet hook. The animal kingdom is my main source of inspiration; the diversity and vivid pigmentation of life on Earth lend themselves perfectly to the vibrant and versatile art of crochet. Many of the animals I make embark on migratory journeys, like their real-life counterparts. Take Agnes, for

example, a cornflower-blue elephant named after mathematician Maria Gaetana Agnesi who lives in my calculus teacher's classroom, happily grazing on old pencil shavings and worksheets. As I fasten off the final stitches on every creature, I hope to weave a little whimsy and color into someone's life.

Each piece I finish reminds me of the network of stitches that connects mother and daughter, past and present, tradition and innovation. In this vast cultural web, I am proud to be my family's link between East and West. As I prepare for adulthood, I am eager to weave my own mark into the great patchwork quilt that is America.

Professional Review by PrepMaven

Clara's essay seamlessly integrates her voice, family history, and current character into a moving and effective narrative. Here's how:

She starts with a perfect opening. Through vivid, specific word choice (a nightstand of "glass-eyed specimens"), the essay showcases Clara's voice and humor ("not a taxidermist"). At the same time, this essay quickly introduces the subject: crocheting.

The essay then "zooms out" to raise the stakes. Crocheting isn't just a hobby: it's a tradition that sustained Clara's family through the Vietnam War. While Clara mentions the brutal reality of her family's experiences, she quickly returns the focus to herself. It's something many students forget: whatever your past struggles, your essay must be about you now.

The essay then gives us insight into her character. Clara won't be deterred by failure, won't quit because something's tough. By focusing on her attempts to improve her crocheting skills, Clara displays the maturity, perseverance, and self-awareness often missing from application essays.

And Clara's essay sticks the landing. We teach students to bridge past, present, and future in their essays. Clara does that: writing about crocheting allows Clara to end with a sophisticated discussion of how her family's history informs not just her current life, but her future college goals.

Orlee's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2024)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2024/
Essay #: 6

Essay

I'm hiding behind the swing door of the dressing room when I text my mom just one word: "Traumatizing!" I'm on a bra-shopping expedition with my grandmother, and just in case it's not abundantly clear, this trip was Not. My. Idea. Bra shopping has always been shrouded in mystery for me, and growing up in a household with two moms and two younger sisters hasn't helped one bit: One of my moms doesn't wear bras; the other proudly proclaims that her bras are older than me. A two-mom family without the faintest idea what a teenage girl needs—par for the course around here.

So when my 78-year-old grandmother volunteered to take me bra shopping, my moms jumped at the chance. Here I was with my frugal grandmother, outlet-shopping among the racks of intimates that aren't sized quite right, that have too much padding or too little…You can see my predicament, and it's no surprise that my younger self was confused by the words "wire-free," "concealing petals," "balconette."

The saleswoman called to my grandmother from across the store, "What cup size is she?"

"I don't know," my grandmother screamed back. "Can you measure her?"

Measure me? They have got to be kidding.

"I just don't want her to feel different," I heard my grandmother say later that day. "Kids this age can be so mean."

I love my grandmother, but she believes the world is harsh and unforgiving, and she thinks that the only path to happiness is fitting in. My grandmother had taken me bra shopping in a last-ditch attempt to make me "normal" because I was entering 9th grade at Deerfield in a few weeks, and she worried that I would stick out worse than the underwire of a bargain basement bra.

It's true—I'm not your typical Deerfield student. I'm a day student with lesbian moms who have several fewer zeros on their bank account balance than typical Deerfield parents. I'm the kid with a congenital foot deformity, which means I literally can't run, who will never be able to sprint across campus from classroom to classroom. I'm the kid

with life-threatening food allergies to milk and tree nuts who can't indulge in the pizza at swim team celebrations or the festive cake and ice cream during advisory meetings.

But fitting in was my grandmother's worry, not mine. What my grandmother didn't consider is that there's no single way to fit in. I might be two minutes later to class than the sprinters, but I always arrive. I might have to explain to my friends what "having two moms" means, but I'll never stop being thankful that Deerfield students are eager to lean in and understand. I may not be able to eat the food, but you can count on me to show up and celebrate.

While I can't run, I can swim and play water polo, and I can walk the campus giving Admissions tours. My family might not look like everyone else's, but I can embrace those differences and write articles for the school newspaper or give a talk at "School Meeting," sharing my family and my journey. Some of my closest friendships at Deerfield have grown from a willingness on both sides to embrace difference.

On one of the first days of 9th grade, I sat down to write a "Deerfield Bucket List"—a list of experiences that I wanted to have during my four years in high school, including taking a Deerfield international trip and making the Varsity swim team. That list included thirteen items, and I'm eleven-thirteenths of the way there, not because I have the right bra, but because I've embraced the very thing that my grandmother was afraid of. Bra shopping is still shrouded in mystery for me, but I know that I am where I should be, I'm doing work that matters to me, and fitting in rarely crosses my mind.

Professional Review by The College Guru

The Common App essay allows you to speak directly to Admissions, in your own voice, sharing important personal attributes and insights into who you are at your core, and demonstrating how you will enrich the college's community. In choosing your topic, it is vitally important to remember that up until now, Admissions will have heard about you from everyone except you. Now, it's your opportunity to shine, bringing your true personality to the forefront and showing how well you will fit in with the incoming class they are building.

Here, we meet Orlee as she is shopping for a bra, accompanied by her doting grandmother. Orlee dives right in, unexpectedly dropping us into an embarrassing, "traumatizing" moment she bravely chose to share. Within a few seconds, we are also introduced to her two self-described fashion-agnostic moms. This is just the first

paragraph and I like her already. With an average of only a few minutes to read each essay, Admissions readers will want to find out where this is headed.

Early on, we learn that Orlee's grandmother's view of the world—"harsh and unforgiving"—makes her protective of Orlee and that her proposed solution is to help Orlee fit in so she will be perceived as "normal." Initially, we think this essay is about teen angst, but in a surprise twist, Orlee quickly lets us know her grandmother's fears about her fitting in are neither unreasonable nor unfounded.

Orlee reveals she has a congenital foot deformity limiting her ability to run and a severe, life-threatening food allergy. Now that she has our attention, she masterfully weaves in additional snapshots of her daily life, demonstrating how she bravely chooses to show up in difficult moments. Her straightforward descriptions are not manipulative, but instead, her outlook is upbeat. We learn about her perseverance and that she is always up for a challenge. She demonstrates how she finds ways to create space for herself so she will be included, and she rightfully doesn't ask for permission or apologize for her physical challenges.

Mindful that others may be quick to put her in a box because of her apparent physical challenges, Orlee immediately focuses us on the many strengths she can contribute on campus, providing several clear illustrations of how she dives right in and overcomes others' negative perceptions. She regales us with the countless ways she has found to enrich her school as a team player, lest we are tempted to fall into the unfortunate trap of underestimating her abilities.

Orlee has set inspiring life goals, and her endearing high school bucket list is nearly complete. This student isn't afraid to go for it and get it. She is simply living her best life, and I find myself cheering for her!

This essay succeeds because it tells us who Orlee is and how she thrives, that she values friends and teammates, and will bring that same energy to her college community. She is intelligent, curious, confident, and kind. She sets her goals and charts her vision to support her worldview. "Fitting in rarely crosses [her] mind." This is her Brand Story and I am here for it!

Marcus' Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2024)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2024/
Essay #: 7
Theme: 'Identity' & 'Overcoming An Obstacle'

Essay

The Zoo

As late afternoon sunlight danced on my shoulders, I squished my eight-year-old face against the glass of the outdoor tank, eyes wide and searching for any signs of life. There! I scrambled from where I was seated, chasing the flickering sight of my prize. The otter darted away from me, his lithe body disappearing into a crack in the stones. I slumped against the wall, disappointed. Ever the HR representative, my mother saw my face and asked me what was wrong. I explained my frustration with the otters -- they're so fun to watch, but they refuse to be seen. My mother leaned down, brushing a long lock of hair out of my face, and told me, "Sometimes, the animals get tired of being watched. They just want to be left alone."

I didn't think much of the otters after that. Until I became one.

In October of my sophomore year, I was four months into my transition from female to male. I wasn't out to my extended family, my wardrobe was a haphazard mess of cargo shorts and skirts, and my voice was still, to my distress, annoyingly high. Being transgender at Middleton High School was no small feat -- I stuck out in a sea of over 2,000 cisgender peers, and most of my teachers did not know how to deal with people "in my situation," as one put it.

One day, as I walked to my bus after school, I heard snickers from behind me. I turned around and saw a rowdy group of boys. One had his phone up, recording me. Everyone was laughing, and in an instant I knew they were laughing at me. I turned and walked away, doing my best to conceal myself from their view. The laughter continued.

I was the star of a humiliating show that I never asked to be a part of. I had become the otter. Their laughs kept ringing in my ears as I sat alone on the bus. I wanted to crawl inside myself and implode rather than think about going back to face them again the next day. My phone kept buzzing, but I refused to check it. It was only when I arrived home and checked those messages that I found that the video had been posted across social

media for hundreds of my peers to see. It seemed like nothing, just a video of me walking, turning, and looking away. But their laughs were clear in the background, and I still understood the point of the video -- look at the freak. Look at the new zoo exhibit.

Seeing that video, I realized that I couldn't allow myself to turn into what they saw me as. They wanted an otter, a punching bag that wouldn't fight back. I was not going to be their otter. The next day, I went to my first Sexuality and Gender Equality club meeting. I spoke to the administration about what had happened. I saved the video and showed people. I took control.

Those boys wanted me to believe that I was merely an exhibit to be laughed at, but now I know I live for greater things. I live for lattes, for courtroom closing arguments, for the pesto I make at work. I live for Black Lives Matter and #enough and Pride. I live for kayaking and summer camp, for the kids in SAGE and my younger sister. My classmates tried to dehumanize me, trample me, and mold me into their image of transgender people. Maybe they'll never see me as an equal, but that is their blindness, not mine. I do not live on display. I do not live in a zoo.

Professional Review by MR. MBA®, Val Misra

Marcus does an excellent job of creating a deeply heartfelt, introspective, and triumphant personal development story in this thought-provoking essay focusing on 'identity' and 'overcoming an obstacle'. It can be risky to discuss two major themes, but he interweaves them flawlessly. Each paragraph stands alone as wonderful insight, written in beautiful creative prose, into Marcus' journey- from childhood confusion (encounter with the otter) to future self-discovery and isolation (he becomes the otter), to self-acceptance and determination (he will not be bullied), and ultimately to victory (his passion and love for his life).

In Paragraphs 1-2, Marcus' individual anecdote on the zoo otter is highly effective to frame the larger discussion of his challenging transition from cisgender to transgender. His mother's wisdom about an otter's reasoning for self-isolation shines brightly, setting the foundation for what is to come. Marcus' self-comparison to the otter he once saw in the zoo intrigues me to read on.

Para 3 effectively highlights the difficulties he endured during his transition in high school- his coming out, his clothing, his high-pitched voice, and academic faculty challenges. These examples help the reader understand his plight.

Para 4-5 depict Marcus' self-realization that he has now become the zoo otter- a show piece, a "freak", something he never asked to be. He weaves a sad, rather troubling encounter in high school of bullying and public humiliation that causes him sorrow, isolation and questioning his self-worth. Marcus' honesty invokes true emotions and I really feel for him.

The 'A-ha' moment arrives in Para 6, where Marcus crafts delightful, deep introspection and realization that he will not be the butt of jokes but an agent of change. He takes "control" by attending club meetings and speaking with school faculty.

Para 7 embodies the victory lap, as Marcus details his joys, self-acceptance and who he is now. He loves coffee, the law, his work, kayaking, his sister, Black Lives Matter and sex-gender associations. Wisdom is shared through his understanding that he cannot change the ignorance of others but live a purposeful, passion-filled life as his new self- a sincere message to the reader and, likely, others like him.

Overall, this winning essay takes the reader on a vivid, emotional and well-structured journey, sharing the author's unique experiences and why these experiences are significant for his growth and maturity.

Michelle's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2024)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2024/
Essay #: 8

Essay

Fish Out of Water:

idiom. a person who is in an unnatural environment; completely out of place.

When I was ten, my dad told me we were moving to somewhere called "Eely-noise." The screen flashed blue as he scrolled through 6000 miles of water on Google Earth to find our new home. Swipe, swipe, swipe, and there it was: Illinois, as I later learned.

Moving to America was like going from freshwater into saltwater. Not only did my mom complain that American food was too salty, but I was helplessly caught in an estuary of languages, swept by daunting tides of tenses, articles, and homonyms. It's not a surprise that I developed an intense, breathless kind of thirst for what I now realize is my voice and self-expression.

This made sense because the only background I had in English was "Konglish"--an unhealthy hybrid of Korean and English--and broken phrases I picked up from SpongeBob. As soon as I stepped into my first class in America, I realized the gravity of the situation: I had to resort to clumsy pantomimes, or what I euphemistically called body language, to convey the simplest messages. School became an unending game of pictionary.

Amid the dizzying pool of vowels and phonemes and idioms (why does spilling beans end friendships?), the only thing that made sense was pictures and diagrams. Necessarily, I soon became interested in biology as its textbook had the highest picture-to-text ratio. Although I didn't understand all the ant-like captions, the colorful diagrams were enough to catch my illiterate attention: a green ball of chyme rolling down the digestive tract, the rotor of the ATP synthase spinning like a waterwheel. Biology drew me with its ELL-friendliness and never let go.

I later learned in biology that when a freshwater fish goes in saltwater, it osmoregulates--it drinks a lot of water and urinates less. This used to hold true for my school day, when I constantly chugged water to fill awkward silences and lubricate my tongue to form better vowels. This habit in turn became a test of English-speaking and bladder control: I

constantly missed the timing to go to the bathroom by worrying about how to ask. The only times I could express myself were through my fingers, between the pages of Debussy and under my pencil tip. To fulfill my need for self-expression and communication, I took up classical music, visual art, and later, creative writing. To this day, I will never forget the ineffable excitement when I delivered a concerto, finished a sculpture, and found beautiful words that I could not pronounce. If biology helped me understand, art helped me be understood.

There's something human, empathetic, even redemptive about both art and biology. While they helped me reconcile with English and my new home, their power to connect and heal people is much bigger than my example alone. In college and beyond, I want to pay them forward, whether by dedicating myself to scientific research, performing in benefit concerts, or simply sharing the beauty of the arts. Sometimes, language feels slippery like fish on my tongue. But knowing that there are things that transcend language grounds and inspires me. English seeped into my tongue eventually, but I still pursue biology and arts with the same, perhaps universal, exigency and sincerity: to understand and to be understood.

Over the years, I have come to acknowledge and adore my inner fish, that confused, tongue-twisted and home-sick ELL kid from the other side of the world, which will forever coexist within me. And I've forgiven English, although I still can't pronounce words like "rural," because it gifted me with new passions to look forward to every day. Now, when I see kids with the same breathless look that I used to have gasping for home water, Don't worry, I want to tell them.

You'll find your water.

Professional Review by HS2 Academy

Michelle's essay offers the reader a picturesque and witty journey through their immigrant experience of adapting to their new life in Illinois (Eely-noise!). While some immigrant experience essays can come across as predictable, Michelle deftly crafts an extended metaphor using the idiom of a "fish out of water" to connect their passions for both biology and art with their evolving struggle to master English. The uniqueness comes in the candid and often humorous depictions of Michelle's everyday struggles with language, from initially resorting to "clumsy pantomimes" to signal an intent to go to the bathroom to their "ineffable excitement" at finding beautiful new words to express themselves, showcasing Michelle's eventual growth into an articulate writer in full command of the English language.

Michelle's diverse passions, ranging from music, to art, to biology, are on full display in this essay, but what's most impressive is Michelle's nuanced and introspective journaling of adapting to American life and culture. It's evident that Michelle genuinely loves writing and relishes finding the right words to convey their thoughts, showcasing their tenacity and love of learning. Michelle's sincere exuberance for growing as a writer and artist shines throughout this essay, with a warmth and humor that's infectious.

Michael's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2024)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2024/
Essay #: 9

Essay

I've been alone for three years now.

My freshman year, my mother had to take a job as a live-in caregiver to make enough money to pay rent and other bills after my uncle got married and moved out. I was ecstatic. I could finally have the entire house to myself. I had imagined the countless hours on the PS4, nobody telling me to go to sleep or to go do my homework. I felt free. Unexpectedly, though, this freedom came at the expense of my childhood.

To compensate for never being home, my mother called me three times a day. The first call would always be at 6:00 a.m, like clockwork. That was the call to wake me up so that I wouldn't miss the bus and be late for school. Then there was the 4:00 p.m call where we went over anything and everything that happened in school that day. Lastly, there was the 7:00 p.m call which always seemed to last over an hour. This was the call that made me miss my mother the most. We labeled this call the "multi-purpose" call. Sometimes we would just talk about how we were both doing. Other times she would teach me things I needed to know, like how to do laundry, how to go grocery shopping, or how to cook. But one thing that she always seemed to bring up was how she wished things were different and how much she ached with the desire to be home with her son.

That last call always weighed heavily on my heart. When around friends and their families, I would often put my head down and smile because their interactions would remind me so much of when my mother was with me every day. It made me miss her insurmountably, to the point where I began to despise every aspect of this "independence." To me, it was loneliness, isolation, and nights laying in bed wishing I had a loved one in the house that I could talk to or hug. I was forced to become a man instead of living out my days as a kid. What hurt me the most, though, was knowing that my mother hated our situation even more than I did. She hated knowing her only child was growing up without her and it hurt her more than words could explain. She would always say how I was her pride and joy, but I've always thought of myself to be her hope, her hope for a better life.

That is why I have worked so hard in school. My mother has dedicated and sacrificed years of her life to make sure that her son could live a great one, and all she has ever asked from me in return was to do well in school. There were numerous times when I felt discouraged and unmotivated, but the thought of letting down the woman that has broken her back for me was far stronger than any fatigue I may have felt.

For three long years now, I have entered my house after school expecting nothing but silence and darkness. I lay in bed at night yearning to hear any sound at all that would signal that there was life in the house beside me. Then I wake up the next morning, get ready for school, and start the cycle all over again. I have almost gotten used to being alone. But I won't let my story end here. The reason why I have worked myself so hard is so that things can be different for me and my mother. She always says that everything she's doing now is for me and that when she gets old it'll be my turn. Except when my turn comes, she will never have to be alone.

Professional Review by Quad Education

Michael's essay begins with a gripping hook, leaving the reader wondering why he is alone. He reveals his mother's sacrifices and his initial excitement at newfound freedom, which quickly turns into the burden of a lost childhood. The essay effectively uses the routine of their daily phone calls to highlight his deep connection with his mother and the pain of their separation.

Michael's forced independence, unlike the typical chosen independence of college freshmen, emphasizes his resilience and maturity. Despite the emotional toll, he channels his determination into academic excellence, driven by his mother's sacrifices and his desire to ensure a better future for both of them.

This essay excels in presenting a clear and compelling narrative of personal growth under challenging circumstances beyond one's control. Michael's story demonstrates his maturity, resilience, and commitment, qualities that suggest he would thrive in a rigorous academic environment. His motivation and determination show he is not only ready for college but also has the potential to effect positive change in society. These are hallmarks of what Harvard seeks in potential students.

Successful Harvard College Essays (2023)

2 essays

Connor's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2023)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2023/
Essay #: 1
Theme: Waking Up Early

Essay

Getting out of bed in the middle of a long, New Hampshire winter was never easy, but some mornings were especially difficult. On those particularly tough mornings, when the temperature could no longer be measured in the comfortable world of positive numbers, my dad would be up before the sun. He would turn on the gas fireplace in his bedroom, carry milk, cereal, bowls and spoons upstairs, and then wake up me and my siblings. We would wrap ourselves in blankets as we ate our breakfast by the fire. I would complain about having to wake up early, never considering that my dad had been up long before.

Every morning for years he woke me up, packed my lunch, and drove me to school. He helped me with homework, coached my soccer team and taught me how to ski. Even as I've gotten older and started to pour my own cereal, my dad hasn't stopped waking up early. He gets up long before my alarm clock even thinks about waking me, walks to his office (a desk, chair and laptop situated above our garage) and starts to work. He works nearly every day, only taking the occasional break to engage in such leisure activities as splitting wood and mowing the lawn. As I've grown older I've looked up to him more and more.

There have been times in the past four years when I've come home with seemingly unbearable amounts of homework and I've thought, "I could settle for a B on this essay" or "How important really are the laws of thermodynamics?" On those late nights, when I'm on the verge of trading my notebooks in for a tv remote, I think about my dad. I think about how hard he's worked to make my life easier, and I realize that mediocrity isn't a viable option. I go downstairs, pour myself a glass of ice water, turn on some music, and get back to my work.

Sometimes it's hard to imagine my dad being young, but twenty-nine years ago, my dad was entering his senior year at Gilford High School. He had won a soccer championship under head coach Dave Pinkham, and was on track for another title that year. He was doing lawn care with his brother to make some extra money, and dreading the speech he would have to make at graduation.

I am now entering my senior year at Gilford High School. I won a soccer championship under the same Dave Pinkham as a sophomore, and hopefully I'm heading toward another this year. I'm running Leggett Lawn Care (which, despite its two unofficial part-time employees, has not yet gone public) and denying the inevitability of the speech I have to make this June. I'm keeping up my grades and trying to emulate my dad by putting others first. I teach Sunday School at my church, support the freshmen and sophomores on my soccer team, and give up countless hours of sleep helping my classmates with calculus. It's now my turn to go out into the world and figure out what I want to do and who I want to become. I don't know exactly where I see myself in five years; I don't even know which state I'll be living in next fall. I do know though that if I'm half the man my father is, (which genetically I am) I'll have the strength and humility that I need to selflessly contribute to the world around me.

Professional Review by Dan Lichterman

In an attempt to break through admission readers' attention economy, many candidates reach for an unusual topic. Yet an essay can have impact even when the topic itself is more universal. Applicants who address familiar topics must find ways to bring specificity and self- insight to their narrative, enabling the particularity of their experiences to resonate anew.

It is no small feat that Connor has been able to take a story about finding inspiration in a parent's example and make it thoroughly his own. His essay evokes a rustic upbringing rooted in grit and humility. Connor paints a visceral and unforgettable image of a sub-zero New England morning in which his father has brought breakfast upstairs so that Connor and his siblings can eat, wrapped in blankets, alongside a gas fireplace in the father's bedroom. The vignette powerfully encapsulates both the cozy warmth within Connor's home life and the father's inspiring stoicism, "I would complain about waking up early, never considering my dad had been up long before."

The essay goes on to illustrate the father's selfless dedication to his family ("only taking the occasional break to engage in such leisure activities as splitting wood and mowing the lawn"). While many students may admire their parents' sacrifices, Connor's recounting of his dad's work ethic and values feels genuine because of its conversational style. By the time Connor tells us that he's grown to look up to his father's inexhaustible spirit more and more, we know precisely what he means.

Personal statements that address the topic of role models often risk taking the spotlight away from the actual candidate seeking admission. Connor avoids this pitfall by

redirecting the focus entirely back to himself halfway through his word count. He credits his own academic tenacity to his father's example, "when I'm on the verge of trading my notebooks in for a tv remote, I think about my dad." There is power within such simple phrasing and we recognize that Connor is writing from the heart, rather than from the thesaurus. He then draws parallels between his father's Gilford High School years and his own–from successful soccer championships, to part-time lawn care, to graduation speeches. Connor's playful aside about Legget Lawn Care remaining a privately owned company perfectly suits his theme of an intergenerational legacy grounded in small town community life.

The unconditional acts of service Connor admires in his father are paid forward in Connor's own church teaching, soccer support, and Calculus tutoring. This connection feels understated rather than resume grandstanding, particularly when paired with Connor's earnestness about the uncertainties of leaving Gilford behind. This essay's success makes a clear case for the value of not overselling yourself and for the capacity of a single well-told anecdote to evoke an entire childhood.

Sean's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2023)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2023/
Essay #: 2

Essay

I have always envied the butterfly.

Its graceful poise as it glides through the air; the blissful flutter of its wings as it courageously embarks upon life's journeys. Its ambitious and adaptive nature — a change-maker and discoverer, a trendsetter in the animal world, a leader amongst other species. Charles Darwin said, "it is not the strongest of species that survives, nor the most intelligent. It is the one most adaptable to change." I envy the butterfly's adaptive approach to change, making them the silent leaders of the animal kingdom.

It was at age nine, on a family trip to the Boston Museum of Science, that I was first drawn to the breathtaking butterfly. As I stepped into the butterfly's endless capsule of nature, the flamboyant and audacious nature of the butterfly was captivating — their vibrant colors flaunted proud and shame-free, central to their persona but not defining of their personality. Their extraordinary courage in self-expression brought a little boy great inspiration. As someone who has questioned and struggled with my identity and accepting my queerness throughout life, the butterfly exemplified what it meant to be bold, courageous, and proud to a young boy who was lacking in all of those.

I vividly recall one butterfly standing out among its comrades. Being an uncreative third-grader, I named my new friend Bloo due to his radiant cerulean shades descending from darkness to light as they progressed from the wing's base. I watched Bloo soar, using his wings to glide far above the dainty and fragile stereotypes placed on him by society. I admire the profound growth Bloo must have achieved to get here, at one point a timid and powerless inchworm evolved into a carefully-crafted canvas of power. Bloo exemplified the strength and pride that I needed to begin accepting my identity. Looking back on this brief encounter with Bloo, I recall how he taught an insecure child self-acceptance. From here, I began to internalize the butterfly's power. I began to molt into a new skin with fledgling wings.

As I progressed through life with these newly-discovered wings, I became increasingly drawn to observing butterflies in nature. They have proven much more than just precious

gems found amongst clouds or prize trophies for kindergarteners to catch in their nets. The butterfly has shown itself as the hidden alpha of the animal kingdom — a leader and trendsetter amongst organisms both small and large, a fearless change-maker enabling them to outsurvive the rest for the past fifty-six million years.

With the wings and strength of the butterfly latched to my shoulders, I proudly embraced the challenge posed by this delicate yet powerful creature — to be a leader and a change-maker. Recognizing many social injustices in my community, I was inspired by the butterfly to become a voice of change. Driven by the butterfly's creativity, I developed a social justice discussion program to take place at my high school, and became a local leader and fighter against corrupt politics in the 2020 election cycle. Bloo reminds me that time moves quickly and I must never settle nor lose focus in the crusade for justice. I hope to use this fragile time to advocate for equality in medicine, combining my passion for science with advocacy to leave a lasting legacy.

Today, the lessons taught by the butterfly are never far from my mind, whether I'm sitting in my English classroom discussing Beowulf, dreading the prospect of my upcoming integral exam, or even studying Darwin in Biology.

All these years later, as I ponder my defining characteristics and core values, I recognize that it is my time to become the butterfly — to embody Darwin's words and face life with the courage to create change as I break free from my cocoon and enter the long-awaited adult world.

Professional Review by HS2 Academy

This piece is quite touching, as it deftly crafts a delicate and nuanced picture of Sean's lifelong connection with the butterfly. It is playful ("my new friend Bloo") while also profoundly introspective. It starts out effectively with a thought-provoking hook. After all, how many people would think to envy a butterfly? But the essay quickly picks up pace and shows how the butterfly truly is a perfect symbol for Sean's own metamorphosis into a true leader and agent of change.

The essay works on so many levels because it utilizes an extended metaphor that aptly describes many parallels with Sean's life. Oftentimes, many college essays utilize figurative language, but the connection with the narrative of that student's life tends to be rather superficial. The idea of a butterfly emerging from a cocoon may seem a bit cliche as an image of a student's transformation, but Sean's essay goes deeper, in part because of a parallel with Sean's own struggles with their queer identity. Phrases like using his wings

to “glide far above the dainty and fragile stereotypes placed on him by society” powerfully capture Sean’s own journey from an insecure child to an advocate for social justice and equality in medicine.

We learn that Sean has truly found inspiration in the butterfly, rising above struggles with self-identity to become a principled leader with a genuine desire to fight injustice. The qualities Sean demonstrates—determination over adversity, passion for equality and justice—would be a welcome addition to any college community.

Successful Harvard College Essays (2022)

1 essay

Sean's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2022)
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Essay #: 1

Essay

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Successful Harvard College Essays (2020)

9 essays

Sarah's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2020)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2020/
Essay #: 1

Essay

I am standing behind my high school when a snowball pelts my side with a thud and splatters across my jacket, covering me with a fine, icy dust. My bewildered eyes trace the snowball's trajectory until they fall upon a pair of snickering hoodlums crouched behind a small mountain of snowballs. They must have been waiting all afternoon for an unsuspecting student to walk by, and perhaps for emphasis, one of the boys looks me in the eye and raises a grimy middle finger. Quickly, I mold a handful of snow into a sphere with cupped hands and cock my arm back.

I haven't thrown anything in a while, but muscle memory guides me through the requisite motions. I played softball for eight years, and my athletic strength was always my throwing arm; in fifth grade, when my coach asked me to throw the ball from third to first, I hurled the ball with such force that the catch knocked him off-balance. Upon entering high school, it seemed natural that I would play on the school's softball team.

However, my body had other ideas. Throughout middle school I'd developed increasingly painful body aches, and in freshman year I awoke one morning with a brutal headache penetrating the crown of my head and the bones of my face as though a vice had been clamped to my skull overnight. After consulting more doctors than I can remember, I was diagnosed with fibromyalgia.

Fibromyalgia is characterized by chronic widespread pain and extreme sensitivity to touch. My neurologist describes fibromyalgia as "headache of the body." Personally, I favor my father's description; after one particularly painful and exhausting day he aptly proclaimed, "Fibromyalgia is your body's way of giving you the finger."

Agonizing muscle cramps mocked me constantly, preventing me from walking longer than five minutes without growing exhausted. The pressure above my eyes sneered at me whenever I attempted to read or write. Even after I found medications to temper the headaches just enough so I could return to school with sporadic attendance, sharp pains gnawed at my body with haughty derision if I even thought about returning to the softball fields and the activities I loved.

For months I tried to ignore the cruel obscenities fibromyalgia hurled my way, steadfastly believing the pain would soon subside and I would achieve everything I had planned for myself if I simply disregarded the taunting aches and worked doggedly to catch up at school. But when softball season arrived, it became apparent that while determination and intelligence could preserve my GPA in the face of fibromyalgia, there was no personal attribute or skill that could heal my body and allow me to join my teammates on the field.

It was time to confront the beast.

In doing so, I kept in mind the schoolyard aphorism that there is strength in numbers. I did not face fibromyalgia alone, but with mathematics by my side. Baseball is a game of statistics, and if fibromyalgia threatened to steal the sport I loved through physical deterioration, I would outsmart this insolent illness and reclaim ownership of baseball through intellectual pursuits. I began a mathematical research project, analyzing the effectiveness of current baseball statistics, as well as deriving my own.

Fibromyalgia forced me to redefine my goals and personal standards for success. This baseball project was my first step toward reclaiming my life and laying the foundation for victory over my illness. As calculations replaced pitching drills, my passion for baseball was channeled into a burgeoning love of science and math. Hours I had previously devoted to softball became filled with scientific journals and books, and summers I used to spend at athletic camps were devoted to research at local universities. Baseball provided a link to my pre-fibromyalgia life at a time when I desperately needed one, and through baseball I realized that if I wanted to beat fibromyalgia, I could not simply hope it would disappear overnight. Whether I modified my medications or adapted my schedule, I needed to devise my own way to face fibromyalgia's antagonizing aches head-on.

So when that taunting rascal waves his middle finger in my direction, my cheeks do not flush with angry humiliation and my legs do not run away, but my hands mold a snowball and my arm pulls back. As I follow through with my throw, pain radiating up my arm, I know instantly that I will pay for this exertion in the morning. But my icy comeback hits the sniggering boy squarely in the chest, knocking him backward into the snow as his accomplice's mouth lies agape in shock.

Well. I guess I've still got it.

Professional Review by Elite Educational Institute

Sarah's story opens with a vivid anecdote of being pelted by a snowball that brings the reader to the scene of the crime with detailed sensory descriptions. She skillfully ties the

story to her talent for athletics, which in turn leads to her struggle with fibromyalgia and howin the face of physical limitation she redirected her passions to science and math. The story comes full circle and ties together nicely at the end with the conclusion of the snowball scene, which leaves the reader feeling victorious and vindicated for Sarah, as well as proud of her determination.

Sarah manages to cover a lot in this essay. The personal statement is an evident combination of overcoming obstacles and discovering academic passions, and also discreetly includes résumé- worthy accomplishments, such as her own mathematical research project on baseball statistics and summer research at local universities. What is important about her personal statement is that she goes beyond the résumé and gives the admissions officers a look at her character and personal struggle. Even though her essay is a bit long, Sarah does not waste a word and ensures that every detail she includes contributes in some way to the overall message she is trying to convey about herself. Rather than simply evoking sympathy for her situation, Sarah weaves humor and a cheeky attitude throughout her narrative. She introduces her love of mathematics with a creative twist on the common saying, “strength in numbers," and affectionately alludes to her father's depiction of fibromyalgia as "your body's way of giving you the finger."

Her vivacious and tenacious personality shines through in her colorful and descriptive language, painting a clear picture of Sarah as a determined person who doesn't let a chronic illness defeat her and instead finds another passion.

Josh's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2020)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2020/
Essay #: 2

Essay

I look over at the digital clock at the front of the bus just as the time changes to 8:30. The engine begins to rumble, the seat begins to shake, and the bus slowly pulls onto Route 6 and heads toward JPA—the Jay Pritzker Academy—near Siem Reap, Cambodia. The bus is alive with chatter. Peace Corps volunteers trade stories about their experiences in their assigned villages; international schoolteachers discuss their plans for the day's lessons. I overhear one of the Peace Corps volunteers, Deidre, say, "I have to say, the Peace Corps offers incredible health care. They medevaced me to Bangkok when I got dengue fever."

Today, I find myself unable to join the conversation. I stare blankly at the blue cloth seat in front of me, trying to gently coax my knotted stomach out of my throat. All I can think about is the empty seat beside me and the uncomfortable feeling of entering uncertain territory alone.

My friend and co-teacher, Shahriyar, is in the Angkor Hospital recovering from a serious bout of amoebic dysentery. I visited him yesterday. He was lying in bed with his summer reading in his right hand and an IV in his left. Looking pale and exhausted, he weakly lifted his head and greeted me. "I don't know if you know this yet," he said, "but I'm flying home tomorrow. Are you

coming with me?" Though the news didn't surprise me, the question caught me off guard. As I left the hospital room, I couldn't help but think how easily this could have been me in his situation.

The bus drives over a speed bump faster than it should have, and I'm jolted back to the present. I try to take my mind off Shahriyar and look out the window at the world around me. Everything is so much different than it is in Deerfield, yet it all somehow feels very natural to me. To my left I see an elderly woman wearing a mask sweeping dust off the street; I smile at her, but she doesn't notice. As the bus gets closer and closer to JPA, the fact that I will have to teach today's lessons by myself begins to set in. I wonder if I'm physically capable of teaching three hours of class by myself in the ninetydegree heat and 90 percent humidity. In the past,

Shahriyar and I had always taken turns leading the class, giving each other a few moments to rest and rehydrate while the other taught. A part of me is afraid to do it. I've never had to lead the class without the comfort and support of having Shahriyar by my side. As I think about the challenges I will face, I realize how easy it would be to turn back. I only have to call Sokun—a local tuk-tuk driver and he'd take me to the airport. Knowing my co-teacher has become seriously ill, nobody would think less of me if I went home today.

As I sit in my seat, planning my trip home, the bus slows nearly to a stop and then turns onto a narrow red dirt road. I've suddenly plunged into a new world. The mess of worn-down concrete buildings and mopeds gives way to miles of flooded rice paddies stretching as far as I can see. Every few hundred yards I see boys and young men working barefoot in the fields. The bamboo huts that dot the landscape make me think back to my visit to the house of one of my students, Dari. I remember looking into his room and seeing a wooden table on his dirt floor. Close by, a bamboo shelf was filled with books. The globe he had won for being on the Honor Roll was proudly displayed on the bookshelf among his prized possessions. Smiling ear to ear, he told us that JPA was the best thing in his life. I realize that it really is too late to go home. I've already fallen in love with my students.

As the bus pulls into JPA's driveway, the rest of the teachers begin gathering their materials. I remain seated, deep in thought. "Are you coming?" I hear a familiar voice ask me. I look up and see Deidre looking at me.

"Of course I am."

Professional Review by Empowerly

In essays about community service, it is easy to fall into the trap of self-aggrandizement—emphasizing your own personal sacrifices and good deeds and in the process making yourself look like someone more interested in self-service than community service. Josh's essay, on the other hand, steers well clear of this pitfall, skillfully conveying compassion, humility, and devotion to the people with and for whom he works—he does not stay on because he pities his students, but because he loves them. As a result, instead of coming off like résumé padding, Josh's work feels motivated by a genuine desire to do good.

Structurally, Josh's essay is solid—it traces the trajectory of his thought process from uncertainty to renewed resolve. This seemingly straightforward story arc is enlivened by choice details and images—the off-hand conversation about dengue fever in the first

paragraph, for example, adds a good jolt of surprise, and the descriptions of the Cambodian countryside are vivid and well-executed. The passage detailing Josh's visit to his student Dari's home is one of the essay's highlights, a scene that is both believable as the essay's "inspiration moment" and

memorable for the deep empathy it contains.

While it's true that Josh has the advantage of a rather unique experience—not every Harvard applicant is in a position to write their personal statement about volunteering with the Peace Corps— the main strengths of his essay are certainly translatable beyond this context. Josh's essay is a personal statement at its best: it not just narrates an experience but hints at deeper elements of his personality and expresses them in a way that does not come off as forced. Someone reading Josh's essay can tell that his volunteering experience was far more to him than résumé fodder. And as the admissions office gets deluged with more and more

applications every year, this spark of sincerity goes very far indeed.

Lucien's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2020)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2020/
Essay #: 3

Essay

I sat under the table, burying my head tightly in my folded arms, while the other children sat on the carpet, listening to the teacher's story. The language barrier was like a tsunami, gurgling with strange and indistinguishable vocalizations. Elementary school wasn't as fun as I expected at all.

"Hello?"

Hearing a whisper, I raised my head up, only to notice a boy's face merely inches away. I bolted up in surprise, my head colliding gracefully with the underside of the table. Yelping in pain, I noticed that the entire class was staring at me.

That was the story of how I met my first friend in Canada.

That boy, Jack, came to visit me during my lonely recesses. It was rather awkward at first —I could only stare at him as he rambled on in English. But it was comforting to have some company.

From there, our friendship blossomed. Our initial conversations must have been hilarious to the hapless bystander. Jack would speak in fluent English while I spurted sentence after sentence of Mandarin. It was like watching tennis—rallies of English and Mandarin back and forth. But I learned quickly, and in no time I was fluent.

Jack also showed me the ropes of Western culture. Heaven knows how embarrassing my birthday party would've been if he hadn't told me about those so-called "loot-bags" beforehand.

Today, I volunteer at a community service agency for new immigrants where I work with children. I do it because I understand the confusion and frustration of dealing with a strange and sometimes hostile environment; I remember how it feels to be tangled up in an amalgam of unfamiliar words and sounds. And so I teach them; I give seminars on reading, writing, and speaking skills as well as Western culture, history, and sometimes, a bit of social studies.

But I strive to do more than just that. I try to be a friend—because I remember how Jack helped me. I organize field trips to the science center, the museum, and the symphony: double-whammy trips where children can have fun while improving their literacy skills.

Through these experiences, I try to understand each of them as unique individuals—their likes, dislikes, pet peeves, background.

Everyone needs a guiding light through the lonesome process of adaptation, a friendly bump to lift them from the dark shroud of isolation. That's what Jack did for me—with a rather painful bump to the head—and it's also what I do for these immigrant children.

My hope is that, one day, these children will also feel compelled to do the same, helping others adapt to an unfamiliar environment. With this, we can truly create a caring and cohesive network of support for the children of our society.

Professional Review by Elite Educational Institute

Lucien's essay depicts a personal connection with his community service activity and provides the why to an extracurricular that probably shows up college application. He starts off with an endearing anecdote of meeting his first friend in Canada and connects the encounter to his current passion, then delves even deeper by concluding with self-reflection and a bigger goal for society that he hopes to achieve. His personal statement gives the reader a glimpse at his background and assimilation into a new culture, and how his qwn experience as an immigrant motivates him to help other immigrants adapt to life in a new place.

The strengths of this essay lie in the vivid and charming recounting of his first encounter with Jack, his first friend in a foreign new environment, and how he uses that story to explain his passion for volunteering. He connects his community service to a bigger goal at the end of the essay that leaves the reader feeling inspired, and alludes to his thoughts, hopes, and dreams. There is a tone of humility and humor as he depicts how he met his first friend by bumping his head under the table, and makes a motif out of the head bump by referring to it again later when he's talking about helping other immigrant children. He modestly credits his noble deeds at the community service agency to meeting his first friend, and humbly reveals his hope that his own good deeds will inspire others to pay it forward. He does a good job of exhibiting his accomplishments in community service without sounding like he's bragging.

Lucien could also make the essay more memorable and distinctive by including anecdotes of his experiences at the community service agency where he gave seminars and

organized field trips. He denotes his volunteering responsibilities in list form, which can seem a bit impersonal and résumé- like. For example, he mentions how he tried to understand the people he helped, but does not include how he goes about doing this, or whether learning about those unique individuals contributed to his experience. Adding a story of how he changed the lives of the immigrants he helped would enhance his message and create a fitting parallel with the anecdote of how Jack helped him as he assimilated only one line on the activities portion of his into Western culture. Overall, Lucien combines humor with humility and leaves the reader feeling inspired.

Chaffee's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2020)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2020/
Essay #: 4

Essay

I think the most tragic part of my childhood originated from my sheer inability to find anything engraved with my name. I never had a CHAFFEE license plate on my hand-me-down red Schwinn. No one ever gave me a key chain or coffee mug with the beautiful loops of those double Fs and Es. Alas, I was destined to search through the names; longingly staring at the space between CHAD and CHARLOTTE hoping one day a miracle would occur. Fortunately, this is one of the few negative aspects of a name like “Chaffee Duckers.”

My name has always been an integral part of my identity. Sure, it sounds a bit like my parents created it from a bag of Scrabble tiles, but it comes from a long-lost ancestor, Comfort Chaffee. Now it’s all mine. In my opinion, a name can make or break a person. The ability to embody a name depends on the individual. My greatest goal in life is to be the kind of unique person deserving of a name so utterly random and absurd.

I began my journey in preschool. Nothing about me screamed normal. I was not prim, proper, and poised. I preferred sneaking away from my preschool classroom, barefoot, in the purple velvet dress I wore every single day to resting obediently during nap time.

I grew up in a family akin to a modified Brady Bunch. Stepsisters, half sisters, stepbrothers, and stepparents joined my previously miniscule household. But in a family of plain names like Chris, Bill, John, Liz, Katherine, and Mark, I was still the only Chaffee.

I was a bit of a reverse black sheep in my family. My name helped me carve an identity separate from my myriad of siblings. Instead of enriching my brain with Grand Theft Auto, I preferred begging my parents to take me to the bookstore. While my parents mandated homework time for my brothers, they never questioned my work ethic or wiretapped my assignment notebook. The thing that set me apart from the herd was that I was self-disciplined enough to take control of my own life. From the very beginning I never depended on my parents’ help or motivation to finish my schoolwork. Putting school first came naturally to me, much to the distaste and confusion of my siblings. My work ethic became known as the patented “Chaffee Method.”

As I got older, I began to embody my name more and more. I didn't want to be that girl with the weird name in the back of the class eating her hair, so I learned how to project my ideas in both written and spoken forms. I was often picked to lead classroom discussions and my complete disregard for making a fool of myself bolstered that skill. The manner in which I operate academically is perfectly described as Chaffee-esque; including but not limited to elaborate study songs, complex pneumonic devices, study forts, and the occasional John C. Calhoun costume.

I take pride in the confusion on a person's face when they first read my name. Seeing someone struggle over those two unfamiliar syllables fills me with glee. I feel as though I am adding a new word to their vocabulary. So on my last day as a page in the U.S. Senate, I prepared myself for the anticipated awkward stumbling as Senator Harry Reid thanked me by name in his closing address. But the stumble never came. I felt very humbled by his perfect pronunciation. Perhaps Chaffee is actually catching on!

Professional Review by Options for College

Chaffee's essay is strong because it follows a clear narrative, all enabled by her rather unusual name. While not everyone has a name as unique as "Chaffee," and are therefore unable to use this approach, writing an essay about an experience or aspect of one's life that is singular to oneself is a smart approach for any college essay. She shapes her development from preschool to high school in the lens of her name, demonstrating the importance that it has played throughout her life.

Chaffee's initial anecdote immediately grips the reader; many people have shared the experience of looking for engraved merchandise, and the fact that she can find none bearing her name sets the stage for the rest of the essay. Chaffee quickly qualifies her discontent with her name, stating that this anecdote "is one of the few negative aspects of a name like 'Chaffee Duckers.'" Unfortunately this qualification is a bit misplaced since she immediately returns to tell a story of her upbringing while failing to address any of the positive aspects of her name until paragraphs later. This is a bit of hedging that isn't entirely necessary in the limited space allowed by most personal statements.

Yet, the essay works quite well. Chaffee spends a great deal of time elaborating on how she was different from both her family and others with examples of her transgressions in preschool and her penchant for schoolwork and education as opposed to procrastination or video games like Grand Theft Auto. Chaffee toots her own horn just a little bit when describing the merits of her work ethic, but it is still fairly endearing overall, and there is no shame in sharing a desire for learning. Chaffee states in the conclusion of her essay

that she now takes “pride in the confusion on a person’s face,” as they try to read her name, demonstrating how she has now accepted and come to appreciate the fact that she does not share a name with the average Mary, Dick, or Jane.

John's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2020)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2020/
Essay #: 5

Essay

“Let’s face it, you’re slow,” my violin teacher said.

He was, as always, complaining that running was detracting from my practice time.

That summed up what running had always meant to me, ever since I was a seventh grader, choosing his sport for the first time. I was fine and content, however. I always had Jeffrey and Archie, classmates like me who ran slowly. We were good friends. We laughed together; we raced together; we pushed each other, and endured tough workouts together. But after middle school the people I trained with went on to do things they were better at. I remained, even though I was not good enough to be considered for varsity.

High school running was hell. I struggled with workouts, most of which I had to run alone. In the hot, dry days of autumn, I often coughed on the dust trails left by my teammates as they vanished into the distance. During the workouts, I got passed incessantly, almost getting run over on occasion. It hurt not to be important; to be dead weight for the team. I looked forward to the next year, when I could hopefully run with the incoming freshmen.

It didn’t happen that way. Even a year later, I was still the slowest on the team. How could the freshmen who had snored off the whole summer beat me, a veteran from middle school and high school with decent summer training? I nevertheless reconsidered the effectiveness of my training, and looked forward to getting “back in shape.” It was only after my condition had been deteriorating steadily for a few weeks that I began to feel a new level of humiliation. I started to have trouble keeping up with old ladies in the park, and each day I worked frantically to prevent the discovery of that fact by my teammates, running toward the sketchy areas of the ramble, in the south, where there’s barely anybody. My mother, worried about the steady deterioration of my condition, contacted a doctor.

I was anemic.

The doctor prescribed a daily iron pill, and the results were exhilarating. I joked that I was taking steroids. I sunk into endless oxygen. I got tired less. During the workouts, I felt

more machine than man. Iron therapy taught me something fundamental. It reminded me why I was running; why I had stuck to this damn sport for four straight years. When I was anemic, I struggled to gather what little motivation I had for those painfully slow jogs in those parks. Putting the effort in, and seeing the dramatic results fooled my mind like a well-administered placebo. Iron therapy was the training wheels that would jump-start my dramatic improvement.

It took four months—four months of iron pills, blood tests, and training—to get back to my personal best: the 5:46 mile that I had run the year before. Early February that year, the training wheels came off. I was running close to seven miles a day on my own. But I wasn't counting. I could catch a light. I could walk as many stairs as I wanted without getting tired. I was even far ahead of where I was the year before. After two and a half years as a 5:50 miler, I finally had a breakthrough race. I ran a 5:30. I asked coach if I could eventually break 5 minutes. He told me to focus more on maintaining my fitness through spring break.

I ran the mile again, this time outdoors. Coach had me seeded at a 5:30. I ran the first lap, holding back. I didn't want to overextend myself. I hoped to squeeze by with a 5:35. The euphoria was unprecedented as I realized by the second lap that I was a dozen seconds ahead and still holding back. I finished with a 5:14.

On the bus ride back from the meet, one of my long-standing dreams came true. I pretended to ignore Coach sitting next to me, but he kept on giving me glances. He was excited about my time. We talked a lot about the race. We talked about my continuous and dramatic improvement. He said it was early in the season and that I would break 5 minutes after only a few weeks of training.

Six weeks later, Mr. Song, my chemistry teacher, asked me if I had broken 5 minutes for the mile yet. I told him all about how I had run in three meets over the past month and had failed to break 5:15 on every one of them. I told him that 5 minutes was now for me a mirage in the distance. Mr. Song, however, did not show much concern: "You're just overtrained. Once you ease up before the big meet, you'll drop in time once more."

Even though these consoling words were from the man who had baffled my nutritionist when he had guessed that I was anemic, I still doubted his wisdom. On Sunday, I would run the mile once. My last mile of the year. This was it. Using my tried-and-true racing strategy, I finished with a 5:02, a 12- second drop in time. Mr. Song's predictions had again turned out to be correct.

Before I was anemic, the correlation between hard work and success was something that only appeared in the cliché success stories of the talented few. Now, I am running more mileage than I ever have before. And my violin teacher still complains.

But I smile. I know it's going somewhere.

Professional Review by Upward College Planning

John opens this essay by illustrating the iconic "grabber" done well: simple, unexpected, and leaving the reader wanting more. Is he actually "slow" at the violin (but that doesn't quite make sense, does it)? We then learn all about John's true passion: running.

Although challenging (and not to mention the fact that he always finishes last), John has stuck with running for many years. Eventually, his "slowness" deteriorates to the point where he needs medical intervention and finds his kryptonite: iron. This magic mineral allows him to heal, excel in his running, and ultimately exceed his wildest expectations by almost breaking the 5-minute mark by a few seconds.

The themes that permeate this essay are perseverance and tenacity: that all-powerful "grit" that distinguishes this student. John guides us through his story through the lens of his infallible work ethic. Even though he did not reach his exact goal, he is seconds away from it, and the reader knows he will keep pushing to achieve it.

As a reader, I would love to hear more about what happens next. Is there another instance that demonstrates John's persistence or has he applied this newfound confidence and self-awareness to other aspects of his life? This self-reflection section is the most important element of the essay as it allows admissions readers a window into what drives a student. It is important to develop this and "show" the evidence of how the student has changed or what they have learned from this experience.

As the essay culminates, John makes us smile as he smiles (even though his violin teacher is still not too happy with him). We know John has learned to appreciate the beauty of the journey rather than the destination and we are just thrilled for him!

Winnie's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2020)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2020/
Essay #: 6

Essay

Soft Wooden Heart

The backbone of my life is my writing desk. I like to describe its surface as an organized mess (despite my parents' overdramatized description of a bomb site), a state of positive entropy and minimum energy. Math exercises overlap an organizer, set next to almost-empty tubes of paint and overdue library books. A constantly filled bottle of water sits behind a glasses' case full of guitar picks, and carved into a mountain of paper, right in the middle, is a space reserved for my laptop—on days when I am slouching, The Complete Works of William Shakespeare needs to be slid under it. An eclectic desk shows an eclectic personality; mine has had the honor of being the training grounds prior to the Great (final) Battle (exam) of Chemistry, the peaceful meadow of relaxed reading afternoons, and all in all the pristine-turned-colorful canvas of an inquisitive mind.

I remember buying it with my mother five years ago, when my bruised knees protested against the tiny white-paint-gone-yellow one I had used since childhood. My new desk was made of native Rimu heartwood—solid, resilient, dependable—a perfect role model for me to grow into. Over the years, its material became representative of my New Zealand identity, its surface slowly coated in quirky personality, and its compartments filled with treasured memories; the heartwood desk echoed my heart.

At first, it did not fit with the decor of the rest of my room, which even now appears boxy and stark next to my grandiosely elegant writing desk, but its quiet strength is unafraid of individuality, just as I have learned to become. It has watched as I grew stronger branches, a straighter trunk, firmer roots; whereas I had once been but a shy young seedling, I sprouted leaves and with them the ability and yearning to provide shade for others. I have certainly physically grown into it, but although I would like to think that I have become completely independent, I remain human; in inevitable times of need, it is still my steadfast, sturdy desk that offers its support.

I sit here and, well, I write: joyfully, desolately, irately, wistfully—at times paralyzed by excitement, at others crippled by fear. I scrawl notes in my organizer (which is, naturally,

not in the least organized), words overflow my blog, overemotional oranges and blues plague my illustrations; shallow scratch marks indent the wood from where I have pressed too passionately into paper. It may be solid, but it is elastic enough to be shaped, resilient enough to adapt: This is my soft wooden heart.

It can take it. My desk remains constant despite scars of experience—unassuming, stoic, ever watchful. Even when I dismembered dying cell phones, their frail key tones pleading for mercy, the desk stood there, nonchalant. Regardless of what fervor goes on from time to time, it knows there will eventually be a constant calm; my lively nest of rebuilt mobiles still calls this place home. Sometimes, I rest my uncertain head on its reassuring solid surface and the wood presses back into my heartbeat, communicating in Morse: "Don't worry. Some things will never change."

And, like a mother, it always turns out to be right. Beneath my seemingly chaotic coat of papers and objects; beneath the superfluous, temporary things that define my present life, my desk and my heart remain still—solid, stable, and evergreen, ready to be written onto and scratched into by experience.

Professional Review by Lora Lewis Consulting

Winnie's piece shows us that a meaningful essay doesn't have to be about a major accomplishment or a painful personal experience; oftentimes, the most inspired writing can evolve from something as simple and unexpected as a writing desk. Winnie's essay is successful because it invites readers into her world, where we discover a smart, unique, and self-aware young woman. Through her "eclectic" desk, we see her interest in the arts, her academic prowess, and her challenges with procrastination. We glimpse her pride in her heritage, her struggles with self-doubt, and her faith in herself to adapt to change and embrace new experiences. By the final sentence, we feel that if we heard Winnie's voice in a classroom or sat next to her in the library, we would recognize her right away.

Winnie's ability to bring herself to life through language also creates some challenges in her essay. She has so much to show us and does so in such creative ways that readers can feel overwhelmed by the information and figurative language that competes for our attention. Your college essay is a valuable opportunity to show who you are, but it's not necessary to weave every aspect of your life into 650 words. For even the most gifted writers, less is often more.

Lessard's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2020)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2020/
Essay #: 7

Essay

**Why a Republican Read The Communist Manifesto **

I am a conservative. Point-blank. I'm not talking "hardcore, no gay marriage, abortion equates to eternity in Hell, Catholicism is the only religion worthy of my acknowledgment" conservative, but I believe in limited government intervention in private business. I may seem like an unlikely candidate for such beliefs; I live in Springfield, Massachusetts, an urban environment where the majority of the population utilizes some sort of government assistance to supplement the costs of living. Well, maybe not the absolute majority, but I certainly see a lot of it. Though raised as a Catholic, I believe in nothing more than simple spirituality, and do not abide by all the stipulations of the strict Catholic community (although I do continue to attend church because I find the environment welcoming and the people overwhelmingly happy and uplifting). I attend the Drama Studio, a small, conservatory style acting community where I am considered the token Republican (artsy and conservative—is this what Harold Camping meant by the Rapture?) Not surprisingly, my colleagues have made many attempts at conversion ("Watch MSNBC, Danielle; I promise you'll love it!") But I stick to my guns—no pun intended. However, I have found that sharing the majority of my time with those of conflicting opinions has enlightened me in the ways of respect and compromise.

Enter Jacob Mueller. Literally the son of a preacher man (his father is the minister at Trinity United Methodist Church), his political views on Facebook are listed as "Member of the Communist Party of America." Oh, boy … He entered my Advanced Scene Work class in its second semester, and as is the Drama Studio custom, I welcomed him with open arms and commenced what I soon discovered to be the long and interesting process of getting to know him. Through this, I discovered a few important things; like me, he loved politics. Like me, he was well informed. And, like me, he was more than willing to argue his opinion.

Through our Odd Couple dynamic, we found an endless number of conversation topics. Every day was a new, "Did you see what the Tea Party's newest legislation entails?" countered by a, "How about that Scott Brown, eh?" I was the Michele Bachmann to his Al

Gore. But the remarkable thing about our debates was not their intensity or their depth, but how much I was learning by listening to him talk.

A strange thing was happening to me. For the girl who had always been staunchly opinionated and stubborn, who had never been one for agreeing with the opposition, who took pride in her ability to stand her ground even when she represented the minority view, compromise suddenly had a new meaning. Its connotation was no longer negative. And, in turn my ability to not only understand but also respect a view contradictory to my own was growing in strength. In order to foster this newfound mind-set, I presented myself with the ultimate challenge. In a moment of excited passion, I logged on to Amazon.com and, for $4.95, ordered a copy of The Communist Manifesto. The little book, with its floppy laminated cover depicting a hammer and a sickle on a glossy black background and plain white block letters spelling out its title with inconspicuous innocence, took its place at the head of my bed, where it resided for the next month. Bit by bit, it began to fill with marks of pensive notation, speckles of yellow appearing in odd places where the highlighter had bled through, its fragile pages curving with the insistent pen marks that filled their margins.

As I devoured the words of Marx and Engels, I realized something remarkable. I'm not going to tell you I agreed with them; in a lot of instances, I didn't. But I did understand what they were saying, and I was able to respect them both as visionaries and intellectuals. Where the old voice in my head would have said, "Wow, what idiots," my new voice was open to more than just the fundamental ideas, but the intelligence it must have taken to form them and the thought process behind them.

When I register to vote, I will not be registering as a Democrat. You won't see me at any PETA meetings, and you certainly won't hear me speaking fondly about President Obama's plans for health care. But I can proudly say that The Communist Manifesto taught this Republican what it means to compromise, and to respect.

Professional Review by Spiderweb Education

Lessard's essay "works" and earned its author a spot at Harvard, yet it circumvents a general guideline of college essay writing by speaking directly about politics and religion—albeit in a funny and personal way. Lessard explains humorously and intimately her status as a curious conservative. If one is going to talk about controversial topics like politics in a college essay, avoid entirely (as this essay does—and even if you do make mention of *The Communist Manifesto*!) providing your own manifesto. The main problem with manifestoes is that they are not personal, but abstract. By contrast, the

college essay needs to tell us all about you, ideally in an unforgettable, up-close, down-to-earth way. Nobody wants to read the RNC or DNC policy platform coughed up as an essay. Instead colleges want to get to know the real you.

One way this essay could be improved might include providing more detail about what exactly Lessard found meaningful in the works of Marx and Engels. As it stands, the essay only touches on *The Communist Manifesto* in a cursory way despite Lessard's reading of that work being pivotal to the arc of the essay. Even another couple of sentences explaining the writer's "respect" (Is it grudging admiration for the Marxist theory of history? Some element of the text's social critique?) could deepen the essay's analysis.

Very effectively, however, Lessard positions herself in this essay as a person on an intellectual journey who is open to new ideas and experiences. This is an excellent posture to demonstrate to an admissions committee. College is all about learning—intellectually, socially, politically, and beyond—and colleges often find students irresistible when they are hellbent on learning to the utmost. Be an intellectual astronaut and demonstrate that in your college essay, as Lessard did quite effectively.

Danielle's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2020)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2020/
Essay #: 8

Essay

I wrap my scarf more firmly around my neck, feeling the chill of the brisk January air as I trudge my way to practice. The bus stop isn't actually that far from the pool, but with a heavy backpack and the fancy shoes that my host sister insisted I wear, the three-minute trek seems to last forever. Turning the corner three blocks down, I finally make it to the parking lot and see one of my friends.

"Salut, Thomas."

He knows that it's me without even looking. "Salut, Danielle." He finishes fiddling with his bicycle lock and stands to greet me. I lean in for my customary kiss, and he obliges, bisous-ing me once on each cheek, before we walk toward Piscine Bréquigny together.

Easy conversation flows between us as our well-trained feet follow the paths to our respective changing rooms. I punch in the code on the girls' side and open the door. Familiar figures stand in various states of undress, and bisous go all around while we change and speculate on the various tortures Marc will put us through today. Then we head down to the pool deck, ready to meet our fates.

I get to our coach first, and mentally switch back into English. "Hey, Marc, what's up?"

He shrugs. "Fine."

I laugh and give him a high five, then move on to bisous and ça va? the rest of the boys. When I get to Islem, who is Algerian, the two of us proceed to execute our exceedingly complex non-French secret handshake, recently perfected at Tours during last week's three-day meet. (We foreigners have to stick together, after all.) We end with a perfect fist bump, and I smirk.

Islem winks back at me. "Et ouais." That's how we roll.

Marc eventually yells at us to get to work, and we all start to put on our caps and goggles. I pull out my team cap from home, reflecting on how much I've changed since I left. Four months ago, I was mute, standing awkwardly to the side, hoping that English instructions for the new and frightening social interaction would suddenly appear out of thin air. Now,

flawless French rolls off my lips as I greet my friends, laughing freely at inside jokes, not thinking twice about kissing swimsuit-clad swimmers on the cheek. I'm not just on the team anymore—I'm part of it, and every single bisous reminds of that fact.

Someone pushes me into the pool and my shriek is swallowed by the water. I surface and swear my revenge, glaring all the while at Pierre, the obvious culprit, who is grinning unabashedly. Then he yelps and falls as he himself is pushed in as well. The whole team eventually follows us into the water to start the day's warm up, and a small smile, fond and content, flits across my face before I join them.

Professional Review by HelloCollege

One of the first pieces of advice that I share about what makes a strong essay is for a student to not overthink it. Not everybody needs to cure a disease by the time they turn 16 or have had a research paper published in a professional journal. Let me get to know who you are as a person – and it's often the simplest day-to-day stories that help students do this most effectively.

Admittedly, I'm not a big fan of athletes writing about sports (which often come across as thin and cliched) so I was bit trepidatious when I read the opening paragraph. I got over it quickly.

Here are the notes I took while reading this essay:

Opening: Sets the scene effectively, draws me in to want to learn more about her abroad experience, seems very friendly.

Changing room / interplay with team: Comes across as personable with a fun sense of humor. Exchanges with coach and the conversations and handshakes with teammates show adaptability and an ability to bring people together.

Practice / reflection moment: Spending four months away from home can be intimidating for most people, let alone a high schooler, and shows a true sense of commitment and perseverance. At the beginning of her trip she seemed scared and vulnerable but she learned to push past any initial anxiety and now presents herself as self-aware and appreciative.

End: She has grown from this abroad experience and her spirit, likability and sense of camaraderie are evident.

When I read an interesting and descriptive essay like this, it's almost like I'm drawn into a mini-movie. I want to keep reading to see how things play out. By the end, I feel like I

know the student and I have a sense of how their unique personal attributes would make them an appealing candidate to any college admissions officer.

Octav's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2020)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2020/
Essay #: 9

Essay

A light breeze caressing the cornfield makes it look like a gentle swaying sea of gold under the ginger sun of late summer. A child's chime-like laughter echoes. As I rush through the cornfield, I hear the rustling of leaves and the murmur of life hidden among the stems that tower over me.

I remember the joy of the day when I solved one of my first difficult combinatorics problems at my parents' house in the countryside. I felt so exhilarated that I ran outside and into the cornfield. As I was passing row after row of stems, I realized the cornfield was actually a giant matrix with thousands of combinations of possible pathways, just like the combinatorics problem I had just solved. I looked at the sky and I thought about the great mathematicians of the past that contributed so much to this field and about how I have added yet another dimension to my matrix. Suddenly, mathematics appeared to me as a 3D live map where staggering arrays of ideas connect each other by steady flows of sheer wisdom.

Suddenly a loud laughter from the next room wakes me up from my reverie. I am back in my room in the drab dormitory where I lived since I was fifteen. The dim sunset barely lightens up my room, while the cold November wind rushes from the broken-and-mended-with-tape window on the hallway, whistling beneath my door. My roommates haven't returned yet, and I feel alone and isolated.

In moments such as these I always take out the ultimate weapon against gloominess: the picture of my family. I look at myself, my parents, my little sister, and my grandfather at the countryside, under a clear blue sky, hugging, sharing the joy of being together. It reminds me of the old times, when life was simpler, but it also reminds me of why I came to Bucharest to live in a dormitory. It was because mathematics fascinated me with its beautiful and intricate theories and configurations, and my parents and my family supported me 150 percent. They put in long hours at work to pay for school costs and they selflessly accepted my long absences. I decided then to honor their support, follow our common dream, and become an accomplished mathematician.

Finally today I consider I matched at least an infinitesimal part of my parents' work. After countless Olympiad stages and fierce selection programs, I managed to win a gold medal at the International Mathematical Olympiad, along with scoring what is called "an ace": getting gold medals in the National Olympiad, the Balkan Olympiad, and the International Olympiad.

Math, for me, is a vast map of knowledge where theories intersect each other like pathways in a cornfield, and that explains the laws of nature and the universe itself. However, no matter what mathematical sphere shall I soar in, I will always have my family with me and the joy of that day when I was running freely in the cornfield.

Professional Review by Dan Lichterman

Octav's essay succeeds through its sophisticated use of narrative shift and juxtaposition. He transforms a youthful pastoral image of running through a cornfield into a wholly unexpected and exhilarating mathematical epiphany. The metaphor proves effective by merging his richly tactile experience with a cognitive experience that is maximally abstract: navigating a matrix of thousands of combinatorial pathways. Within this reverie, we see Octav's intellectual freedom and ability to lose himself in both the contributions of great thinkers and his own original insights.

After leading the reader into his experience of pure mathematical reasoning, the essay takes a deft biographical turn. Through Octav's austere study in a drab Bucharest boarding school we realize for the first time just how far he has travelled and how much has been sacrificed for his dream of becoming a mathematician. The cornfield takes on further dimensionality, now representing both a nostalgic connection to his family and the unbounded expansiveness that accompanies the life of the mind. When Octav mentions his mathematical "ace" it is almost besides the point–we already wholly believe in the promise of his curiosity-driven journey.

Successful Harvard College Essays (2019)

10 essays

Sandra's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2019)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2019/
Essay #: 1

Essay

"Ut Italiam laeti Latiumque petamus"

"Sandra, would you mind reading the next few lines and translating them for us?"

The professor glanced at me, a kind glimmer in his bespectacled eyes. I gulped. I was in a classroom of eighteen, five of whom were high school Latin teachers. And I was supposed to recite and translate Livy's Ab Urbe condita — with elisions! After fumbling through a few words and mistaking a verb for a noun, I finished the first sentence. I skimmed the second line, looking for the main verb. Singular. I searched for a singular noun and pieced the two together. Then, I noticed an accusative and added it as a direct object. As I continued, a burst of exhilaration shot through my body. My eyes darted across the page, finding a verb, a noun, and objects. I reached the end of the passage and grinned, relief pulsing in my veins.

"Very good!" The professor beamed at me before selecting his next victim.

A few months ago, I never would have imagined myself sitting in Harvard's Boylston Hall this summer for six hours a week, cherishing the ancient literature of Rome. Even though the professor decided I was eligible for the course despite not taking the prerequisite, I was still nervous. I worked hard in the class, and it reminded me just how much I love the language.

Translating has always given me great pleasure and great pain. It is much like completing a jigsaw puzzle. Next, I look for phrases that connect the entire clause — does this adjective match this noun? Does this puzzle piece have the right shape? The middle of the sentence is the trickiest, full of convoluted dependent clauses, pieces colored ambiguously and with curves and edges on all four sides. I am sometimes tangled in the syntax, one of the worst feelings in the world. After analyzing every word, I try to rearrange the pieces so they fit together. When they finally do, I am filled with a satisfaction like no other. Translating forces me to rattle my brain, looking for grammatical rules hidden in my mind's nooks and crannies. It pushes my intellectual boundaries. No other language is as precise, using inflection to express gender, number, and case in just one word. When I

pull apart a sentence, I am simultaneously divulging the secrets of an ancient civilization. Renowned scholars are telling the stories of their time through these words! No other language is as meticulous. Every line follows the same meter and the arrangement of every word is with a purpose. The story of Pyramus and Thisbe includes a sentence where the word "wall" is places between the words "Pyramus" and "Thisbe" to visually show the lovers' separation. Translating is like life itself; the words are not in logical order. One cannot expect the subject of a sentence to appear at the beginning of a clause, just like one cannot plan the chronology of life. Like the delayed verb, we do not always know what is happening in our lives; we just know it is happening.

When translating we notice the nouns, the adjectives, and the conjunctions just like we see the people, senses, and connections of our lives. However, we often do not know what we are doing and ask ourselves the age-old question: Why are we here? Perhaps we are here to learn, to teach, to help, to serve, to lead, or just to live. We travel through life to decide what our purpose is, and it is that suspense and our unknown destinies that make the journey so irresistibly beautiful. I feel that same suspense and unknown when I translate, because I am beautifully struggling to unlock a past I know very little of. It is unbelievably exhilarating.

Thus, I question why others consider Latin a dead language. It is alive in all of the Western world. The Romance languages of French, Spanish, and Italian all have Latin origins. Without Latin, I would not be able to write this essay! It is alive in the stories it tells. You may see an apple and associate it with orchards, juice, pie, and fall. When I see an apple, I think of the apple of discord thrown by Eris that ultimately caused the Trojan War. This event, albeit destructive and terrifying, leads to the flight of Aeneas and eventually, his founding of Rome.

I study Latin for its rewarding return, incredible precision, intellectual challenge, rich history and culture, and deep influence on our world. I study Latin to show others how beautiful it is, to encourage the world that it should be valued. I study Latin to lead our society, like Aeneas did, toward a new city, a new dawn where everyone appreciates a mental trial of wits, everyone marvels at a vibrant past, and no one wonders whether Latin is dead or not.

Professional Review by Dan Lichterman

What is most striking about Sandra's essay was not the fact that she was taking a class alongside high school Latin teachers, or that she was taking a summer class at Harvard. Rather, it was how in-depth Sandra went into her thought process when translating Latin.

It became clear from the vivid detail with which she described her translating process that she takes it rather seriously, and it is always a pleasure to read application essays that make such passion clear.

That said, there are times where Sandra's writing appears to deliberately make something engaging when there is no need. For example, “One cannot expect the subject of a sentence to appear at the beginning of a clause, just like one cannot plan the chronology of life” seemed to be an intentionally poetic sentence made to fit Sandra's claim that “translating is like life itself.” Overall, the simile works, but you should not feel forced to make dramatic claims in your essay. If you write about something that you are passionate about, that should naturally become clear in the way you write.

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Christopher's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2019)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2019/
Essay #: 2

Essay

When I broke the news to my volunteer team, we were in a church basement, cleaning up after the final event of the summer. I tried to downplay it. I nudged Ms. Diana, the neighborhood leader, in the shoulder, and said, "Guess what I'll be doing next Wednesday — having lunch with the president." Her face blazed with a kilowatt smile. Before I could slow her down, she shouted, "Christopher's meeting President Obama next week."

Eldred dropped his broom, Ms. Sheila left the cups scattered on the floor, and all the others came running over and fusilladed me with questions. Yes, the campaign had chosen me from all the other summer organizers. Yes, I would bring photos for everyone. And yes, we had the strongest team by the numbers — total calls, knocks, voters registered, and events — in the country.

I felt guilty that only I could go and told them so. "I wish that I could bring you all with me. You made nearly all of the calls, brought your friends and family along, and made this what it is. I've just been here to facilitate." The others good-naturedly shouted me down. Then Ms. Melva spoke up. Her words were pressed out against the heaving of her respirator. "Christopher, don't feel bad. You'll bring us wherever you go in your pocket. Just pull us out when you meet Barack."

For a long time, I was perplexed by her advice. Then I thought back to the exercise that we employed before any volunteer activity. We sat in a circle and gave our reasons for being in the room, willing to work with the campaign. That way, when it came time to make our "hard ask" on the phones, we would be supported by personal conviction and shared purpose. The "hard ask" is the Obama campaign's tactic for garnering support or a commitment to volunteer, moving from values to idealism to specific action.

In my work on the campaign, I am reminded of my cross-country coach, Rob. Before every single race, from petty league meets to national championships, Rob taps the spot on his thigh where a pocket would be. We look at our teammates who are lining up with us and tap the same spot. Coach Rob is reminding us, and we're reminding each other, that we carry "the bastard" in our pockets with us throughout the race.

"The bastard in your pocket" is a metaphor for the sum of our efforts to succeed as runners. "The bastard" exists as a sort of Platonic ideal form of the high school cross-country runner, melded from accrued mileage and mental conditioning. My goal in a race is to take this ideal form and to transform it into a reality that lives on the course.

I want an education that fills my pockets. And, perhaps more importantly, an education that prompts hard asks, that demands us to use "the bastard" and that uses the compounded experiences of a group for a single purpose.

Professional Review by BEEC

Through the two examples of his volunteer work and cross-country experience, Christopher is able to depict a nuanced and sophisticated understanding of leadership and a profound dedication to teamwork.

In the opening paragraphs, he describes the moment in which he related news of an invitation to meet the president to his volunteer team. The moment is shown as the culmination of Christopher's efforts as a summer organizer for the Obama campaign. The mention of the invitation serves as a validation of demonstrable and impressive leadership; further, the reference to members of his team by name displays that his work was meaningful and personal.

Throughout the essay, Christopher reveals his passion for forming and being a part of a community as both a goal in itself and as a way to achieve success for the team. This is a point he elaborates upon in his reference to "the bastard in your pocket," which he presents as an ideal that can be transformed into action in order to achieve examples of his volunteer work and cross-country success. An allusion to the words of his cross-country coach, he uses this example to expand upon his views toward community and lived experience. He talks about both action and intention, emphasizing his own success in transforming beliefs and ideas into tangible results. The last paragraph in Christopher's essay serves as a succinct but powerful conclusion, one that links the kind of educational experience he seeks with his determined, goal-actualizing mentality.

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Laura's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2019)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2019/
Essay #: 3

Essay

I’m a bit of a grandma. I don't wear horn rimmed spectacles, nor perch on a rocking chair, and I certainly wish I carried hard candies in my backpack. However, I do enjoy baking: butter sizzling as it glides across heated metal like a canoe across a glassy lake; powdered sugar fluttering through the air like glitter from a confetti cannon. Some consider themselves math, literature, or history nerds. I rifle through cookbooks, browse the internet for ingenious new recipes, and revel in this year’s birthday gift: a copy of “Bread Illustrated.”

My greatest achievement in elementary school was not the perfect score on a spelling test, but the first time I mastered a batch of cookies that didn’t bear a rigidity comparable to steel. To my parents’ bewilderment, I dismissed Barbies, yo-yo’s, and jump ropes in favor of a wire whisk: It was love at first sight.

Why do I bake? Sometimes it’s to thank a friend or reconnect with former colleagues, employers, and teachers. Just as often, it’s the intricate processes involved. Creating the exacting liaison between eggs and flour to create a pâte à choux is, for me, a form of meditation. And sometimes I bake to reflect and even gain insight into my other interests.

Baking pastries for my next Junior Commission meeting, I ruminated on my interviews with officers and local homeless regarding their direct experiences with human trafficking in my own community. I recalled a police detective telling me, “For a youth isolated from family and friends, it doesn’t take much to accept the exploitation because he believes trafficking is his only chance of survival. I remember thinking, “Except that your body has to be sold like a box of cereal at Safeway?” This inspired my exhibit that was presented at high schools in my county, in which a figure, made up of barcodes, stands silhouetted against a black background.

Then there was the time my political interests literally gave me food for thought. As a Senate page, I welcomed Senators and staff back from their Independence Day recess with choux à la crème, that perfect French amalgam of wheat, egg, butter and air we call cream puffs. I had cherry-picked the ingredients from a local farmer’s market, because

local and organic is more than just a trend for me; it means contributing to the reduction of food miles and supporting small businesses rather than Big Agra. Ironically, activists that day chose to protest an aggressively lobbied pro-GMO bill by showering the Senate floor with dollar bills. Senators and staff brushed them off of their jackets while gingerly stepping around them to navigate the room.

But the elephant in the room wasn't the litter of currency, but the senators who paid more attention to corporate lobbyists than the protesters exposing their corruption. It deepened my perspective on how politics intersects our lives, farm to table. Yet, I've realized that when I feel empowered to advocate for a cause, I need to remember how the audience — legislators, for example — might view both my side and the opposing side. Sometimes they see us both as intruding groups. Other times, there are unseen advantages to acting in agreement with one side over the other or coming to a compromise.

If, as M.F.K Fisher said, "First we eat, then we do everything else," then baking is an avenue through which I have connected with people, causes and even intellectual pursuits. But the greatest gift that baking offers me is the responsibility to share. With this, I have realized an innate priority: to turn my talents, whether in the kitchen or an advocacy meeting, into tools to improve the welfare of others. My goal is to employ my compassion, intellect, and creativity into a career in public service. As much as I sometimes feel like a grandma, I also know a lot of grandmothers who happen to run our political system.

Professional Review by Transizion

Laura opens with a unique opening line, sure to catch the eye of an admissions officer. She proceeds to draw upon compelling and specific imagery, which grounds the reader in her life while adding authenticity and depth to her interest in baking. Referring to her first successful batch of cookies as a moment of pride in her childhood, Laura sets herself apart from peers who may have chosen to focus on other interests.

Through citing baking as a way to connect with others, Laura shows that she sees herself as part of a greater community — something which admissions officers appreciate seeing. Further, Laura sets the stage for an exploration of baking as a form of meditation, showcasing her thoughtful nature, as she writes that "creating the exact liaison between eggs and flour... is a form of meditation."

Writing that baking is a way to “gain insight into my other interests” is a segue into fleshing out her other interests — something which done poorly can read as artificial, but here naturally flows with the essay. We see Laura consider the less fortunate in her community as she bakes, showing rather than telling how she sees baking as a form of meditation. While the second to last paragraph walks the line between reciting a resume and maintaining the momentum of her story, the line "how politics intersects our lives, farm to table," clinches its greater point as a reflection on the impact of politics on everyone's daily lives.

Laura closes with a quote, a tactic which could read as artificial with a cliche choice. However, her quote speaks to the specific intersection of food and a greater purpose, elevating the themes of her essay. She concludes by connecting her passion for baking with the greater world, underscoring how her passion for baking unifies her mindset, compassion for others, and goals for the future.

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Marina's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2019)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2019/
Essay #: 4

Essay

My father said I didn't cry when I was born. Instead, I popped out of the womb with a furrowed brow, looking up at him almost accusatorially, as if to say "Who are you? What am I doing here?" While I can't speak to the biological accuracy of his story — How did I survive, then? How did I bring air into my lungs? — it's certainly true that I feel like I came preprogrammed with the compulsion to ask questions.

I received my first journal in preschool, probably because my parents were sick of cleaning my crayon drawings off my bedroom wall. Growing up, my notebooks became the places where I explored ideas through actions in addition to words. If the face I was sketching looked broody, I began to wonder what in her life made her that way. Was she a spy? Did she just come in from the cold? Graduating from crayons to markers to colored pencils, I layered color upon color, testing out the effects of different combinations, wondering why the layering of notes in music filled me with the very same happiness as the sight of the explosion of paired colors beneath my hands.

I began to take notes, on anything and everything. Reading Steve Martin's *Born Standing Up*, I took away lessons on presentations, of maintaining a rhythm and allowing crescendos of energy to release every so often. While watching a documentary on people preparing for a sommelier exam, I made note of the importance of an enriching environment where most everything points you to your goals. Flipping through my old journal, I see that even an article about trouble in the South China Sea inspired notes on precedent and maintaining tradition lest you provoke the unknown. I was looking for the rules of the world.

More than just a place to catalogue my observations about the world, my notebooks are places to synthesize, to course-correct, to pinpoint areas for iterative improvement. When the words are down on paper, I see my patterns of thought and the holes in my logic stark against the white page. If I have a day of insecurity that leads to a sudden rush of journaling characteristic of that in a teen movie, looking down at the angsty scribbles, I'll recognize my repeated thoughts and actions and look for pressure points in that system of behavior where I can improve.

Now my 2016 notebook returns to exploring the world through actions and experiments. Dozens of doughnut-shaped sketches dot pages that ask “how would you play tic-tac-toe on a torus?” Another page containing bubble letters answers the simpler question of the result of sorting these figures into groups of topological equivalences. Not two pages later are the results of a research binge on Mersenne primes that took me through perfect numbers and somehow deposited me at a Wikipedia page detailing the mathematical properties of the number 127. Once again, I look for the rules of the world.

Whenever I feel discouraged, I look to my stack of notebooks, shelved neatly by my desk. In those pages I’ve learned that I have room to fail and grow, to literally turn over a new leaf if a problem is particularly tricky. Through years of scribbling away, I’ve learned that the most fundamental part of my development has been giving myself the space to try: to sketch mangled faces, to draw the wrong conclusions, to answer a question incorrectly, and to learn from my mistakes without shame. I look to that mass of notebooks filled with my ideas, my mistakes, and my questions, and I'm reminded that I’ve grown before, and that I’ll grow again, all the while asking questions.

Professional Review by Madenberg College Consulting

Marina’s opening line catches readers' attention, although it’s not immediately clear how it relates to the theme until Marina's reflection on her initial anecdote shows, rather than tells, her predilection for asking questions. Marina stakes her interest in keeping notebooks through anecdotes relating even back to preschool. Although her imagery borders on purple prose, the momentum of the essay keeps the writing from dragging too much.

Marina tracks her shifts in mental framework — from initially gathering information to finally synthesizing and building upon her observations — as she flips through the pages of her notebooks. While the examples of notes taken, in paragraph three, walk the line between adding detail and being repetitive, they deepen the reader's understanding of her notebooks. We see her exhibit a growth mindset, as she notes that she uses her notebooks as a space to process thoughts and find areas for improvement.

The second-to-last paragraph also walks the line between deepening Marina's interests and adding redundant details. However, it broadens Marina's interests to not only cover pop culture and world events, but also math. This also exemplifies the paragraph's purpose, of the notebooks as a way to explore the world through experimentation.

Marina closes her essay on a positive, grounded note that brings the content of the essay one step further to show her mindset of iterative growth. With a closing sentence returning to "asking questions," she exhibits full-circle imagery which underscores the essay's theme.

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Aiden's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2019)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2019/
Essay #: 5

Essay

I am African-American, Caucasian, Jewish, and gay, and narrowly escaping the degradation of my ancestors: my great-great-great grandfather's slavery, my grandmother's persecution in the Holocaust, and the denial of gay identity. I am the personification of the culture and struggles of each of these groups. As I walk through life with this mix, I must be able to respect and love all different walks of life. Furthermore, during those times that I stereotype people, I assume roles onto their identity. I am able to stop myself and realize that they hold the wisdom from experiences that I do not, and that I am actually hurting myself. Judging a book by its cover really does make you miss out. Some people I know acknowledge me as the gay guy, a member of that small minority that is stricken with bullying and identity crisis, seldom as a Jew or black. It has always been important to me for people to recognize me by my radiant personality and not by my superficial sexuality or race. My ethnicity and orientation do not define me: they are the tools my ancestors have granted so that I can pursue my destiny, and I have my individual spirit to color my path. I am an independent, positive person.

I carry the mark of maturity with the essence of vitality. I can only hope that people remember me via my relationships with them and my effects on their lives. And so I apply the same mindset to others. The snappy, aggravated cashier at the grocery store checking me out may be working through her retirement to pay for her granddaughter's tuition. Or the black youth with his jeans hanging low and "speaking Ebonics" is actually executing a facet of his culture from which he takes pride and grows. Moreover my template also allows me to be open-minded; how could I not be cultural? My ancestors would not have succeeded without those that have listened and empathized with their plights. And how could I shut my ears? I cannot; I will not. I will not allow myself to shut out another's opinion simply because I was not introduced to their beliefs in my upbringing. How ignorant and arrogant to speak my gospel and thrive on the grace of others but not even consider others' words? Every breath I take is due to the grace of those magnanimous humans before me who not only listened to those Jews, or those slaves, or that gay person, but also took it upon themselves to advance humanity beyond close-mindedness into a world where every individual's contribution based on their experience is respected.

There is never a time to neglect the social fragility of our existence, not in the courtroom or the living room. To assume the serenity of social culture is a blind eye to the macrocosm of daily life. It is my expectation to persevere for the fight for human rights and to respect the nature of all cultures and all peoples through my actions as well as my words. It is insufficient to tell someone they are wrong for persecuting. We have to help them find no solace in their prejudice. Not only do I have a duty to argue for the progress of our humanity, I will do so by example.

Professional Review by Elite Educational Institute

In this essay, Aiden immediately captures the reader's attention with a blunt confession of his complex identity before delving more deeply into how his identity has shaped his outlook on life.

This essay emphasizes the importance of struggles and challenges the narrowness of identity. Perhaps the most poignant strength of Aiden's piece is its message: that superficial aspects of identity do not define a person; rather, one's identity affects how one pursues his or her destiny. One aspect which could have improved this essay is to break the thoughts into more than one paragraph as to give the reader a chance to breathe and pace him or herself. Despite this, Aiden's thoughts flow gracefully and logically throughout his writing, and the content pulls the reader in so it is barely noticeable that his essay functioned as one large paragraph.

Aiden shows his insightfulness and maturity both by acknowledging the strife his ancestors went through, but also by taking his acknowledgment and great respect for them and applying them to his own life. His writing is wise, powerful, and greatly moving, and the depth of his wisdom and maturity clearly impressed those who read it.

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Kevin's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2019)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2019/
Essay #: 6

Essay

I stood frozen in the produce aisle at ShopRite, wondering which of the five varieties of oranges to buy. Valencia, blood orange, organic, Florida navel – what were the differences? When I asked my mom which variety she was looking for, she responded curtly, “It’s your choice. Pick what you want.” The thing was, I didn’t know what I wanted.

For my parents, this level of freedom – even in the orange section of the grocery store — is somewhat unique to the United States. The lingering policies of the Cultural Revolution in 1970s China dictated life choices for my parents; growing up in poverty, their families’ sole concern was putting food on the table. As a result of economic disadvantage, higher education became my parents’ life goal. “If I didn’t make it to college,” my dad told me, “I would have been trapped in that godforsaken village for the rest of my life” (only one-tenth of his high school ever made it). My parents didn’t have a choice: my mom’s entire life revolved around studying, and my dad was spanked into shape at home. Sports, music, or entertainment were out of the question – my parents’ only option was to work hard and dream of a choice in America.

The miraculous thing is that my parents, having no freedom of choice for the better part of twenty years, still had the vision to grant me choice in the United States. Unfortunately, this is not common, even in our beloved land of opportunity. All I have to do is talk to my closest childhood friends - children of other Asian-American immigrants – to see the glass walls that cultural and familial expectation have erected around their lives. For some of them, playing the piano is an obligation, not a hobby, and medical school is the only career option.

Oddly enough, I had always felt a bit left out when I was younger – why weren’t my parents signing me up for American Math Competitions and middle school summer research programs, when all my friends were doing them? I’ve come to realize, though, that having the choice to do the things I’m interested in brings out an enthusiasm I can explore passionately and fully. My many hobbies – playing soccer with our neighbor in my backyard, fiddling around with Mendelssohn on my violin, or even talking to my

friend about our latest stock picks – all have come from me, and I'm forever grateful to my parents for that.

The contrast between my parents' lives and mine is shocking. In the United States, I have so many paths available to me that I sometimes can't even choose. I don't even know what kind of oranges to buy, yet oranges – or any other fruit - were precious delicacies to my dad as a child. I can dream of attending a school like Harvard and studying whatever I want, whether it be math, economics, or even philosophy or biochemistry – a non-existent choice for my parents, who were assigned majors by their universities. I can even dream of becoming an entrepreneur, which I see as exploration and self-destiny in its purest form. I can be sure that wherever my true passions take me, my parents will support the choices that I make, as they have for seventeen years.

Most importantly, though, I value that Harvard, with its centuries-long devotion to educating the full person, fosters the same sense of choice for its students that I have come to so deeply appreciate in my parents. I am exhilarated to have the freedom to define my own academic journey and, looking forward, for this upcoming four-year odyssey to lay the groundwork for a lifetime of exploration. For me, thankfully, it's all possible - but only because of the sacrifice and vision of my parents.

Professional Review by Elite Educational Institute

Kevin begins his essay with an anecdote, a tried and true method of grabbing readers' attention. Through the colorful imagery of choosing oranges in the store, Kevin begins to construct a theme of self-direction.

References to his parents' past show Kevin's appreciation for their struggles as well as his broader awareness of global issues. This contextualizes not only his application, but also his mindset. We see Kevin reflect on his childhood, his initial mental perturbation about not being like other children finally reconciled with his understanding of his unique opportunity. Kevin further shows his self-awareness of his freedom to pursue his own interests — a strong choice, as many colleges desire intellectually curious students.

Kevin closes his essay with a return to his anecdote about choosing images in the store, a full-circle imagery method which helps to underscore his essay's theme. He makes clear that he would make the most of his college education, and just as importantly, that he appreciates the values of the school to which he's applying. Kevin ends his essay on an uplifting, mature note, reflecting what kind of student he would be on campus.

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Julia's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2019)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2019/
Essay #: 7

Essay

I was in 9th grade the first time I stumbled upon a copy of Newsweek. What caught my eye was its trademark title: white type, red highlight, a connotation that stories of great consequence lay beneath. Such bold lettering gave me a moment's pause, and I was prompted to leaf through its glossy pages.

To my surprise, I was instantly hooked.

A new world unfolded before me. Biting social commentary. World conflicts that weren't dumbed down. Piquant reviews of best-selling books, controversial exposés of political figures, tantalizing tidbits on pop culture, full-page spreads of photographs.

And the prose was elegant, sharp, mesmerizing. It radiated sophistication and IQ. As I scanned the credentials of the authors, my only thought was, wow. The articles were written by worldly, ambitious people who were experts in their fields, people with PhDs and MBAS from world-class institutions, people who could write brilliantly, who got paid to give their opinions, who walked with a purpose and ran in the direction of their dreams. People I knew — then and there — I'd like to one day become.

This is what education looks like, I told myself. I was young, I was impressionable. Like a child standing on the outside of a candy store, nose pressed against the glass, I hungered to be a part of that cerebral adult world. So I read that magazine from cover to cover. Twice. And with each turn of the page I felt my small-town naïveté break into smaller and smaller pieces. I remember that day as an incredibly humbling experience. I had an awkward, self-conscious epiphany: that I actually knew next to nothing about the world. There I was, cream of the crop of my middle school, fourteen years of "smart" outwitted by a thin volume of paper. I was used to feeling gifted, to getting gold stickers and good grades, to acing every elementary examination placed in front of my cocky #2 pencil.

I wasn't used to feeling like I'd been living in the Dark Ages.

At the same time, however, I struggled with another realization, one that was difficult for me to define. I felt. . . liberated. I felt as though I had taken a breath of fresh air and found

it to be bracing and delicious, like it was the first breath I'd ever taken, and I'd never known that air was so sweet.

Talk about a paradigm shift: somehow, reading Newsweek had re-kindled my natural intellectual curiosity; it had, briefly, filled a hole in my soul that I didn't know existed. It had also sparked something within me-a hint of defiance, a refusal to accept complacency. One taste of forbidden fruit, and I knew I could never go back.

Although reading a news magazine seemed like a nonevent at the time, in retrospect it was one of the defining moments of my adolescence. That seemingly unextraordinary day set a lot of subsequent days in motion-days when I would push my limitations, jump a little higher, venture out of my comfort zone and into unfamiliar territory, days when I would fail over and over again only to succeed when I least expected it, days when I would build my dreams from scratch, watch them fall down, then build them back up again, and before I knew it, the days bled into years, and this was my life.

At 14, I'd caught a glimpse of where the bar was set. It always seemed astronomically high, until it became just out of my grasp.

Sadly, Newsweek magazine went out of print on January 1, 2013. Odd as it may sound, I'll always be indebted to an out-of-print magazine for helping me become the person I am today.

Professional Review by Karan Gupta Consulting

Julia’s strongest skill here is her powerful language and poetic use of metaphors. One of the highlights of the essay is her description of how reading Newsweek humbled her, remarking that she was used to feeling "gifted" but now felt like she had been living in the Dark Ages. Her answer of the prompt is spot-on, expressing precisely how the experience marked a transition from childhood to adulthood.

Julia could have elaborated on why being interested in Newsweek was such a surprise for her. She also could have chosen a more reflective and thoughtful conclusion to end an otherwise very strong piece of writing. There is definitely an irony between what was at the time an "out-of-print magazine" and her "natural intellectual curiosity" that could have been teased out further.

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Reginald's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2019)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2019/
Essay #: 8

Essay

As the first texts came in — “Where are you? The game’s over.” — I grinned, my feet propped up against the trunk and my back relaxed along the incline of the thickest arm of the tree. I swung off the branch and clambered down. The satisfaction on my face a little too apparent, I walked back to my friends, who sat out of sight on a swing set. The competition of the night was manhunt, a combination of hide-and-seek and tag renamed to suit the “dignity” of kids our age.

As I approached the swings, Marc called out, “You won. Where’d you hide?” “That tree over there,” I replied. “You climbed a tree?” Jack laughed, the surprise clear on his face. As manhunt novices, we had previously confined our gameplay to the ground. They were intrigued, recognizing I had taken our sport to new heights, literally.

As absurd as perching on a tree may be, there’s an undeniable thrill to discovering a new hiding spot and changing the game. In that way, manhunt simultaneously fuels my desire to innovate and my love of competition — passions I transfer from my musical, academic, and athletic pursuits to the boundaries of Jack’s backyard.

I search for new perspectives, new trees to climb, in all my endeavors. When I improvise in jazz band, I enjoy sharing original musical riffs and runs. My bandmates and I persist in the hunt for a “perfect solo.” While we know there's no such thing, we look for the next moment of musical insight that will change the complexion of our improvisation. And though we improve as a group, each of us takes pride in our own unique, musical style. The challenge of blending these varying shades of jazz into a cohesive performance is the reason I love being a part of the band.

The classroom brings new perspectives as well. Each day’s lesson engages my curiosity as I consider the world from a different physical, historical, or political point of view. It’s the excitement in my Physics teacher’s voice as he tells us that lightning strikes from the ground up and that Zeus is a lie, or the tightly bound silence in the room as a classmate reads aloud a letter home from an American soldier in Vietnam, that captures my interest.

My competitive drive, meanwhile, kicks in whenever I hear a countdown, whether it's the measure before a jazz solo or the seconds before a sailing race. When I'm out on the water, the urgent beep of my watch preceding the start refocuses my attention to the wind and waves before me. I envision the race ahead, visualizing the changes in wind patterns and the movement of the fleet of boats. When the pounding of my heart drowns out my thoughts and I fall into the rhythm of maneuvering the boat, that's when I know I'm at my competitive peak.

Similarly, my drive comes to life during soccer games, when a desire to win embodied in a slide tackle is all that defends our net. Though the steely looks in my opponents' eyes and the chants from the stands threaten to distract me, my ambition and pride in representing my high school harden my nerves on the game field and fuel my resolve in practice.

As much as I love to compete and innovate, the thrill of achievement is matched by the camaraderie among the friends, bandmates, and teammates with whom I share the journey. The determination to push my limits and reach for the next branch is at the root of my athletic ambitions and musical interests, but the personal relationships and shared experiences along the way make the process all the more rewarding. Even in a casual game of hide-and-seek and tag, I compete, innovate, and develop lasting bonds and memories that make a good-natured competition more than a zero-sum game. That's what delivers the real joy of manhunt.

Professional Review by Focus Admissions

Opening in the middle of the action with incoming texts and the imagery "my feet propped up against the trunk and my back relaxed along the incline of the thickest arm of the tree," Reginald immediately grounds the reader in his surroundings. The writing has a clear voice, lighthearted yet confident, exemplified through its easy rhythm.

Reginald's choice of details to set the stage — grinning, clambering down the tree, and explaining manhunt in a tongue-in-cheek manner — serves doubly as a portrait of his personality. Reginald shows, not tells, his innovative nature through recounting how he won a game of manhunt. As his opening anecdote has completed its purpose of humanizing Reginald, he connects the values inherent to the game to his broader interests in "musical, academic, and athletic pursuits." Tales of improvising jazz not only reflect Reginald's appreciation for the arts, but also his ability to collaborate with others and appreciate others' hard work.

The details in his paragraph on his academic curiosity add a layer of authenticity, strengthening his essay more than a simple statement of his curiosity. Similarly, because the imagery in Reginald's discussions of sailing and soccer captures readers' attention, we can be sure that it is a deep interest of Reginald's which he is pursuing for far more than just another accolade to add to his resume.

To balance out his emphasis on competition, Reginald closes with appreciation for all of his friends and teammates. We see that his pursuit of competition stems from a desire for constant self-improvement. Returning to the imagery of hide-and-seek, Reginald lands his full-circle theme.

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Valerie's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2019)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2019/
Essay #: 9

Essay

Languages have played a central role in my life. I have studied a variety of languages, to varying degrees — but always in the name of my greater goal, which is to understand people — to truly comprehend what lies beneath the surface: How does a culture conceive of itself? what can we learn about how the Japanese based on formality of address? What can be said about the Germans, whose language requires the verb appear at the end of a sentence? Maybe not much, but without the knowledge of the language, the possibility of real understanding is impaired. My interest in linguistics — psychology as well — derives from this belief: there is an underlying structure to all language, and through the study and comprehension of this structure, there can be a mutual understanding.

Beyond the underlying structure, words themselves have a deep and rich history, and their usage is a form of beauty in itself. It was my father who opened my eye to this truth — who taught me to love words for their stories and to appreciate etymology. It began as a friendly contest between us, but for me, appreciation soon became full-fledged adoration that was only encouraged by my study of Latin. I began drawing connections I had previously missed between words I use every day, and I found myself spending hours in front of the computer looking for sites to aid me in my discoveries. One of my favorite discoveries (and an apt one to share with you) is the word hedera.

I happened upon hedera when I noticed the similarity among the words apprehend, aprender, and apprendre, in Spanish and French, respectively. It was clear, judging by the orthography and definitions, that these words shared a Latin root, but in my studies, never had I come across such a word. Next thing I knew, I had the following on my hands: apprentice, comprehend, prehensile, apprehensive. What relationship exists between one who is learning a trade and a sense of foreboding? The answer lay within the etymologies, which led to hedera, the Latin word for ivy. Once suffixes had been stripped away, the remaining word was always -hendere. Alone, the word means virtually nothing; it was contrived from hedera as a verb form to convey a sense of grasping. What better to do so than ivy, a plant known for its tenacity? I could not help but admire the ivy which had embedded itself into the foundations of language.

Language is all about meaning and understanding, but to grasp the true meaning of language, one must look beyond the surface of the sentence to the structure, and even beyond that to the meaning and histories of the words themselves. Language, therefore, is my passion because it is the study of understanding.

Professional Review by LifeLaunchr

The strength of Valerie's essay lies, unsurprisingly, in her adept use of language to string together sentences as well written as they are communicative. Valerie's writing is uncharacteristically advanced for her age: It is free of the attempts at poetic flourish that often appear in personal statements and manages to showcase her extensive vocabulary without using ten-dollar words. As Valerie's puts forward, words and language are the tools she commands best; her essay is proof of this.

As for its content, this essay successfully exhibits its author's intellectual curiosity by parsing through the reasons why she loves linguistics and then demonstrating her learning process by parsing an actual word. And yet, this exercise causes the writer to stray from her initial discussion of how linguistics helps her better understand cultures and people, a wildly intriguing concept that ultimately doesn't get much airtime here.

Beyond that, this essay could exhibit more about its author as an individual. Though Valerie's alludes to a playful relationship with her father, this is all we get in the way of a glimpse into her personality. At 475 words, this essay is well under the 650-word limit. A more colorful introduction, some insight into how Valerie's love of linguistics shapes her interactions with others, or a more personal conclusion could liven up what is already a sound argument for the writer's keen intellect.

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Samantha's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2019)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2019/
Essay #: 10

Essay

Language is not the sole domain of humans. Animals also talk, and over the last few years I have been fascinated by learning two new languages that even foreign language school students have never heard of. Studying animal languages is very different from learning Korean, Chinese, or Spanish. There are always dictionaries to refer to when I learn human languages, but when learning animal languages I don't have a Google translator to spit out satisfactory answers. In fact, I have to use my own judgment, which combines my mind, heart, and instinct to interpret what I hear.

Tree frogs, specifically Japanese tree frogs and Suweon tree frogs, use songs not just to express their amorous intentions but to survive. While these two species may look physically identical, they are sexually incompatible. So in order to lure the right female, male frogs sing serenades that are distinguishable from other species. Analyzing these serenades at an ecology lab with spectrograms and waveforms, I decoded every pulse of sounds emitted by these ravenous tree frogs into the patterns of numbers to let humans understand their lyrics.

Unlike frogs' mating songs, bats use language not only to communicate but also to navigate and locate insects at night. While flying, bats shoot out biosonar sounds and listen to the echoes that bounce off obstacles to grasp the world around them. Visualizing a world just with sound, I was enchanted by their invisible language when I studied the Greater Horseshoe bat's supersonic echolocation at a wildlife conservation lab. When bats cast nets of invisible words every millisecond during free flight and ziplining experiments, we captured and revealed their dialogue that had neither conjugations nor grammar.

After eavesdropping on tree frogs' and bats' conversations, I discovered that they use languages for survival. The language of the frogs exemplifies power — the stronger and bigger a frog is, the louder it can sing, scaring off all its prey and bravely exposing itself to predators. And for bats, their invisible language is their vision. They silently scream out for help and listen carefully as nature's echoes guide their path. In a sense, animals communicate with other species and with nature.

On the other hand, humans have developed esoteric words, convoluted sentences, and dialects to express their sophisticated ideas and feelings. This amazing evolution has, I believe, isolated us from nature. Now we prefer to live away from wildlife, tending to communicate only among other Homo sapiens sapiens through texts, tweets, and e-mails. Taking a page from Dr. Dolittle's pocket diction, I hope that my work helps us broaden our anthropocentric minds and understand animals who also share our biosphere. If our souls are reconnected with nature, maybe we could hear Mother Nature whisper some secrets about her mysteries that we are too wired or unaware to heed.

Early explorers boldly left the comforts of their homeland to learn the languages and traditions of other cultures. Due to their dedication, these self-taught bilinguals were able to bridge cultures and share values between different communities. In the same way, I want to take risks in learning to communicate with other species beyond human beings and become a multilingual biologist who connects human and animal realms. I wish to venture into the animal kingdom and become a pioneer in mastering and sharing nature's occult dialects with our species. When we finally learn to comprehend and harmonize with nature, we humans might become more humane.

Professional Review by Capital College Consulting

Describing her study of animal languages was likely quite difficult for Samantha express through other components of her application. Her essay brings to light this extremely unique academic interest while also depicting the relations and insight she draws between animal and human language.

Because it isn't a good idea to scholastically ramble in a college essay, Samantha instead weaves a story with a mixture of academic knowledge and self-reflection. Additionally, instead of writing about her interest in science or biology, she writes about a very specific scientific niche in which academic context is needed; similarly, she focused on providing just as much insight about the topic as she did about the academic details of the topic itself.

Samantha’s powerful and articulate description of her interest captivates the reader. Her framing of animal language in humanistic terms, such as when she talks about bats' languages in terms of "conjunctions and grammar," makes the essay exceptional. She develops this comparison further near the end of the essay when she presents her insight about the disconnect between humans and animals and her future desires to reconnect the two. While the unique topic in itself was likely to grasp the audience's attention,

Samantha's expressive reflections and explicit desire to continue studying the topic mesmerizes the reader even further.

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Successful Harvard College Essays (2018)

8 essays

Jeremy's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2018)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2018/
Essay #: 1

Essay

Two hundred and two Hot Wheels cars, each two by five inches long, adorned with flames and spoilers, lined the edges of my room. My mother would urge me to put them away and go play outside, but I never wanted to. I drove those cars all around the house. They intrigued my six-year-old self. I loved my collection that I had hand picked on my own. Every single one of those 99-cent cars was *mine*. I never fathomed, however, that it would not take nearly as long for that collection to disappear as it took to grow. After July 6, 2006, I never saw my collection again.

On that day, I squinted to get one last glance at the front door of my home. 50 Greenridge Way was a quaint, two-story home in a quiet suburb of Rockland County, New York. My mother was six months pregnant with me when my parents signed the papers in 1997. They were proud of themselves—they had something that was theirs. My mother and father were determined to achieve the American Dream. They saved up for their baby grand piano, and they worked hard so that my sister and I could paint our rooms pink and blue like the ones on the cover of PB Teen. They did not know, however, how fast what they attained could disappear. The unanticipated vicissitudes of owning a small business left my parents struggling to pay the mortgage, unable to feed the rapid growth of their dream. They desperately reached out for help and fell victim to a mortgage scam. Legally outsmarted and outspent, my family continued to struggle until we could no longer fight. After thousands of dollars of debt, countless phone calls, and many tears, we lost the battle. On July 6, 2006, we were told we had six hours to get out.

Six hours. *Six* hours to get out of something filled with *nine* years of work, a lot of money and an immeasurable amount of emotion—six hours to pack up our lives and move them somewhere else. Day laborers were instructed to come and throw our belongings onto the front lawn. Family and neighbors flocked over, all agreeing to store as much as they could. I scrambled to find the things important to me. I threw my blankie, my Gameboy and my Build-A-Bear into a small duffle bag. As I rushed into my aunt’s car, my eyes glued to the movers tossing my mom’s favorite Diego Rivera painting onto the street, I felt uneasy.

Many questions should have been going through my eight-year-old head, but only one did: where are my 202 cars?

For the next five years, my family was homeless. Many doors were slammed in our faces, and we were given the “one night maximum” package in many of our family members’ homes. However, the takeaway from this experience is not what I learned about the behavior of others—it is what I learned about character. The values that cannot be touched—my experience, resilience, and faith—built more character in me than any two by five inch car or baby grand piano ever will. Losing every single one of our belongings by theft and storage unit auctions, including my 202 cars, showed my family that the intangible things that got us through hardship are everlasting. The six horus spent leaving our home felt so remarkably unequivalent to the nine years we spent enriching it, or the 8 years I spent growing my car collection. However, those unexpected losses taught me that a loss of my possessions was not a loss of my character. Even in the hotels, cars, and basements, this experience showed me that no matter how little my family had, we would always have the privilege to hope.

My family has been pushed into brief bouts of homelessness since the incident, and may be facing our next bout in the coming days. Although I still worry about our financial status, a feeling of overwhelming faith creeps up my spine and deadens that anxiety. Our faith and tenacity will never be plundered like our possessions. My unseemingly unshakable phobia of losing “everything” again has diminished over the years because if I lose my possessions again, I know I will not be losing “everything.” The next chapter of my life will signal the beginning of newer, and perhaps tougher, challenges, but through all of the uncertainty and worry, I will be letting out a sigh of relief. None of our possessions, including that carefully constructed collection of two hundred and two cars, adorned with flames and spoilers, were the vehicles that drove my family through the five years of turmoil. *It was our intangibles that did. *

Professional Review by The Brain Domain

Homelessness is an incredibly powerful topic to write about. Jeremy approaches the subject with touching candor, detailing how his family lost their home in pursuit of the American Dream, and how he lost his beloved Hot Wheels collection.

But what makes this essay truly remarkable is not the topic; it’s the build up. Jeremy begins with descriptive imagery of his Hot Wheels and uses those cars as a motif throughout the essay. This essay could have easily opened with a line about how he is homeless, but it truly builds up to the moment he realized his family was being kicked out

of their home. We feel empathy for this family, and we feel deeply connected to the writer, because we are brought along for the ride

The strongest aspect of this essay is its seamless incorporation of the 202 Hot Wheels into the overall message of the essay. That message can come off a bit heavy-handed at times; the essay would have benefitted from more showing and less telling. But it is incredibly sincere, and the point is hammered home by the repeated use of the toy cars. By ending with the same image that opened the essay, the writer brings the story full circle, and the reader is left with a deep understanding of not only his hardship, but how he rose above that hardship.

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Ariel's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2018)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2018/
Essay #: 2

Essay

“Black Eyeliner Does Not Make You a Non-Conformist”

Several years ago, my mother told me I listen to “white people music.” And I suppose that’s true—rock ‘n’ roll tends to spring from the middle-class basements of young, white men. Though I did point out that its origins trace back to jazz musicians of the Harlem Renaissance. Also that one of the greatest guitarists of all time—dear Mr. Hendrix; may he rest in peace—was black.

My devotion to punk rock began in seventh grade, when Green Day’s “Boulevard of Broken Dreams” came up on my iTunes shuffle. I started to look into their other releases, eventually immersing myself into the complete punk discography. My mother, having grown up in a racially segregated New York, was more likely to listen to Stevie Wonder than Stevie Nicks. But, she must have figured, to each her own.

So while my compatriots indulged in the music of Taylor Swift, One Direction, and Lady Gaga, my tacky Hot Topic headphones blasted Green Day, Ramones, and The Clash. My young adolescent ears drank in the raw, chaotic beauty, an echo of the pain of the past. The thrashing, pulsating vitality of the instruments painted a picture, connecting me to the disillusioned kids who launched an epic movement of liberation some 40 years ago.

Punkers question authority. Aggressively contrarian, they advocate for the other side—the side that seemed smothered silent during the post-Vietnam era. They rejected established norms. They spoke out and weren’t afraid.

I had always felt different from my peers. In my girls’ prep school, the goal was to be blond and good at soccer. I was neither, which automatically deemed me “uncool.” I had a few close friends but never felt like I was part of a whole.

Then came the punk philosophy, for the outliers, for those who were different. That was something I could be part of.

Instead of trying to conform to my peers, I adopted an anti-conformist attitude. Much like the prematurely grey anti-hero of my favorite book, I sneered at all the “phonies” around

me. I resented anything popular. Uggs? Wouldn't buy them. Yoga pants? Never. Starbucks? Well, I could make a few concessions.

But I felt more cynical than liberated. I wasted so much energy on being different that I lost track of what actually made me happy. I insisted I didn't care what people thought of me, which was true. Yet if I base my actions almost solely on their behavior, how could I deny their influence?

Luckily, as I transitioned from a private school to a brand new public high school, I got to clean the slate. I bought yoga pants and found they were comfortable. I listened to a wider variety of music, even the kind that wasn't 100% hardcore punk. And I was happier.

I revised my punk philosophy: Do as you like—whether it fits into the "system" or not.

The Beatles's "Revolution" lyrics sum it up well:

You tell me it's the institution

Well, you know

You'd better free your mind instead

What I think Lennon was getting at is questioning everything does not entail opposing everything. Defiance for the sake of defiance is unproductive at best, destructive at worst.

I believe in life's greater Truths, like Love and Justice. These Truths are what should govern my actions—not what's popular and what isn't. Striving to act on these ideals has helped me stay true to myself, regardless of what's considered "conformist."

Perhaps I've failed the punk movement. We'll have to wait and see.

In the meantime, I'll do what makes me happy and change what doesn't. I'll wear Doc Martens instead of Uggs; I'll partake in a grande pumpkin spice latte; I'll watch Gossip Girl; I'll blare my favorite guitar solo over the speakers in my room.

And that's as punk as it gets.

Professional Review by The Brain Domain

Ariel's essay—a pitch-perfect portrait of coming-of-age malaise—shows that you don't need some monumental event or life-changing epiphany to craft a compelling narrative. Not much happens over the 647 words of this essay, but the soul is in the details: the nods to her mother, the subtle *Catcher in the Rye* allusion, the levity to be found in her unyielding fondness for lattes.

This essay follows a relatable and adaptable template: let's call it the "blind-but-now-I-see" script. Ariel opens the piece as a causeless rebel (rocking out to Green Day, granted), but blooms into a more nuanced being with a worldview of her own making. Importantly, the young heroine's quest is shown as much as told, with motifs like yoga pants and Uggs serving as markers of her growing maturity. The essay also showcases Ariel's mastery of cadence—making good use of the em-dash and colon—and her willingness to experiment with prose as she spells out her capital-T Truths. Though Ariel's story has been told and retold between the covers of countless young adult novels, she tells it with wit and warmth, portraying herself to admissions officers as a particularly self-aware, free-thinking applicant.

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Janice's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2018)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2018/
Essay #: 3

Essay

What is love? A promise at the altar? The soft kiss of water on parched lips? A flash of his shadowed gray eyes, or the tender caress of pink pigment on her cheekbones?

“I *love* those Jimmy Choos!”

“I just love the pasta salad at *La Madeleine*.”

“Love you!”

“Love ya more!”

Love. For a word describing such a powerful emotion, it is *always* in the air. The word “love” has become so pervasive in everyday conversation that it hardly retains its roots in blazing passion and deep adoration. In fact, the word is thrown about so much that it becomes difficult to believe society isn’t just one huge, smitten party, with everyone holding hands and singing “Kumbaya.” In films, it’s the teenage boy’s grudging response to a doting mother. At school, it’s a habitual farewell between friends. But in my Chinese home, it’s never uttered.

Watching my grandmother lie unconscious on the hospital bed, waiting for her body to shut down, was excruciatingly painful. Her final quavering breaths formed a discordant rhythm with the steady beep of hospital equipment and the unsympathetic, tapping hands of the clock. That evening, I whispered—into unhearing ears—the first, and only, “I love you” I ever said to her, my rankling guilt haunting me relentlessly for weeks after her passing. My warm confession seemed anticlimactic, met with only the coldness of my surroundings—the blank room, impassive doctors, and empty silence. I struggled to understand why the “love” that so easily rolled off my tongue when bantering with friends dissipated from my vocabulary when I spoke to my family. Do Chinese people simply love *less* than Americans do?

As I look back on seventeen years growing up in my Chinese family, I don’t feel a gaping hole where “love” should be. I see my grandmother with her fluff of white hair, guiding my clumsy fingers as they grip the Chinese calligraphy brush, carefully dip *just enough*

ink onto its thick bristles, and slowly smooth the pigment over tan parchment to form wobbly Chinese characters. I taste the sweet watermelon brought to my room at 3 a.m. during finals week by a worried mother, and I hear the booming voice of my father begging me to get more sleep. I envision *baba*, dad, waiting in the 100 °F heat every day to pick me up from school, just to drive home in traffic-infested roads. My *mama*, mother, staying home from work to care for my cold, then feeling no resentment when she contracted it herself. My mistakes yielded stern, harsh lectures brimming with concern, while my tears assuaged *mama*'s irritation. I picture that arcane emotion imprinted in tacit smiles and hidden tears—shining from chests and unabashed pride. Within the realm of my memories, I discovered a truth that lessened my crushing regret at the loss of my grandmother: just because Chinese love, *ai*, can never render a fondness for Britney Spears' *Toxic* or be prostituted to mold description of delicious dishes, the emotion isn't any more absent, or any less profound. Knowing that I could possibly have shared with my grandmother an implicit love that neither of us chose to address vocally, I could loosen my selfish grip on her past and allow her to ascend into her future.

Although the alien expression "wo ai ni, *mama, baba*," would be met with a few awkward blinks and a "How much money do you need?" expression, I feel the fondness of my joking father like "[g]reat drums throbbing through the air [,]" and for my stern mother in "great pulsing tides[,]" as Countee Cullen articulates in *Heritage*. We Chinese aren't *limited* by the cultural and linguistic "love" barrier; we learn, through living together as a family, through our shared experiences, the sensation of true devotion and compassion, and, if that's not something Americans call *love*, then I don't know what "love" is.

Professional Review by The Brain Domain

Janice's nuanced take on the word "love" proves an effective window into her Chinese culture. Here, it turns from musings about love that leave the reader eagerly anticipating Janice's connection to the topic to a personal account of family and identity. Throughout the essay, she maintains an emotional authenticity that doesn't feel sappy, which can be a delicate line to tread. A core strength of the essay is the way it demonstrates personal growth. It shows Janice starting at a place of guilt for only professing her love to her grandmother once, and ends with her coming to terms with the ways that love is expressed differently in her family. Through the intimate details that Janice provides about her childhood—such as her mother caring for her when she was sick—the reader gets a genuine sense of who she is and where she comes from.

While the essay overall reads smoothly, it could benefit from the simplification of some phrases and sentences. Clarity is more important than ornate language. Finally, the quote in the last paragraph feels unnecessary. In such an eloquent and personal essay, turning to someone else's words seems out of place. Despite these minor weaknesses, Janice does an excellent job of writing an essay that demonstrates her insight, personal growth, and unique voice.

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Phillip's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2018)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2018/
Essay #: 4

Essay

The summer after my freshman year, I found myself in an old classroom holding a blue dry erase-marker, realizing what should have been obvious: I had no idea how to be a teacher. As an active speech and debate competitor, I was chosen as a volunteer instructor for an elementary public speaking camp hosted by my high school. For the first time, I would have the opportunity to experience the classroom from the other side of the teacher's desk. My responsibility was simple: in two weeks, take sixteen fifth graders and turn them into confident, persuasive speakers.

I walked into class the first morning, enthusiastically looking forward to the opportunity to share my knowledge, experiences, and stories. I was hoping for motivated kids, eager to learn, attentive to my every word.

Instead, I got Spencer, who thought class was a good time to train his basketball skills by tossing crumpled speeches into the trash can from afar. I got Monica, who refused to speak, and I got James, who didn't understand the difference between "voice projection" and "screaming." I got London, who enjoyed doodling on her desk with permanent marker, and I got Arnav, who thought I wouldn't notice him playing Angry Birds all day. The only questions I got were "When's lunch break?" and "Why are you giving us homework?" and the only time I got my students to raise their hands was when I asked "How many of you are only here because your parents forced you to?"

Just ten minutes into class, two things hit me: Spencer's crumpled paper ball, and the realization that teaching was *hard*.

When I was younger, I thought that a good teacher was one that gave high-fives after class. Later, of course, I knew it was far more complicated than that. I thought about teachers I admired and their memorable qualities. They were knowledgeable, enthusiastic, and inspiring. Their classes were always fun, and they always taught me something.

There was plenty I wanted to teach, from metaphors to logical fallacies. But most importantly, I wanted my students to enjoy public speaking, to love giving speeches as

much as I did. And that's when I realized the most important quality of my favorite teachers: passion. They loved their subject and passed that love on to their students. While it wouldn't be easy, I wanted to do the same.

Every day for two weeks, I searched for creative ways to inspire and teach my students. I helped London speak on her love for art; I had Arnav debate about cell phone policies in schools. And by the end of the camp, I realized that my sixteen students all saw me not as a high school student, but as a teacher. I took their questions, shared my enthusiasm, and by the time camp was over, they weren't just learning, but enjoying learning.

I was on the other side of the teacher's desk, but I hadn't stopped learning. Each day, I was learning how to communicate more effectively, how to deal with new challenges and circumstances, and how to be a better teacher. I once thought that being an adult meant knowing all the answers. But in reality, adults, even teachers, constantly have more to learn. I made the transition away from being a child during those weeks, but I did not and would not transition away from being a learner.

When class ended each afternoon, I would cap my blue dry-erase marker, give high-fives to the students as they walked out the door, and watch as their parents picked them up. I was confident that when my students were asked the inevitable questions of "Did you learn something today?" and "Did you have fun?" their answers would be a resounding yes. And even as their teacher, I learned and had fun too.

Professional Review by The Brain Domain

Phillip's choice of subject matter is carefully considered: he doesn't attempt to dazzle us with any flashy exploits or overwhelm us with the breadth and depth of his achievements. Instead, he chooses a simple success story, of his experience working with kids at a public speaking camp, that highlights his personal growth.

The story has a complete narrative arc, with a definite beginning, middle, and end. Phillip describes a distinct set of opinions that characterize each phase of his short teaching career, illustrated with colorful descriptions of typical moments for each. There are also certain symmetries between the beginning and end (the blue marker, for example) that leave the reader with a sense of finality and satisfaction. In addition, Phillip's voice throughout the story is phenomenal. His humor feels natural, and he's able to make the reader aware of his positive qualities without bragging or posturing; he shows them to us, through the story and through his subject, rather than loudly announcing them. His writing is confident and clear and doesn't distract at all from the content of the essay.

It's important to note that even though Phillip's story depicts a success, a good college essay need not end in triumph. If you try to create a victory where there isn't really one, you run the risk of sounding insincere. You have plenty of other places to list your accomplishments!

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Chad's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2018)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2018/
Essay #: 5

Essay

The man was a prodigy. He had performed for American presidents and even the Queen of England, every moment documented with autographed photos hanging in his guest bathroom. Even with a stature of 5 feet and change, his presence towered above me unforgivingly. His skeptical eye stared down at me as I struggled to balance my mom's iPhone on its makeshift tripod. A month earlier, the Pasadena Symphony-Pops had commissioned me to create a video featuring its debuting conductor, Michael Feinstein.

Now, the five-time Grammy nominee hunkered down on his piano bench, impatiently waiting for my command. With no professional equipment and little preparation beforehand, I had thrown together whatever I could find. A day before, I had taken pliers to bend a coat-hanger into a holder for the purple-cased iPhone 4. I even used a block of Post-Its to prop up a second-hand GoPro for another camera angle. Fumbling about, I felt like a child looking desperately for direction, almost expecting an adult to hand me a checklist—complete with the right questions to ask, directions to give, and instructions to complete. But I was on my own now. My "wing-it" approach to the shoot quickly became obvious, and Feinstein's skeptical reception grew into condescension as I stumbled painfully through the interview. The filming ended, and heavy doors swung shut behind the mansion as I was escorted out.

I had blown it. Academic rubrics and guidelines were straightforward—but here, being a straight-A student in the classroom held little value. For the first time, the Feinstein project had given me the opportunity to conduct my own show—but I had arrived without a baton. The MacGyver camera rigging wasn't the flaw; in fact, I think I pulled off the creative contraption decently well considering my lack of better resources. The real failure was my complete lack of preparation and absence of confident leadership. Yes, it would've been easy to write off Feinstein as arrogant—he certainly didn't serve me a generous helping of grace. He had envisioned a director with a camera crew—I was a 16-year-old amateur with my mom's iPhone. But looking back, I realized that Feinstein had given me a valuable gift: expecting more from me than what I expected from myself. Did I want to just be the teenager with a camera phone? The interview with Feinstein was humiliating,

but the experience forced me to decide if I wanted to be that director with his own camera crew.

I took action. As part of the commission, I had already negotiated for the PSA to pay for professional editing software, Final Cut Pro X and Motion 5. I had a vision of what I wanted, but I also had no idea how to use these programs to get there—I was just an amateur with no film experience beyond the occasional school project with iMovie. I dove head-first into editing, determined to not let my inexperience stop me. The process was brutal—I spent countless hours reading online manuals to solve frequent problems. But every frustration fueled determination. Over the course of 80 working hours, the video progressed from a barebones slideshow of images to a multi-faceted film with customized titles and transition animations. The completed production, though far from a masterpiece, gave me a sense of accomplishment knowing that my initial failure propelled me to work beyond my expectations and fulfill my own vision.

I was ready. Stepping back one last time to watch the finished video with my Pasadena Symphony-Pops clients, I no longer felt like the lost boy in the Feinstein mansion. And amidst the excitement and congratulations around me, I wished Michael would have been there too—to thank him for helping me set aside the iPhone and coat hanger, take the baton, and conduct my own show.

Professional Review by One2One College Consulting

Tackling perhaps one of the toughest prompts the Common App offers, Chad's essay details a memorable account of a time he encountered failure—and more importantly, the lessons he took from the experience. The essay prompt is difficult to attempt because applicants need to carefully balance their need to impress admissions officers (or at the very least, not scare them off) with their essay's need to tell a compelling story and avoid cliche. All the while, the essay must reveal something significant about its writer.

The personality Chad's essay reveals speaks a lot to his approach in attempting this essay. His reaction to failure and embarrassment is defiant resistance rather than quiet submission. The attitude he carries throughout the challenge, from his initial approach to his subsequent refusal to quit, is reflected in details of his writing too. The highly organized structure, signposted by declarative, no-nonsense statements ("I had blown it," "It took action," "I was ready") speak to this, as does the level of specificity to which he still remembers some details ("5 feet and change," "purple-cased iPhone 4").

With this being said, this essay could have benefitted from more direct insight into Chad's personality. Most of what readers understand is gleaned from details that may not fully capture the significance of this event to Chad.

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Margot's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2018)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2018/
Essay #: 6

Essay

It was five o'clock in the morning, and an intruder was in my home. His vile gurgling sounds had crawled into my room and slinked under my covers, and his deafening beeps had yanked me from sleep. I now lay frozen, listening intently for any other noises—footsteps, perhaps? The screams of my family members?—but the house fell silent.

Slowly, I slid out of bed and tiptoed into the dark hallway. The intruder was definitely near—his distinct, woody odor had infiltrated the air. And with each timid step toward the kitchen, upon reaching the door, I could hardly breathe. Ever so slowly, I pushed it open and scanned the room. There, gloating next to the fridge, sat "Mr. Coffee."

Twenty-four hours earlier, this machine was not here. Twenty-four hours earlier, I had risen from my sleep and ambled into the kitchen to brew a cup of joe not from a coffee maker, but from my family's old French press. It was a routine that jump-started every morning: grinding the oh-so-slightly toasted beans into an aromatic dust, blanketing the bottom of the glass vessel, listening to the kettle whistle on the stove, and then submerging the roast to create a bold espresso. After I filled a steaming mug, I'd be energized for the day—infused with caffeine and enthused with the artistic process.

But the press was now missing; its home invaded by this new contraption. Just as my eyes narrowed with suspicion, my yawning father meandered into the room.

"Hey… what is this?" I gestured to Mr. Coffee.

"Ah, yes!" he chimed, "That's our new coffee maker!"

"Oh."

My feeling of betrayal must have been palpable, because he raised his eyebrows sharply. "Is something wrong? Margot, come on—this is much more convenient than the old press."

The machine agreed with him; blinking its bright lights and humming haughtily. Then, as if to prove that it was indeed the most efficient appliance ever created, it once again began to pump out an endless flood of muddy liquid.

I deliberated. My father was right, of course—the French press was unarguably time consuming and cumbersome, especially at 5:00 AM—but it was tangible. It was real. Crafting coffee in the morning afforded me a sense of pride and artistry that always inspired the rest of my day. Every cup was a learning experience—fixing the flavors, tweaking the temperatures—but it was only now, after the press had been replaced, that I realized how much I truly appreciated it.

Our French Press is now long gone, but its memory is a constant reminder to apply meaningful effort and a creative touch to all of my endeavors. Whether doing research, coaching a swim practice, or simply playing Scrabble with my family, I invest myself completely. Yes, I may work a little slower, I might go over the top sometimes. But I don't want to live in a world where the familiar and cherished act of making coffee is replaced by the perfunctory push of a button.

Professional Review by CollegeMapper

The introduction of Margot's essay sets the stage for what promises to be a frightening account of a home invasion. In the opening paragraph, Margot has effectively conveyed a sense of fear without directly using words such as *scared* or *frightened*. She immerses the audience in a story by using sensory descriptions allowing them to fully engage with the narrative and imagine details for themselves.

Through the story of a coffee machine we learn of Margot's appreciation for fine details and methodical thinking process. The replacement of her French press with an automatic coffee machine is as scary to her as a home invasion because it represents the loss of an artistic practice which is an intrinsic part of her morning routine. More broadly, it can be taken to mean the loss of culture or craftsmanship as she generalizes this example to the rest of the world. Margot's appreciation of something so ordinary demonstrates a level of personal depth which cannot come across on a résumé.

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Bobby's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2018)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2018/
Essay #: 7

Essay

Bold white rafters ran overhead, bearing upon their great iron shoulders the weight of the skylight above. Late evening rays streamed through these sprawling glass panes, casting a gentle glow upon all that they graced—paper and canvases and paintbrushes alike. As day became night, the soft luminescence of the art studio gave way to a fluorescent glare, defining the clean rectilinear lines of Dillon Art Center against the encroaching darkness. It was a studio like no other. Modern. Sophisticated. Professional.

And it was clean and white and nice.

But it just wasn't *it*.

Because to me, there was only one "it," and "it" was a little less than two thousand miles west, an unassuming little office building located amidst a cluster of similarly unassuming little office buildings, distinguishable from one another on the outside only by the rusted numbers nailed to each door. Inside, crude photocopies of students' artwork plastered the once white walls. Those few openings in between the tapestry of art were dotted with grubby little handprints, repurposed by some overzealous young artist as another surface for creative expression. In the middle of the room lay two long tables, each covered with newspaper, upon which were scattered dried-up markers and lost erasers and bins of unwanted colored pencils. These were for the younger children. The older artists—myself included—sat around these tables with easels, in whatever space the limited confines of the studio allowed. The instructor sometimes talked, and we sometimes listened. Most of the time, though, it was just us—children, drawing and talking and laughing and sweating in the cluttered and overheated mess of an art studio.

No, it was not so clean and not so white and not so nice. But I have drawn—rather, lived—in this studio for most of my past ten years. I suppose this is strange, as the rest of my life can best be characterized by everything the studio is not: cleanliness and order and structure. But then again, the studio was like nothing else in my life, beyond anything in which I've ever felt comfortable or at ease.

Sure, I was frustrated at first. My carefully composed sketchbooks—the proportions just right, the contrast perfected, the whiteness of the background meticulously preserved—were often marred by the frenzied strokes of my instructor's charcoal as he tried to teach me not to draw accurately, but passionately. I hated it. But thus was the fundamental gap in my artistic understanding—the difference between the surface realities that I wanted to depict, and the profound though elusive truths of the human condition that art could explore. It was the difference between drawing a man's face and using abstraction to explore his soul.

And I can't tell you exactly when or why my attitude changed, but eventually my own lines began to unabashedly disregard the rules of depth or tonality to which I had once dutifully adhered, my fervor leaving in its wake black fingerprints and smudges where once had existed unsoiled whiteness. It was in this studio that I eventually made the leap into a new realm of art—a realm in which I was neither experienced nor comfortable. Apart from surface manifestations altogether, this realm was simultaneously one of austere simplicity and aesthetic intricacy, of departure from realism and immersion in reality, of intense emotion and uninhibited expression. It was the realm of lines that could tell stories, of colors and figures that meant nothing and everything.

Indeed, it was the realm of disorder and messy studios and true art—a place where I could express the world like I saw it, in colors and strokes unrestrained by expectations or rules; a place where I could find refuge in the contours of my own chaotic lines; a place that was neither beautiful nor ideal, but real.

No, it was not so clean and not so white and not so nice.

But then again, neither is art.

Professional Review by The Brain Domain

Perhaps the most prominent facet of Bobby’s essay is the use of imagery. It is first utilized to bring the reader into the piece and make the introduction pop, with “Late evening rays [...] casting a gentle glow” and “the soft luminescence of the art studio” becoming “a fluorescent glare.” Immediately, the reader knows what the essay will generally be about: art. Still, in the beginning of the essay, a lot of information is left out, leaving the reader begging for details to contextualize the mental images Bobby leaves them. Throughout the rest of the piece, Bobby’s use of imagery brings his essay to life, with “black fingerprints and smudges” and “unsoiled whiteness” being used to describe his art. He also uses imagery to illustrate the contrast between his organized, type A persona and the abstract

art he eventually creates. One such example is “the whiteness of the background” on his sketchbook being “meticulously preserved” but yet “marred by the frenzied strokes of my instructor's charcoal.”

Nevertheless, imagery alone does not provide the concrete, powerful narrative found in Bobby’s essay. One of the most powerful appeals of the essay is that it represents a coming-of-age story that echoes the Bildungsroman literary sub-genre, in which characters evolve psychologically from youth to adulthood during the story. Indeed, not only does this essay document Bobby’s development from child to young adult, but Bobby’s art also matures from something orderly and superficial to something abstract and deeply meaningful.

What separates Bobby’s essay from a well-written story, however, is the subtextual narrative it provides the reader. Though, on the surface, Bobby’s essay explores the contrast between the abstractness of his art and the order of rest of his life, it also mirrors the history of art itself. Just as Bobby the old artist had “the proportions just right, the contrast perfected” in his sketchbook, so too did the painters of the Renaissance work tirelessly to master perspective—to make art seem as realistic as possible. Just as Bobby the new artist’s “lines began to unabashedly disregard the rules of depth or tonality,” so too did art slowly—from the playful light of Monet’s Impressionism, to the square faces of Picasso’s Cubism and the complete abstraction of Pollock’s expressionism—care less and less about how realistic it was and more about the message it conveyed. In Bobby’s words, “It was the difference between drawing a man's face and using abstraction to explore his soul.”

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Jessica's Essay

Successful Harvard College Essays (2018)
Source: https://www.thecrimson.com/topic/sponsored-successful-harvard-essays-2018/
Essay #: 8

Essay

As a child raised on two continents, my life has been defined by the "What if...?" question. What if I had actually been born in the United States? What if my parents had not won that Green card? What if we had stayed in the USA and had not come back to Bulgaria? These are the questions whose answers I will never know (unless, of course, they invent a time machine by 2050).

"Born in Bulgaria, lived in California, currently lives in Bulgaria" is what I always write in the About Me section of an Internet profile. Hidden behind that short statement is my journey of discovering where I belong.

My parents moved to the United States when I was two years old. For the next four years it was my home country. I was an American. I fell in love with Dr. Seuss books and the PBS Kids TV channel, Twizzlers and pepperoni, Halloweens and Thanksgivings the yellow school bus and the "Good job!" stickers.

It took just one day for all of that to disappear. When my mother said "We are moving back to Bulgaria," I naively asked, "Is that a town or a state?"

Twenty hours later I was standing in the middle of an empty room, which itself was in the middle of an unknown country.

It was then that the "what if" — my newly imagined adversary—made its first appearance. It began to follow me on my way to school. It sat right behind me in class. No matter what I was doing, I could sense its ubiquitous presence.

The "what if" slowly took its time over the years. Just when it seemed to have faded away, it reappeared resuming its tormenting influence on me—a constant reminder of all that could have been. What if I had won that national competition in the United States? What if I joined a Florida tennis club? What if I became a part of an American non-governmental organization? Would I value my achievements more if I had continued riding that yellow school bus every morning?

But something—at first unforeseen and vastly unappreciated—gradually worked its way into my heart and mind loosening the tight grip of the "what if"—Bulgaria. I rediscovered my home country—hours spent in the library reading about Bulgaria's history spreading over fourteen centuries, days reading books and comparing the Glagolitic and Cyrillic scripts, years traveling to some of the most remote corners of my country. It was a cathartic experience and with it finally came the discovery and acceptance of who I am.

I no longer feel the need to decide where I belong. I am like a football fan that roots for both teams during the game. (If John Isner ever plays a tennis match against Grigor Dimitrov, I will definitely be like that fan.) Bulgaria and the USA are not mutually exclusive. Instead, they complement each other in me, whether it be through incorporating English words in my daily speech, eating my American pancakes with Bulgarian white brine cheese, or still having difficulty communicating through gestures (we Bulgarians are notoriously famous for shaking our heads side to side when we mean "yes" and nodding to mean "no).

As a child raised on two continents, my life will be defined by the "What…?" question. What have Bulgaria and the USA given me? What can I give them back? What does the future hold for me? This time, I will not need a time machine to find the answers I am seeking.

Professional Review by College Choice Counseling

Jessica's essay elaborates on key themes of identity as an American and Bulgarian, scholar and tennis player, and answers questions the reader will have about her extracurricular passions and motivations.

The essay is a variation on the classic college essay theme where a potential hardship becomes positive. Here, she tells the story of overcoming a life lived in constant contemplation of hypotheticals to one where duality not a source of confusion, but one that "complements" each other. Jessica's essay suggests that she has transcended distinction and demonstrates maturity with an ability to appreciate the quirks of both her American and Bulgarian identities.

Jessica's "rediscovery" of her home country serves as an opportunity for her to mention her interests and hobbies, providing context and narrative support for the extracurricular activities she probably lists on her application. Speaking about Bulgarian history, travels, and code switching, Jessica conveys a cultural awareness and keen observation of nuance in her essay.

Jessica's essay could have been used a bit more of thorough examination of how her "rediscovery" translated to her ultimate response to the "what if" question. It takes a distinct experience—splitting a childhood between two vastly different worlds—but doesn't go far enough in exploring the process behind her transformation to make her story of self-discovery truly substantive or original.

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